

starting out: the caro-kann

JOE GALLAGHER



EVERYMAN CHESS

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Introduction

Who Invented it?

The Caro-Kann is named after the European masters Horatio Caro and Marcus Kann. Of the two, Caro had the slightly more distinguished playing career, having participated in a number of strong tournaments around the year 1900. It would be fair to say, though, that if it wasn't for their contribution to opening theory their names would have sunk without trace in the annals of history. Individually, they are totally forgettable but together they have achieved great fame. As Raymond Keene put it, Caro and Kann have become as inseparable as Tweedledum and Tweedledee.

How Does it Start?

The opening is introduced by the moves 1 e4 c6 and has long been one of Black's major defences to 1 e4. The idea behind 1...c6 is simply to support the advance 2...d5. Now if White captures on d5 Black will be able to recapture with the pawn, maintaining an equal position in the centre. If Black had started with 1...d5 then this would not be possible and he would have to recapture with a piece. This (1...d5) is the slightly less respectable Scandinavian Defence (otherwise known as the Centre Counter).

Solid or Sharp?

In chess there are two distinct approaches to playing the opening with Black. The first is to try and negate White's advantage of moving first through careful, no-nonsense play. The second, more risky strategy is to counterattack at once, concentrating more on one's own ideas than on what White is doing. The Caro-Kann, with the exception of one or two sidelines, belongs firmly to the first group. It is an opening that should appeal to those who like a solid structure with relatively easy development and do not consider a draw with Black to be an unmiti-

gated disaster. This doesn't mean that the game will not become complicated, just that the onus is mainly on White to sharpen things up.

My Caro-Kann Credentials

I must admit there were a number of eyebrows raised in the chess community when they heard I was writing a book on the Caro-Kann. That is because I don't play the opening with Black and am a fully paid up member of the second group which believes in counter-attacking from the word go. Still, I feel reasonably well qualified to write a book on this opening. During my twenty years as a chess professional I have had to face the Caro-Kann on literally hundreds of occasions. I have never managed to find one line that has fully satisfied me and have chopped and changed, in the process accumulating a lot of experience in all the major variations. In addition, I got on quite personal terms with the opening when I covered it for the famous one volume opening's encyclopaedia *NCO* (Nunn's Chess Openings).

Is this Book Aimed at Black or White?

This book is not aimed at one side or another but is meant to be an objective overview of the whole opening. The book should be of obvious interest to anyone who plays the Caro-Kann with Black or to someone who is looking for a good solid variation against 1 e4. But what about those of you who play 1 e4 and just have to face it from time to time with White. Is there enough material to make it a worthwhile purchase for you? Well, that depends on your variation. If you just want to play one of the sidelines then the answer is probably no. Sneaking a quick look at the bookstall may well be sufficient. However, if you play (or are thinking of playing) the main lines with 3 Nc3 or 3 Nd2 then five of the ten chapters will be relevant. There is also plenty of material on the Advance variation (3 e5) and special coverage of the Fantasy Variation (3 f3) as that has long been one of my pet lines.

No doubt the coverage of the opening would have been slightly different if the book had been written by someone who has played the Caro-Kann all their life, but not too much should be read into the fact that White scores quite heavily in the Illustrative Games. The fact is that White tends to win the more attractive games while Black's wins are more likely to be long drawn out, less publishable affairs. The theoretical sections demonstrate that it is not easy for White to obtain a serious advantage against the Caro-Kann.

The 'Starting Out' Series

As can be gauged from the title this is not a book aimed at the master player who has played the Caro-Kann for many years and is looking for the latest novelty on move 20. For you it may still serve as a refresher course in basic Caro-Kann strategy, but the book is aimed

mainly at the inexperienced player or more experienced players whose knowledge of the Caro-Kann is limited. Heavy theoretical variations have been kept to a minimum and the emphasis placed on explaining the ideas behind the moves. When I have felt that long variations are essential (Chapter 7, for example) then I have tried to talk you through them.

Throughout the book important concepts have been highlighted by way of notes, tips and warnings. Another feature of the book is that each sub-section has one paragraph entitled 'Theoretical' and another 'Statistics'. Under 'Theoretical' we discuss whether it is necessary to burn the midnight oil learning variations or whether it is possible to get by on general principles. The statistics section is a useful guide to which side has been performing better in a variation, but no more than that. All the statistics have been taken from the 2002 MegaBase from ChessBase.

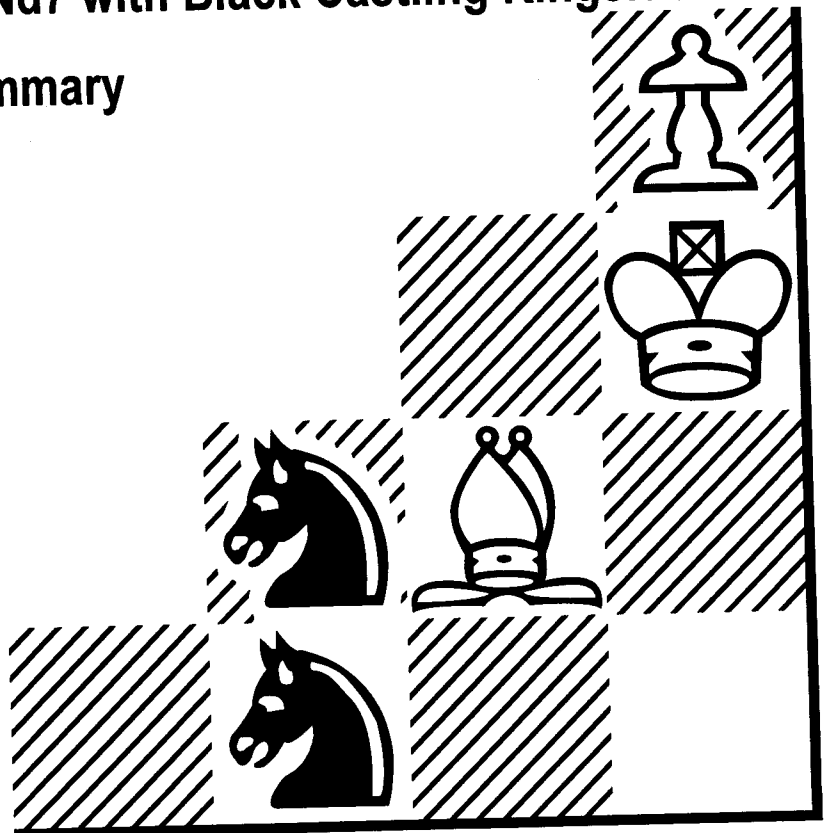
Have a good time in the Caro-Kann

Joe Gallagher,
Switzerland,
September 2002

Chapter One

Classical Variation 4...Bf5: The Old Main Line

- Introduction and Early Divergences
- 7...Nd7 with Black Castling Queenside
- 7...Nd7 with Black Castling Kingside
- Summary



Introduction and Early Deviations

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 (Diagram 1)

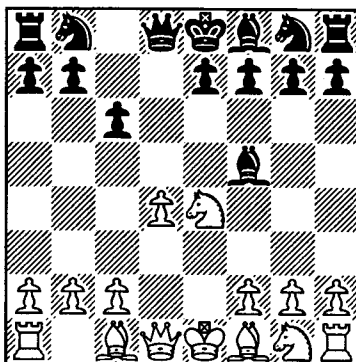


Diagram 1

The starting position for the Classical Variation

The Classical Caro-Kann, as the variation with 4...Bf5 is usually known, enjoys a reputation as one of the most rock-solid lines in chess. Although the variation has been spiced up a little in recent times, it is not played by those who are looking to win at all costs. It is primarily a variation which Black employs when he wants to avoid defeat, or a variation you can employ against an aggressive player who you feel may overpress. In fact the variation is so solid that many white players, including your author, have changed their repertoire after failing on countless occasions to breach its defences.

The Classical Caro-Kann has a great history. Many of the World Champions have employed it regularly – Capablanca, Botvinnik, Petrosian, Karpov, the young Kasparov and the old Tal – but others such as Fischer and Alekhine steered clear of it. It was not their territory. Anand, Bareev and Dreev are some of the modern day talents who use it.

Strategy

4...Bf5 is clearly a logical move. Black develops his bishop to its best diagonal with gain of tempo. One could hardly ask more of a move. Afterwards Black usually just develops as quickly as possible: ...Nd7, ...Ngf6, ...e7-e6, ...Be7 (or d6) and ...Qc7 are all typical moves, while he will usually need to play ...h7-h6 when White starts to harass his bishop on g6. Black can castle either side and he will be looking to free his position with ...c6-c5 at some point. On other occasions, especially when White has played c4, he may essay ...b5 in order to wrestle control of the d5-square from White. Black usually has a bit less

space but it is rare that his pieces become so congested that they have to fight each other for the same squares.

White will normally advance his h-pawn to gain space on the kingside and exchange off light squared bishops. This is because he usually castles queenside and if he leaves the bishop on h7 pointing towards his king he may live to regret it. White's main strategic aim is to establish a powerful knight on e5. Black will always be able to capture this piece but it usually means exchanging one disadvantage for another. One of White's other aims will be simply to avoid excessive simplification.

In this first section we shall be looking at some of the lesser-played lines after 4...Bf5. Afterwards we move on to the old main lines while in the next chapter we shall look at the modern and (slightly) more dynamic way of playing the variation for Black.

5 Ng3

As White has no good way to maintain his knight in the centre (5 Bd3 Qxd4) he has to move it. Occasionally 5 Nc5 is played and that is examined in Game 1. But on the vast majority of occasions White retreats to g3 in order to attack the bishop.

5...Bg6

Funnily enough, if Black overlooked the threat to his bishop and played 5...Nf6 then after 6 Nxf5 he would still be able to save himself with 6...Qa5+ and 7...Qxf5. Black players, however, prefer to keep their strong bishop.

6 Bc4

The main line is 6 h4 and that is the subject of the next section and the next chapter.

6 N1e2 received a thorough going over in the 1960 Tal-Botvinnik World Championship match.



TIP: Buy the book of this match. There are plenty of Caro-Kann's and Tal was a wonderful writer.

Tal's idea was to play Nf4, Bc4 and sacrifice a piece on e6 (and he did manage this on one occasion) but the variation has been neutralised by the continuation 6...Nf6 7 Nf4 e5!:

a) On 8 dxe5 Black should prefer 8...Qa5+ followed by 9...Qxe5 to exchanging queens on d1.

b) 8 Nxg6 hxg6 9 Be3 Nbd7 10 Qd2 exd4 11 Bxd4 Bc5 12 0-0-0 0-0 is about equal.

6...e6

Black can also play 6...Nf6 but this is likely to transpose back into the main line. He cannot get by without ...e7-e6.

7 N1e2

The reasons for this slightly odd-looking move are twofold:

1) White remains free to advance his f-pawn

2) White can play Nf4

7...Nf6

7...Bd6 is an important alternative move order designed to draw the sting out of the f4-f5 plan we see in the main line. For example, if White now continues with 8 0-0 Qc7 9 f4 then Black can play 9...Ne7, making it harder for White to play a successful f4-f5. After 7...Bd6 many White players give up on the idea of a quick f4-f5 and choose one of the following variations:

a) 8 h4 h6 9 Nf4 Bxf4 (Black didn't want to retreat his bishop to h7 as this would allow a white knight into h5) 10 Bxf4 Nf6. The bishop pair must give White a small advantage but Black is very solid and won't be easy to break down. I know from experience!

b) 8 Nf4 Qh4!? 9 Ngh5 Bxh5 and now 10 Nxh5 leads nowhere after 10...Nf6, as White loses his knight if he takes on g7, while 10 Qxh5 Qxh5 11 Nxh5 g6 12 Nf4 Nf6 may leave Black fractionally worse, but is hardly the sort of position to trouble a good solid Caro player. Even Kasparov got absolutely nowhere when he had this position against Topalov.

8 0-0 Bd6 9 f4 (Diagram 2)

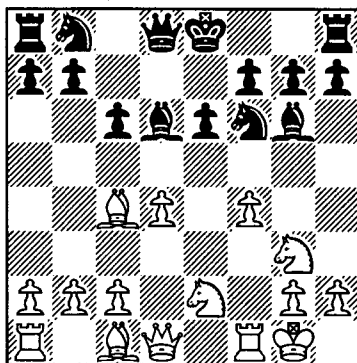


Diagram 2

White plans f4-f5

Now Black must prevent White from playing f4-f5. Two good methods are highlighted in Game 2.

The conclusion is that these lines don't cause Black too many problems.

Theoretical?

6 Bc4 is quite a popular sideline and well worth a little study. It's a bit sharper than the rest of this chapter and there are one or two

things Black will have to know (the dangers of allowing f4-f5, for example)

Statistics

White has scored an impressive 59% with 6 Bc4 (700 games) and this rises to 65% in the position after 9 f4 (135 games). Black players just don't know how to handle it. With 5 Nc5 White has scored 56% (330 games) but this can be knocked down a couple of points when we take into account the average ratings.

Game 1

□ McShane ■ Borbjerggaard

Stockholm 2002

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2

You will notice that sometimes White plays 3 Nc3 and sometimes 3 Nd2. The vast majority of the time it makes no difference after 3...dxe4 4 Nxe4. In Chapter 10 you will find a discussion on the differences between these moves when Black refrains from capturing on e4.

3...dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Nc5

The only real reason to play this move is to avoid theory. After something like 5...b6 6 Nb3 e6 7 Nf3 Bd6 8 g3 White has chances of a small opening advantage. Recently Black has started bringing things to a head much quicker.

5...Nd7!? 6 Nxb7

The first thing to point out is that White doesn't want to retreat his knight as he gets a similar position to the previous note except that Black has played the useful developing move ...Nd7 instead of the slightly weakening pawn move ...b6. That is obviously in his favour. The only real alternative to the text has been 6 Bd3, when Korchnoi, true to style, mixed things up with 6...Nxc5 7 Bxf5, but most players just prefer to take on d3 with a comfortable enough game.

When taking the pawn on b7 White understands that he won't be able to hang onto it, but he is hoping to gain some advantage by leaving Black with split pawns.

6...Qb6?!

Perhaps this is already a slight mistake as Black has to recapture with his queen on c5. If instead he had played 6...Qc7, then after 7 Nc5 Nxc5 8 dxc5 Rd8 9 Bd3 e5 White has to deal with the threat of ...e5-e4 so Black will have the time to take back on c5 with his bishop. This developing move should be preferable to taking back with the queen.

7 Nc5 Nxc5 8 dxc5 Qxc5 9 c3 Qb6

I don't really like this move as it simply encourages White to play Qb3 followed by Be3. The problem for Black is that an exchange on b3 will open the a-file for the white rook and his slight weaknesses on the

queenside will suddenly become glaring ones.

10 Nf3 g6 11 Qb3 Be6 12 Bc4 Qxb3?! 13 axb3 Bxc4 14 bxc4 (Diagram 3)

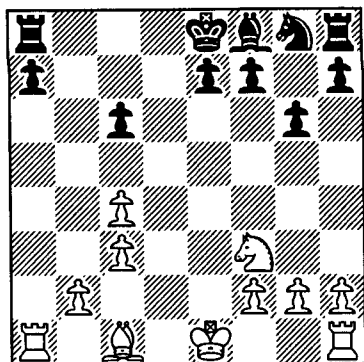


Diagram 3
White has a good ending

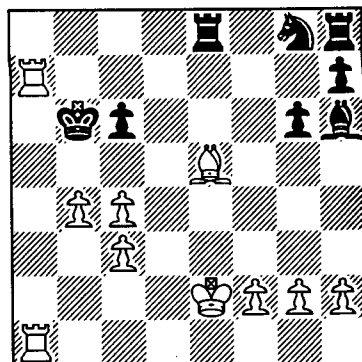


Diagram 4
Black's king is in a mating net

So here we are. Black has walked straight into an awful endgame with terrible queenside weaknesses.

14...Bg7 15 Ra6 Kd7 16 Bf4

Not bad, but 16 Ke2 and 16 Be3 also look very good and perhaps less complicated.

16...f6 17 Ke2 e5 18 Rd1+ Kc7 19 Rda1! Bh6

After 19...exf4 20 Rxa7+ Rxa7 21 Rxa7+ White will regain his piece with a winning position.

20 Bg3 Kb7

Black probably saw that 20...Ne7 is met by 21 Nxe5! and decided to set a trap. If White now takes on e5 he walks into a pin. England's youngest grandmaster fell for it.

21 Nxe5! fxe5 22 Bxe5 Re8 23 Rxa7+ Kb6

Or 23...Kc8 24 Ra8+

24 b4! 1-0 (Diagram 4)

But, of course, there was a sting in the tail. After 24...Rxe5+ 25 Kd3 White will soon be playing the move R1a6 mate!

Game 2

□ Genocchio ■ Serrer

Budapest 1999

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 Bc4 e6 7 N1e2 Nf6 8 0-0 Bd6 9 f4

This is certainly the most aggressive move at White's disposal and Black is well advised to prevent the pawn advancing any further.

9...Qd7

Some black players believe they can stop f4-f5 by 9...Qc7, as after 10 f5 exf5 11 Nxf5 they can play 11...Bxh2+. However, practice has shown that this line is very dangerous for Black. It seems better to make sure that White can't play f4-f5 rather than letting him play it at the cost of a pawn.

One move that definitely stops White's f-pawn in its tracks is 9...Bf5!?. This remarkable-looking move is played with the idea of transposing into a sort of Tartakower Defence (see Chapter 5) after 10 Nxf5 exf5. Black believes that he has a favourable version because the move f4 has weakened central squares such as e4 and rendered White's dark-squared bishop passive. White, however, does have some attacking ideas in this position. Firstly, he can prevent Black from castling by playing 11 Ng3 g6 12 Re1+, although this is only a minor inconvenience for Black as after 12...Kf8 the king is close to a perfectly good square on g7. A typical continuation now is 13 Qf3 h5 14 b3 Nbd7 15 Bb2 Qc7 16 Re5!?, when White will leave his rook there until it is taken. In return, his powerful centre will give him good compensation. Practice has so far been unable to establish who has the better chances in such positions.

10 Bd3

White threatens to play f4-f5 again.

10...Bxd3 11 Qxd3 g6

But finally Black stops it once and for all.

12 f5!? (Diagram 5)

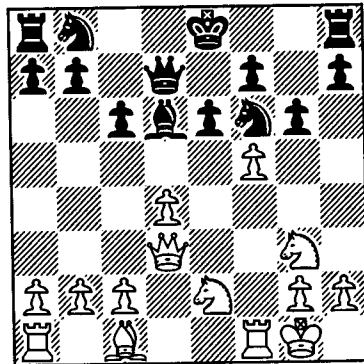


Diagram 5
White sacrifices

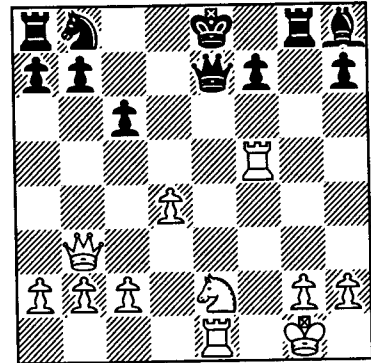


Diagram 6
The e-file spells trouble for Black

Or at least he thought he had. This pawn sacrifice has breathed new life into the line.

12...gxf5!

12...exf5? 13 Bg5 Be7 14 Rae1 Na6 15 Nxf5! gxf5 16 Ng3 Nb4 17 Qc4 0-0-0 18 Nxf5 b5 19 Qxf7 Bd6 20 Qxd7+ Rxd7 21 Bxf6 Rf8 22 Nxd6+ Rxd6 23 Be7 Rxf1+ 24 Rxf1 1-0 Fressinet-Mulder, French League 1999.

13 Bg5 Be7 14 Rae1 Rg8!

This is why Black has to take with the g-pawn as he now gains an important tempo by hitting the bishop. If instead he had played 14...Na6, then 15 Nxf5 exf5 has just transposed to the Fressinet game given above, a game that was particularly unpleasant for Black.

15 Bxf6

White players are still undecided between the text and 15 Bh4. Ideally he would like to keep his bishop and sacrifice later but the reply 15...Rg4 is a little annoying.

15...Bxf6 16 Nxf5!

Otherwise White has insufficient play for the pawn.

16...exf5 17 Rxf5 Bh8

This is better than 17...Bg7 as it doesn't obstruct the rook.

18 Qb3!

Immediate discovered checks don't lead anywhere so White targets the f7-square.

18...Qe7? (Diagram 6)

An incredibly naïve move. In the later game Genocchio-Solozhenkin, Reggio Emilia 2000, Black played the superior 18...Rg6! and after 19 Nf4+ Kf8 White should have taken the rook with an equal game.

19 Kf1!

Oh dear, Black really walked into that one! Now the rook is defended, White will be able to move his knight with devastating effect. Black now decided that he had nothing better than parting with his queen. After other moves he was liable to have to part with his king.

19...Nd7 20 Nf4 Qxe1+ 21 Kxe1 0-0-0 22 c3 f6 23 Qa3 Rge8+ 24 Kf2 Kc7 25 Rh5 Re4 26 g3 Nf8 27 Qa5+ Kc8 28 Qf5+ 1-0

7...Nd7 with Black Castling Queenside

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7

Until recently this move was thought to be obligatory in order to prevent White playing Ne5. As you can see, we now have a whole chapter on 7...Nf6, which has become the modern main line.

8 h5

Although it quickly became clear to White that he had to exchange off Black's dangerous bishop, it took some time to establish whether he should do so immediately (8 Bd3) or after 8 h5. Finally the theoreticians all agreed that the advantages of playing h4-h5 (it fixes the

black kingside and frees h4 for the rook) outweigh the disadvantage (the pawn can become weak). Nowadays 8 Bd3 is rarely seen.

8...Bh7 9 Bd3 (Diagram 7)

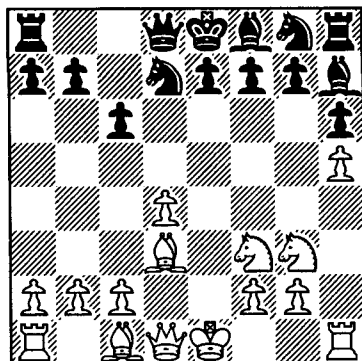


Diagram 7
White offers a trade

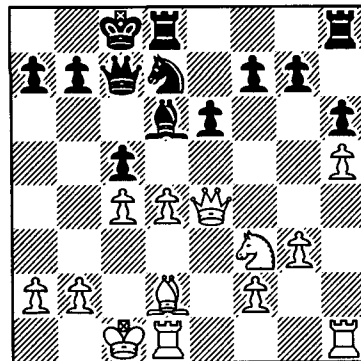


Diagram 8
White has a choice

9...Bxd3 10 Qxd3 Qc7

This signifies Black's intention to castle queenside. It would make no sense for Black to waste a tempo on ...Qc7 if he was going to castle kingside. Black can also play 10...e6 or 10...Ngf6 and, although these two moves give White the option of developing his bishop to f4, this does not trouble Black. The point is that after 10...e6 11 Bf4 Qa5+ White has nothing better than 12 Bd2 (after 12 c3 the black queen is well placed on a5), when Black replies 12...Qc7 transposing to the main line. The only difference is that the players have played one move more. For simplicity's sake I have always assumed that Black played 10...Qc7, although in many of the examples we meet below the queen first went to a5.



NOTE: To sum up, the moves 10...Qc7, 10...Ngf6 and 10...e6 are interchangeable if Black is going to castle queenside, but if he wants to remain flexible on the future home of his king, then 10...e6 and 10...Ngf6 are the better options.

All the lines where Black plays ...0-0 are considered in the next section.

11 Bd2

11 Rh4! is a move with which White has scored extremely well in practice. The main idea is to show Black that he can't prevent Bf4 if White really wants to play it. After 11...e6 12 Bf4 Black should settle for 12...Bd6. Then the endgame after 13 Bxd6 Qxd6 14 Ne4 Qe7 15 Qa3! Qxa3 16 bxa3 Ke7 is interesting, though probably no better for White.

11...e6 12 0-0-0 Ngf6 13 Ne4

The knight on g3, White's most passive piece, is brought back into play. Ideally White would prefer to avoid exchanges, but you can't have everything. There is one quite important alternative, namely 13 Qe2 – the idea is to prepare Ne5. After 13 Qe2 0-0-0 14 Ne5 Nb6 (14...Nxe5 15 dxe5 Nd7 16 f4 is pleasant for White) we have:

a) 15 c4!? Rxd4 16 Be3 Rxd1+ 17 Rxd1 is an interesting pawn sacrifice which according to theory is neutralised by 17...Rg8 18 f4 Kb8!. You really have to know your stuff to find these moves. You are probably wondering about the more obvious 17...Qxe5, which costs Black his queen after 18 Rd8+!, and 17...Bd6, which costs material after 18 Rxd6!.

b) The position after 15 Ba5 Rd5 (15...c5!?) 16 Bxb6 (certainly not 16 b4 Rxa5!) 16...axb6 17 c4 Ra5! 18 Kb1 Bd6 19 f4 Rd8 has been reached many times in chess practice (this line was especially popular back in the 1960s) with theoretical opinion oscillating between level and slightly better for White. Sounds about par for the course in the Caro-Kann.

13...0-0-0 14 g3!

This was introduced into tournament play by the Soviet star Efim Geller. At first it didn't really catch on but ever since the 1980s it has been established as the main line. The idea is simply to play Bf4.

14...Nxe4

Black can also exploit the pin on the d-file with 14...Nc5 but the commentators almost unanimously agree that White is better after 15 Nxc5 Bxc5 16 c4. White usually follows up with moves such as Bc3, Qe2 and Ne5, while Black just sits there waiting for White to over-extend. There was one active plan Black tried for a while which was based on playing ...Bd6 (more often the bishop drops back to b6), walking his king to the corner and then playing ...b7-b5. But then when someone got blown away by a d4-d5 break, most Black players went back to doing nothing.

15 Qxe4 Bd6

15...Nf6 looks so obvious but it is a move that many black players are reluctant to play. That is because the knight no longer covers the important e5-square so White is usually able to install a powerful knight there. Also, there are occasions when Black plays ...c7-c5 when it would be more useful to have the knight on d7 than f6. Still, there is one advantage in playing ...Nf6 immediately: the white queen can't retreat to c2 so Black can avoid the main line below where White meets ...c6-c5 with d4-d5.

After 15...Nf6 16 Qe2 Black should not play 16...c5 because after 17 dxc5 Bxc5 18 Rh4! the rook can cause a lot of trouble on the fourth rank. For example, in the famous game Tal-Hübner, Montreal 1979, the rook made Black nervous about having his king and queen on the same file so he played 18...Kb8, only to find himself in serious trouble on the diagonal after 19 Bf4 Bd6 20 Rxd6! Rxd6 21 Ne5! (with ideas of



Nc4 and Nxf7).

WARNING: Black must be careful about playing ...c6-c5 before White has played c4 in case there is a dangerous Rh4-c4 manoeuvre.

Instead of 16...c5 Black should play 16...Bd6, when both 17 Ne5 c5 18 Rh4 and Lautier's 17 Rh4 should be a little better for White. Alternatively, 17 c4 c5 18 Bc3 would transpose into Game 3.

16 c4 c5 (Diagram 8)

White now has two continuations:

- a) The solid 17 Bc3 is examined in Game 3. This has been the most popular line over the years but it seems to me that Black can equalise with the slightly unusual 17...cxd4 18 Nxd4 Nc5.
- b) 17 d5 is a sharper line where Black appears to be on the defensive at the moment – see Game 4

Theoretical?

One should be able to get by on general principles but of course knowing the theory will help to eliminate accidents. Even in the so-called quiet lines there are a lot of things happening just under the surface.

Statistics

In the lines where Black castles queenside in the Classical Caro-Kann, White has an overall score of 57%. Breaking it down a little further, after Geller's 14 g3 the White score rises to 60% (taken over a total of 800 games). This is surprisingly high but may be explained by the fact that White averaged a massive 30 Elo points higher per game.

Game 3

□ Antonio ■ Van der Sterren

Sydney 1989

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 h5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 Qc7 11 Bd2 e6 12 0-0-0 Ngf6 13 Ne4 0-0-0 14 g3 Nxe4 15 Qxe4 Bd6 16 c4 c5 17 Bc3 cxd4 (Diagram 9)

The position after 17...Nf6 18 Qe2 cxd4 (it's best for Black to take at once) 19 Nxd4 a6 has been reached on countless occasions. White only took with the knight on d4 to avoid the line 19 Bxd4 Qa5, so now he usually goes straight back to f3 – this knight belongs on e5. The game De Firmian-Miles, Biel 1989 was quite typical for this variation. After 20 Nf3 play continued 20...Rd7 21 Ne5 Bxe5 22 Bxe5 Qa5 23 a3 Rhd8 24 Rxd7 Nxd7 25 Bc3 Qg5+ 26 Qd2 Qxd2+ 27 Kxd2 f6 28 Kc2 and Black still had to suffer a bit more before reaching the sanctuary of a draw.

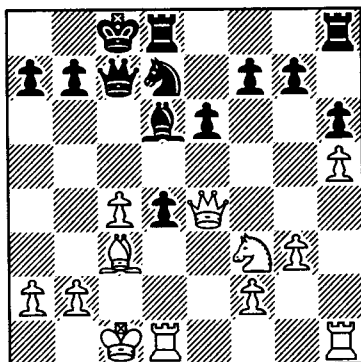


Diagram 9

White has a choice of recaptures

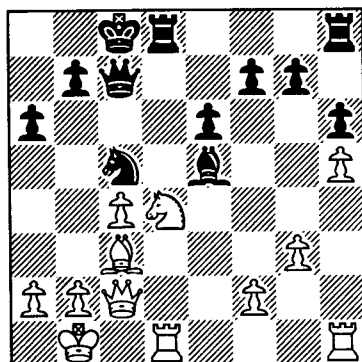


Diagram 10

Black contests the diagonal

18 Nxd4 Nc5!? 19 Qc2 a6

Black rules out Nb5.

20 Kb1

Against 20 Rhe1 the black bishop would still, as in the game, go to the long diagonal but this time via f6.

20 Nf3?! Qc6 21 Ne5?? was the disastrous plan White came up with in Kaiumov-Prakash, Udaipar 2000. After 21...Bxe5 22 Bxe5 Nd3+! 23 Rxd3 Qxh1+ he could have resigned.

20...Be5! (Diagram 10)

An important move which neutralises White's pressure on the long diagonal. It is surprising that this plan has not been played more often. The game is level. The remaining moves were

21 f4 Bf6 22 Rd2 Rd7 23 Rhd1 Rhd8 24 a3 Qb6 25 Ka2 e5 26 fxe5 Bxe5 27 g4 g6 28 hxg6 fxg6 29 b4 Na4! 30 Qxa4 Bxd4 31 Kb3 Qe6 32 Bxd4 Rxd4 33 Rxd4 Rxd4 34 Rxd4 Qe3+ 35 Kc2 Qxd4 36 Qe8+ Kc7 37 Qf7+ Kb8 38 Qe8+ Ka7 39 Qxg6 Qxc4+ with a draw (eventually) by perpetual check.

Game 4

□ Frolov ■ Volzhin

Samara 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 h5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 Qc7 11 Bd2 e6 12 0-0-0 Ngf6 13 Ne4 0-0-0 14 g3 Nxe4 15 Qxe4 Bd6 16 c4 c5 17 d5 (Diagram 11)

This looks the better try at the moment but I am reluctant to award the move an "!" as they have a habit of coming back to haunt chess writers.

17...Nf6

After 17...Rhe8!? most sources recommend 18 Bc3 but then 18...exd5 19 Qxd5 Be5! is fine for Black. 18 Qg4! looks more like it but further tests are required before any reliable conclusions can be drawn.

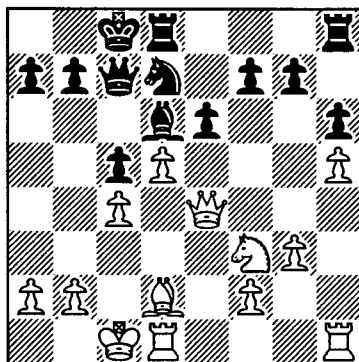


Diagram 11
An ambitious push

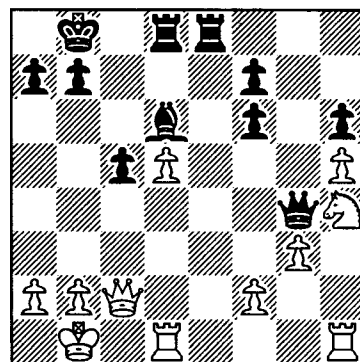


Diagram 12
An important moment

18 Qc2 exd5 19 cxd5 Rhe8

Of course, the tactic underpinning White's play is 19...Nxd5 20 Qf5+!, winning the knight.

20 Bc3 Qd7 21 Bxf6 gxf6

White now has a strategically won game so Black must rely on the dynamics of the position to keep him alive. For the moment Black still has hope because he occupies the open file and his queen is potentially active. If we picked up the white knight, though, and put it down again on f5 then White would be winning. That is his aim then, to transfer the knight to f5.

22 Kb1!?

One couldn't find such a move without delving deep into the position. A number of games have gone as follows: 22 Nh4 Re5! 23 f4 Rxe5 24 Qe2 Rxd5 25 Rxd5 Bxf4+ 26 gxf4 Qxd5 27 Rd1 Qxa2 (Adianto even played 27...Qxd1+!? 28 Qxd1 Rxd1+ 29 Kxd1 Kd7 recently and drew without difficulty; knights struggle against rook pawns) 28 Rxd8+ Kxd8 and the white king is too exposed for him to have serious winning chances.

Do you understand 22 Kb1 now? Some bright spark had the idea of playing the same variation as above but with the king on b1. That means ...Bxf4 will not be check and the rook will be lost for nothing.

22...Kb8

Black has also tried 22...f5 here but it didn't look very convincing.

23 Nh4 Qg4 (Diagram 12) 24 Qf5?

In this book long theoretical variations have been kept to a minimum,

but the following seems quite important as recent writers and annotators have just overlooked it. The game Golubev-Adianto, Lucerne 1994 went 24 Nf5! Qf3 25 Nxb6 Bf8 (25...Re2 will transpose to the line below) and now 26 Qf5! would have been just winning for White. Afterwards Golubev, in *Informator*, gave the following critical line: 24 Nf5 Re2 25 Nxb6! Qf3 26 Qf5 Rxb2+ (26...Qxf5+ 27 Nxf5 Be5 28 f4 Rxb2+ 29 Kc1 Bc3 30 h6 and the h-pawn is all-powerful) 27 Kxb2 Be5+ 28 Kc1 Qa3+ 29 Kd2 Rxd5+ 30 Ke2 Qxa2+ 31 Kf3 Qb3+ 32 Kg2!! (Lukacs, in *ChessBase Magazine* just gives 32 Ke2 with a draw) 32...Rxd1 33 Rxd1 Qxd1 34 Ng4! and it will take a miracle to stop the h-pawn.



NOTE: This is not an isolated example. A lot of the recent database analysis overlooks important older lines given in books. The best way to learn an opening is still from a good book – once you have mastered the basics you will be able to cope much better with the databases (which is the logical next step).

24...Qe2 25 Rhe1?

On his last move White missed an opportunity but this is a serious misjudgement. 25 f4 would have maintained the balance.

25...Qxe1 26 Rxe1 Rxe1+ 27 Kc2 Re2+ 28 Kd3 Re5 29 Qxf6 Bc7!

An excellent move. Now the white king is trapped where Black wants him and his dreams of reaching the safety of g2 will remain just that – dreams.

30 Qxh6 Rxd5+ 31 Kc2 Re2+ 32 Kc1 a6! 33 Qf8+ Rd8 34 Qxf7 Be5 35 Qb3 Rxf2 36 h6 c4 37 Qb6 Rdd2 38 h7 Rc2+ 0-1

7...Nd7 with Black Aiming to Castle Kingside

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 h5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6

In this section we shall discuss the lines where Black castles kingside (or at least where he prepares to castle kingside). Up until about 1980 the kingside was considered out of bounds for the black king. The players who favoured this variation did not want to take the slightest risk of their king coming under fire. Then a more dynamic group of players, led by Larsen, decided it was a risk worth taking. There were some spectacular reversals but also plenty of successes. In this variation it is natural for Black to seek active play on the queenside but this play is inevitably restrained if the black king is on this side of the board. Moves like ...b7-b5 and ...a7-a5 are no longer a viable option and Black even has to be careful with ...c6-c5. By castling kingside Black takes slight chances with his king's safety in order to unleash the full potential of his queenside counterplay. That at least is the theory; let's see if it holds up in practice.

11 Bf4 (Diagram 13)

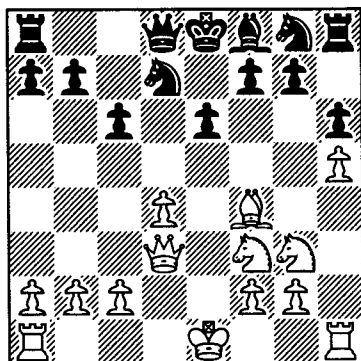


Diagram 13
The active choice

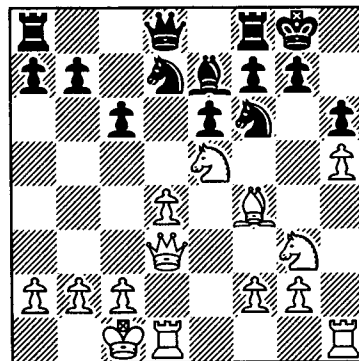


Diagram 14
The stage is set

At one point it was not thought to matter whether White played 11 Bd2 or 11 Bf4 as Black could always just play 11...Qa5+ 12 Bd2 (the queen is well placed on a5 after 12 c3) 12...Qc7, transposing into the main line. That's right, but the main line where Black castles queenside.

Basically, if Black is going to castle kingside, then White has the choice of where he wants his bishop. Naturally it is more active on f4 than d2 so the move 11 Bf4 is now considered the most precise response to 10...e6 (or 10...Ngf6). In fact, there are quite a few Black players who play 10...e6 with the idea of playing the line with ...0-0 against 11 Bd2, but simply transposing into the line with ...0-0-0 if White plays 11 Bf4.

11 Bd2 is examined in Game 8.

11...Ngf6 12 0-0-0 Be7

12...Nd5 13 Bd2 Nb4 has become quite popular as Black tries to show that White shouldn't have developed his bishop to f4 in the first place. However, on the latest evidence Black is struggling to equalise, both after 14 Bxb4 Bxb4 15 c4 and 14 Qb3!?

13 Ne5

The most aggressive continuation and one which makes full use of the bishop's position on f4. It is true that Black can exchange another pair of minor pieces now but White's bishop will be well placed on e5.

The line recommended by most theoretical sources is 13 Kb1 0-0 14 Ne4, but this usually leads to an endgame so it may not be to all white players' tastes. This is examined in Game 5.

It is probably a little premature to play 13 c4 as Black has the thematic reply 13...b5!. Now White should definitely not accept the pawn sacrifice. The position after 14 cxb5 cxb5 15 Qxb5 Nd5 is highly dangerous, for White. Instead, he should play 14 c5. Black still gets con-



trol of d5 but this time White keeps his space advantage and the queenside closed.

TIP: In similar positions Black should always think about (that doesn't mean you have to do it) meeting c4 with ...b5. The d5-square and some open lines on the queenside are usually ample compensation for the pawn.

13...0-0 (Diagram 14)

Game 6 features a famous example where Black paid dearly for keeping his king in the middle.

After 13...0-0 White has a choice:

a) 14 c4 c5 15 d5 Nxe5 (15...Bd6!? is also playable) 16 Bxe5 Ng4 17 Bxg7 was the famous game Karpov-Hübner, Tilburg 1982. Hübner played 17...Kxg7 and lost but the critical test seems to be 17...Bg5+ 18 Kc2 Nxf2. This is an unnecessarily risky line for White.

b) 14 Kb1 is often played here, or more precisely a combination of Kb1 and Ne5 played on moves 13 and 14. This position is examined in Game 7.

Theoretical?

These lines are not very theoretical as Black should be able to get to an early middlegame pretty easily. Of course it helps to have studied these middlegames but you won't have to strain yourself memorising sharp lines.

Statistics

In the lines where Black castled kingside with the bishop on d2 the score was 50-50. When Black still aimed to castle kingside with the bishop on f4 (supposedly superior) then White scored 59%. However, in many of these games Black was playing à la Larsen (Game 6) and he does better when he aims for ...c6-c5.

Game 5

□ Stefansson ■ S.Kasparov

Tanta City 2001

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 h5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bf4 Ngf6 12 0-0-0 Be7 13 Kb1

A useful precaution. If White plays c2-c4 the king will be less exposed and in many variations it is important that a2 is protected.

13...0-0 14 Ne4

The knight on g3 doesn't have a great future so White decides to exchange it off.

14...Nxe4 15 Qxe4 Nf6 16 Qe2 Qd5! (Diagram 15)

Black threatens to take on h5.

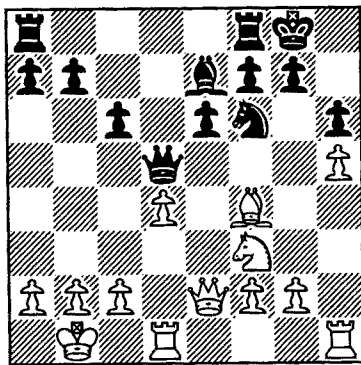


Diagram 15
Black cheekily attacks h5

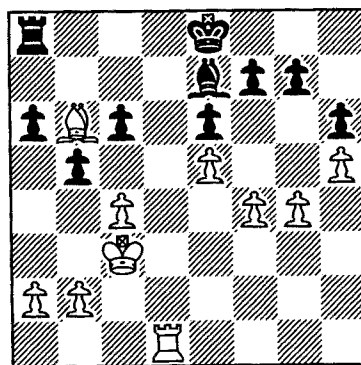


Diagram 16
White has control

17 Ne5 Qe4

This is Black's idea. An exchange of queens normally eases his defensive task and White has no comfortable way to avoid the exchange (18 Qd2 Nd5).

18 Qxe4 Nxe4

Chess theory is a strange creature and not always an exact science. All the books assess this position as slightly better for White, but a similar position that occurs in the 11 Bd2 variation is dismissed as harmless (see Game 8). The truth is probably somewhere in between. White has a very slight pull but a Caro-Kann player should feel perfectly at home in such positions as Black and have no trouble holding the draw.

19 Be3!?

Most theoretical sources give 19 Rhe1! Nf6 (19...Nxf2? 20 Rd2 Bh4 21 Ree2 leaves the black knight in trouble) 20 g4 with advantage to White, but Stefansson is not convinced by this and decides the most important thing is to stop Black playing ...c6-c5.

19...Rfd8 20 c4

Over the next moves White claims more and more space as Black sits idly by. I think he should have at least doubled rooks on the d-file. Instead of the feeble 20...Kf8, Black should play 20...Rd6.

20...Kf8 21 g4 Nf6 22 f3 Nd7 23 f4 a6 24 Kc2 Nxe5 25 dxe5 b5 26 Bb6 Rxd1 27 Rxd1 Ke8 28 Kc3 (Diagram 16)

The ending is very unpleasant for Black as each one of White's pieces are more active and his pawns more dynamic. The advance ...b7-b5, played by a man craving space, has also weakened the queenside pawn structure.

28...Rb8 29 Bc7 Rb7 30 Bd6 Bh4 31 b4 f6 32 Rd3 Kf7 33 Bc5!

Now Black got scared about Rd8 and Rf8 mate, but creating space for his king cost him a pawn and, soon after, the game.

33...g5 34 hxg6+ Kxg6 35 Rd6 h5 36 gxh5+ Kf5 37 exf6 Bxf6+ 38 Bd4 Bh4 39 Rxc6 Be1+ 40 Kb3 Kxf4 41 Bc5 a5 42 cxb5 Bxb4 43 Bxb4 Rxb5 44 Rc4+ Kf3 45 Ka4 1-0

Game 6

□ Beliaevsky ■ Larsen

Tilburg 1981

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 h5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bf4 Ngf6 12 0-0-0 Be7 13 Ne5 a5 14 Rhe1 a4?

Larsen is doing a wonderful impression of a beginner. He was famous for advancing his rooks' pawns but how could he simply ignore White's powerful build-up in the centre? Where is his sense of danger? I suspect that, by focusing on the alternative and more standard sacrifice 15 Nxf7, he completely missed White's next move. That sacrifice is not so dangerous as after 15...Kxf7 16 Qg6+ Kg8 White can't play 17 Rxe6 because of 17...Nf8.

15 Ng6! Nd5

Black is forced to decline the offer. After 15...fxg6 16 Qxg6+ Kf8 17 Rxe6 Qe8 White's position is so strong that he doesn't even have to avoid the exchange of queens. After 18 Rde1! Qxg6 19 hxg6 one nice variation is 19...Nd5 20 Rxe7! Nxe7 21 Bd6 Re8 22 Nf5, while White also ends up winning after 19...Bb4 20 c3.

16 Nf5! (Diagram 17)

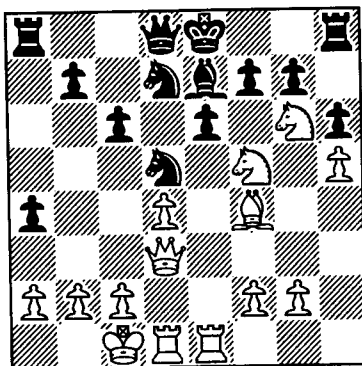


Diagram 17
Take my knights!

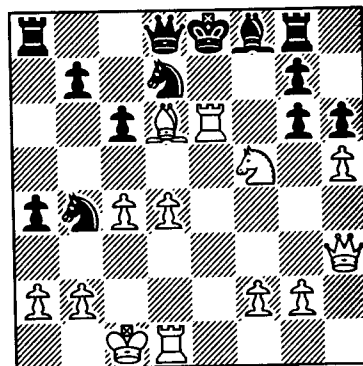


Diagram 18
White's attack crashes through

Much stronger than taking the rook. The most dangerous threat is 17 Nxe7 mate.

16...Bf8

After 16...fxg6 17 Nxg7+ Black gets mated while 16...exf5 17 Nxe7 Nxe7 18 Bd6 is not a lot of fun.

17 Bd6 Rg8

17...fxg6 still loses to 18 Nxg7+.

18 c4 Nb4 19 Qh3!

I think it would be fair to say that Larsen felt under pressure at this point.

19...fxg6 20 Rxe6+ (Diagram 18)

20...Kf7 21 hxg6+! Kxe6 22 Re1+ Ne5

After 22...Kf6 23 Ng3! Black gets mated.

23 Bxe5! 1-0

I'm just as impressed by this game now as I was 20 years ago. Big Al certainly packs a punch.

Game 7

□ Glek ■ Bareev

Russian Championship, St. Petersburg 1998

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 h5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bf4 Ngf6 12 0-0-0 Be7 13 Ne5 0-0 14 Kb1

After 14 Ne4 Nxe4 15 Qxe4 Nxe5 16 Bxe5 Qd5! White cannot even claim the slightest of edges as the only ending he can get involves taking on d5. This is still better than the 17 Qg4?! f6 18 Bf4 Qxa2 19 Bxh6 Rf7 tried in De Firmian-Korchnoi, Lugano 1989. White's king is in greater danger than Black's.

14...Rc8!?

Black figures that if he can get away with moves like ...a7-a5-a4, then he also has time to play ...Rc8. He is not entirely sure about what he wants to do on the queenside, but the text, by defending c6, introduces the possibility of playing ...b7-b5.

15 Qf3 Qa5 16 c4 Rfd8 17 Rd3 Qa6!

The white army appears slightly less coordinated than a few moves ago, a sure sign that his play during this stage of the game can be improved upon. Black is now ready for ...b7-b5, an important move which will gain control of the key central square d5.

18 Rhd1 b5 (Diagram 19) 19 c5

White must keep the position closed.

19...b4 20 Ne2?!

White is thinking of attacking with g2-g4-g5, but it was better to try and simplify with 20 Ne4.

20...Qb5 21 g4 Nd5 22 Bh2 Nxe5 23 Bxe5 Rd7 24 Rb3

White would have liked to exchange off Black's knight with something like 24 Nf4 but this runs into 24...Nc3+.

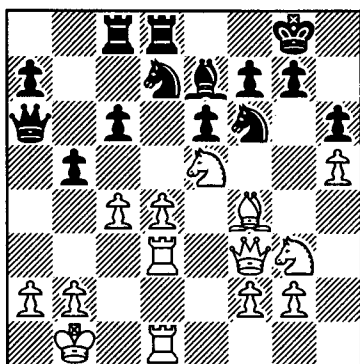


Diagram 19

Black begins queenside operations

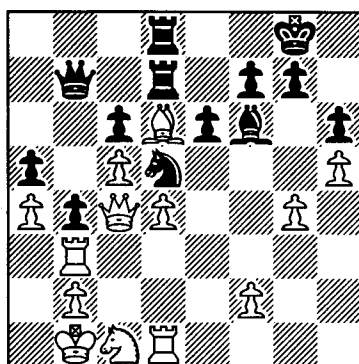


Diagram 20

Black can win a pawn

24...Rcd8 25 Qd3 a6 26 Nc1 Qb7 27 Qc4 a5 28 a4! Bf6 29 Bd6!?
(Diagram 20)

This loses a pawn but at least Black's knight has to quit the dream post on d5 to collect it. 29 Bxf6 might be objectively better but the position after 29...Nxf6 is not pleasant for White.

29...Nb6!? 30 Qc2 Nxa4 31 f4 Qb5!

Black is already planning to give up an exchange and use his queen in defence along the fifth rank.

32 g5!? hxc3 33 fxc3 Bxc3 34 Rg3 Rxd6 35 cxd6 Bh6 36 Qf2?

A terrible blunder. There was still plenty of fight left in White after 36 Rdg1.

36...Nc3+! 37 bxc3 bxc3+ 38 Ka1 Qa4+ 0-1

Game 8

□ Godena ■ Brunner

Horgen 1994

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 h5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bd2

As we have already mentioned, this move is considered slightly inferior to Bf4 because Black has an easier time in the lines where he castles kingside. The point is that with the bishop on d2, White will have to waste time with Qe2 if he wants to play Ne5, whereas with the bishop on f4 it is possible to play this at once.

11...Ngf6 12 0-0-0 Be7

Of course Black doesn't have to go for kingside castling. 12...Qc7 just takes us into the previous section.

13 Qe2

White prepares to play Ne5. The main alternative is 13 Ne4 and this

usually leads to an exchange of queens after 13...Nxe4 14 Qxe4 Nf6 15 Qe2 Qd5! 16 c4 Qe4 17 Qxe4 (17 Be3 b5! is dangerous for White) 17...Nxe4 18 Be3. This ending is very similar to the one found in Game 5, but this is a slightly more favourable one for Black because he has the possibility to play 18...Nd6, or even 18...Bg5. This line is no longer considered as a realistic winning attempt for White.

13 Kb1 0-0 14 Ne5 is considered in the next note while an early c2-c4 by White should almost certainly be met by ...b7-b5!

13...0-0 14 Ne5

14 Kb1 is just too slow to cause Black difficulties. White can get away with one preparatory move but not two. Black replies 14...c5.

14...c5! (Diagram 21)

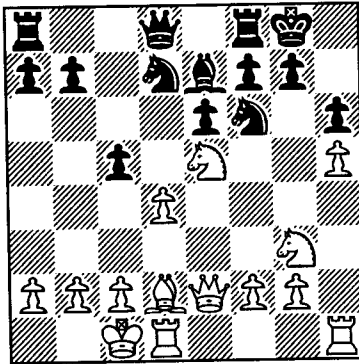


Diagram 21
A typical pawn break

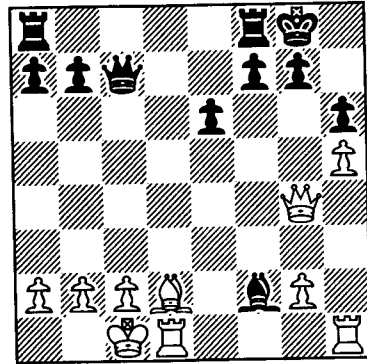


Diagram 22
Black defends actively

Some black players like to indulge themselves by pushing their a-pawn but the text is much more thematic and appears to solve all Black's opening problems.



TIP: Push your c-pawn rather than you're a-pawn with Black in these lines. Unlike the speculative ...a5, the move ...c5 activates the black pieces.

15 dxc5

On 15 Be3 Black can just play 15...Qa5 with a level game.

15...Bxc5

15...Nxc5!? is also fine as there is no good discovered attack on the queen. For example, 16 Bxh6? Qa5 and Black collects on a2.

16 Nxd7 Qxd7 17 Ne4

Again there is no great discovery. 17 Bg5 can be met by either 17...Nd5 or 17...Qe7, while 17 Bxh6 still costs White his crucial a-pawn after 17...Qa4.

17...Nxe4 18 Qxe4 Qc7 19 Qg4 Bxf2! (Diagram 22)

There is no need to defend passively with 19...Kh8 20 Bc3 Rg8.

20 Bxh6 f5?

But this is a serious mistake which leaves the black king in a perilous state. With 20...Qg3! Black could have forced the exchange of queens and obtained a level endgame. Even after the tricky move 21 Rd4 Black can just play 21...f5!.

21 Qe2 Qb6 22 Bg5!? f4 23 Qg4 Rf5 24 h6 Qe3+ 25 Kb1 Qg3 26 Qe2 Qe3 27 Qh5 Qe5 28 hxf5?

Just when White could have won on the spot with 28 Rd7! he blunders and loses. The Italian number one is a strong player with one major flaw – he rarely has more than two minutes for his last twenty moves.

28...Qxg7 29 Bh6 Rxf5 0-1

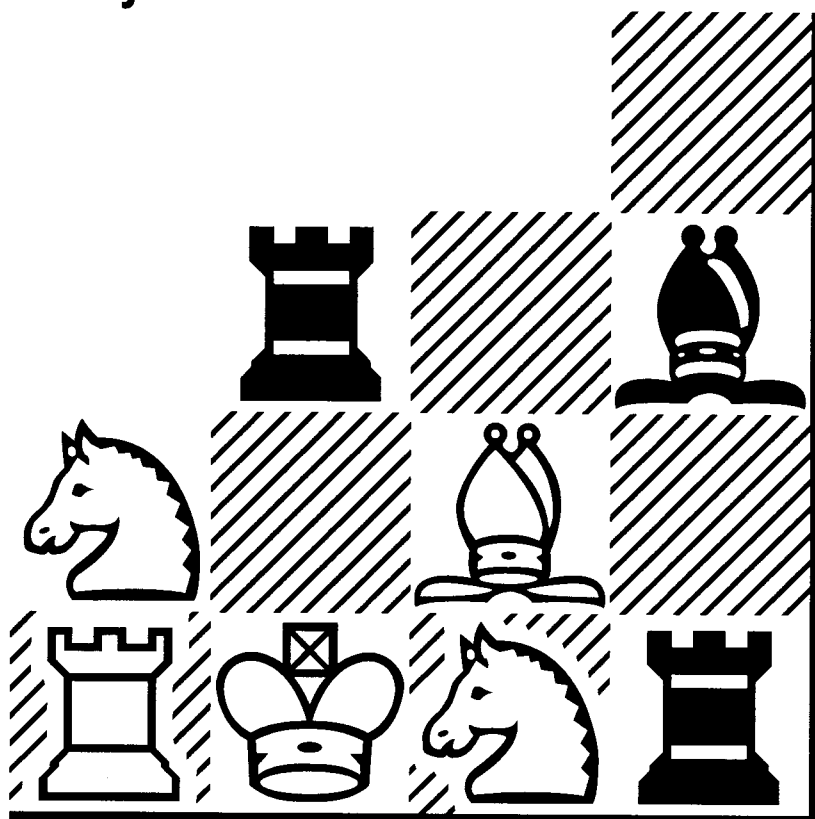
Summary

- 1) The old lines of the Classical Caro-Kann are as respectable today as they have ever been. When Black castles queenside White has good chances of obtaining a slight advantage.
- 2) However, when Black castles kingside and plays accurately (i.e. not like in Game 6) even this may be beyond White unless he is willing to play a rather dull endgame straight from the opening. The middle-game positions seem fine for Black.

Chapter Two

Classical Variation 4...Bf5: The Modern 7...Nf6

- ▨ Introduction and Early Divergences
- ▨ Main Line with 8 Ne5 Bh7 9 Bd3
- ▨ Summary



Introduction and Early Deviations

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nf6 (Diagram 1)

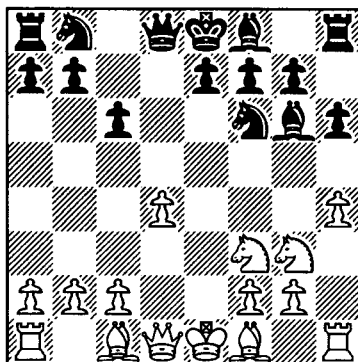


Diagram 1

Black's not scared of Ne5

It wasn't so long ago that the move 7...Nf6 was condemned as an inaccuracy and accompanied by the dreaded '?', or perhaps just '?!' if the annotator happened to be feeling in a particularly good mood. How things have changed! Now it is the main line of 4...Bf5 and, consequently, one of the main lines of the whole Caro-Kann. So why didn't they like this move in the past? Well, unlike 7...Nd7, the move 7...Nf6 doesn't prevent White from playing 8 Ne5. Black players worried that if White was given this aggressive move for free (Black can't allow his pawn structure to be destroyed by Nxg6) it could serve as the platform for a dangerous attack. However, when concrete analysis revealed that the attacking lines Black feared were not so dangerous, attitudes began to change.

Why Bother with 7...Nf6?

So who went to all this trouble of making 7...Nf6 work? Well, it was mainly supporters of the lines where Black played 7...Nd7 and castled kingside who were looking for an improved version of this variation. The basic idea is to develop the kingside as quickly as possible and then play ...c6-c5. By keeping the knight on b8, Black will then have the option of playing ...Nc6, a rare move in the Caro-Kann.

They also hoped to show that the move Ne5 has a negative side. Principally, the knight no longer controls the squares d4 and e5 (that's right, a knight on e5 doesn't control the square e5) so Black's counterplay with c5 has more bite than with the knight still on f3. On other occasions it may just be easier for Black to simplify the game

because he can exchange off the knight on e5.

Let's see how the line has developed.

8 Ne5

This is obviously the critical test. 8 h5 is the subject of Game 9.

8...Bh7 9 Bc4

Threatening mate in one always raises the pulse even if it's a million to one shot. Currently 9 Bd3 is more popular and that is examined in the next section.

9...e6 10 Qe2



WARNING: Caro-Kann players should make sure they have an efficient radar system that picks out all Nxf7 threats. Basically, when there is a queen on e2, a knight on e5 and a bishop on c4 (or b3) the alarm bells should be ringing.

10...Nd5

The best move. Of course, in practice, Black has failed to prevent Nxf7 on numerous occasions. Moves such as 10...Bd6, 10...Nbd7 and 10...Qxd4 have all fallen victim to 11 Nxf7. The move 10...Be7 is another story, though, as after 11 Nxf7?! Kxf7 12 Qxe6+ Ke8 13 Qf7+ Kd7 the black king may be able to escape to the queenside. I like the German GM Mainka's reaction to 10...Be7: he just played 11 Bg5!?. I'll leave you to get your teeth into that one.

11 Bb3

The lot of a chess writer is not an easy one. In this important position White has ventured no less than eleven moves! I'll restrict myself to the most important:

- a) 11 Bd2 is the subject of Game 10.
- b) 11 Bxd5 has its points as 11...exd5 costs Black his queen and 11...cxd5 his b-pawn. That leaves 11...Qxd5 but then 12 Qh5 is awkward as there are only undesirable ways to defend f7 (12...g6 or 12...Bg8). Okay, I didn't tell the whole story. Black should play 11...cxd5 as after 12 Qb5+ Nd7 13 Qxb7 Nxe5 14 dxe5 Rb8 15 Qa6 Qd7! (Miralles-Speelman, Andorra 1998) he has excellent compensation for the pawn.
- 3) 11 Qf3 Qf6! 12 Bxd5 cxd5 13 Qb3 Qe7 14 Qb5+ Kd8 led to an unclear position in Haba-Khenkin, Poland 1999. Black has the better structure but his king is stuck in the middle. I'll just say that Khenkin believes in Black's position as this is not the only time he has played it.

11...Nd7

Black has also played 11...Bb4+ as White can't play 12 c3 because of 12...Nxc3!, and 12 Bd2 (not that he would want to play this move anyway) because of 12...Nf4. Therefore he would have to play 12 Kf1, although after something like 12...Bd6 13 Nh5 White has quite good attacking chances.

12 Bd2

White prepares to castle queenside.

12...a5 (Diagram 2)

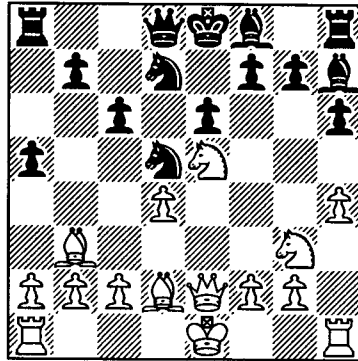


Diagram 2

...a7-a5 has a purpose



13 a4

TIP: When Black has a knight on d5 he usually prefers to have the moves a4 and ...a5 included. The reason for this is that White will be less keen to drive the knight away from the centre with c4 as it would than have an outpost on b4.

13...Nxe5 14 dxe5 Qb6 15 0-0-0 0-0-0

The position is roughly level. Black shouldn't forget that he can capture a white knight that lands on e4.

Theoretical?

The theory is very imprecise and no one really knows what's best so it probably won't hurt to do your own thing. Just remember that f7-square.

Statistics

Ignoring all transpositions, Black has scored an excellent 50% with 7...Nf6 (nearly 600 games). But this is quite a sophisticated variation and Black players have averaged 30 points higher than White. If we take the position after 9 Bc4 White has scored 52% from around 150 games.

Game 9

□ W.Watson ■ B.Lalic

London 2002

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3

Nf6 8 h5

White spurns the opportunity for Ne5 and just continues as if Black had played 7...Nd7. He is giving Black every chance, by playing ...Nd7 at some point, to transpose back into the previous chapter. In this game we will examine if Black can profitably avoid this transposition.

8...Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bd2

If White tries the more aggressive 11 Bf4 then 11...Bd6 looks like a good reply. This is another line that would not have been available to Black with his knight already on d7.

After 11 Bd2 a lot of Black players will just play 11...Nbd7 and that takes us into Game 8 (which was quite decent for Black). There is, however, one interesting attempt to exploit the fact that he hasn't moved his queen's knight yet. Black can play ...c6-c5 and try and follow up with ...Nc6. This should create more pressure against the white centre than the similar lines with the knight on d7.

11...c5!?

Black plays his thematic move without delay. Many leading Caro players have adopted this line with Black. The other independent line is 11...Be7 12 0-0-0 0-0 and, whatever White plays, Black follows up with ...c6-c5. For example, 13 Ne5 c5 14 dxc5 Qc7 15 Bc3 Nd5 16 Ne4 Na6 17 Bd4 Rfc8, Smirin-Dautov, Dresden 1998, is considered level.

12 0-0-0 Nc6 13 Bc3 Qd5 14 dxc5 Qxd3 (Diagram 3)

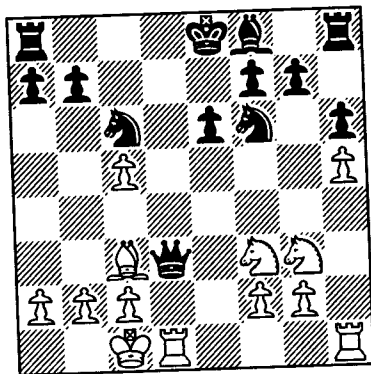


Diagram 3

How should White recapture?

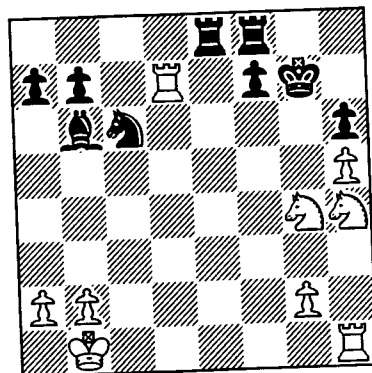


Diagram 4

The threats mount up

15 cxd3!

Every other time this position had been reached White played 15 Rxd3 and achieved precisely nothing after 15...Bxc5 16 Bxf6 gxf6 17 Ne4 Be7. The theoreticians lavished praise upon Black's 12th and 13th moves and White discarded the line and moved on.

That was the state of play until a letter from Grandmaster Bogdan

Lalic arrived at the offices of the famous Dutch publication *New in Chess*. Bogdan wanted to know how it was possible that the world's professional grandmasters and theoreticians (including himself) had completely overlooked this idea, while a middle-aged London solicitor found it straight away. Admittedly, William Watson is a grandmaster and former British Champion, but he rarely moves in chess circles these days and certainly doesn't study the game anymore.

Probably no-one appreciated the strength of 15 cxd3 as, from a positional point of view, it is so ugly. The point is, though, that there is nothing Black can do to prevent the advance d3-d4-d5, after which it is the black structure that will be left looking physically challenged.

15...Bxc5 16 Bxf6 gxf6 17 d4 Bb6 18 d5! exd5?

Lalic saw that 18...Nb4 19 dxe6 fxe6 20 Rhe1 Bxf2 21 Rxe6+ Kf7 22 Re4!, countering against the knight on b4, is awful for Black, but missed the best move 18...Ne7!. Now 19 d6 Nd5 is not so good as the pawn is isolated on d6, so White should play 19 dxe6 fxe6 20 Ne4 Nd5 with some advantage because of Black's loose pawn structure in the centre. This may not look like much but it obviously impressed Bogdan, and I, myself, have analysed this position and can confirm that it is quite easy for things to go wrong for Black.

19 Rxd5 Bxf2 20 Ne4 Be3+ 21 Kb1 0-0

Black can save his f-pawn with 21...Bg5 but then Nd6+ and Nxb7 is good for White. Basically, the pawn structure is ideal for the white knights and they are the masters of the board.

22 Nxf6+ Kg7 23 Ng4 Rae8 24 Rd7 Bb6 25 Nh4! (Diagram 4)
25...Nd4

Black stops White from playing Nf5 and sets a little trap. If White now tries to win material with 26 Rxd4 Bxd4 27 Nf5+ Kh8 28 Nxd4, then he will end up losing it after 28...Re4. But Watson had other ideas for his knight on h4.

26 Ng6! Re4

26...Rg8 27 Rf1 is terminal.

27 Nxf8 Rxg4 28 Ng6

A simple but elegant return to the fray. Black is now totally lost.

Rg5 29 g4 Kf6 30 Rf1+ Ke6 31 Rxf7 Rxg4 32 Rfe7+ Kf6 33 Rf7+ Kg5

Black walks into a mate. If he had gone back to e6, White would probably have made some room for his king with 34 a3 before continuing on his merry way.

34 Rd5+ 1-0

Game 10

□ Anka ■ Solozhenkin

Helsinki 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3

Nf6 8 Ne5 Bh7 9 Bc4 e6 10 Qe2 Nd5 11 Bd2 (Diagram 5)

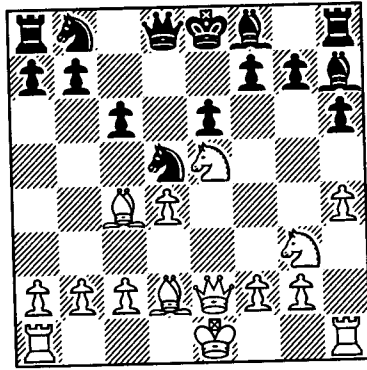


Diagram 5
White offers the c2-pawn

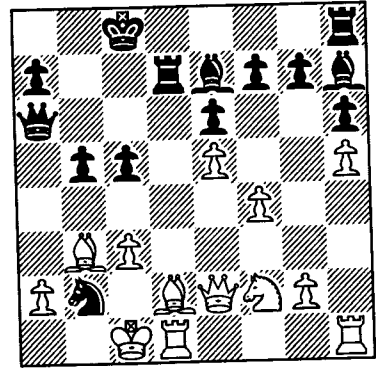


Diagram 6
Black's knight will soon be regained

This is the latest attempt by White to breathe fire into this line. We saw above that in the theoretical section White playing 11 Bb3 in order to prepare Bd2 and 0-0-0. This time White just gets on with the queenside castling plan without even taking a time out to protect his c-pawn.

11...Nd7

11 Bd2 was first played in Xie Jun-Chiburdanidze, Elista Olympiad 1998 and that is still the only game where Black dared to take the pawn. After 11...Bxc2!? 12 Rc1 Bh7 13 0-0 Nd7 14 Bxd5 cxd5 15 Nh5 the Black position looks rather shaky to the naked eye. Still, she went on to win a tough struggle. Dreev has suggested 12 Qh5!? as an alternative way for White to conduct the attack.

12 0-0-0 Nxe5 13 dxe5 Qc7 14 f4 0-0-0 15 Ne4 Be7 16 Qf3?

It may be a bit harsh to give this move a question mark, but White's troubles can be traced to this move which weakens the seemingly unimportant c4-square. Dreev has reached this position twice with the black pieces and both times his opponents played 16 h5 and he played ...f7-f6 to break up the bind in the centre. For example, Ye Jiangchuan-Dreev, Shenyang 1999 continued 16...Kb8 17 Rhe1 f6 18 exf6 gxf6 19 Qf3 Rhe8 20 a3. This position is probably all right for Black but he got into trouble by playing 20...f5.

16...Nb6 17 Bb3 c5 18 c3 Qc6 19 Bc2 Nc4 20 Qe2

NOTE: One of the hallmarks of a strong player is that they sense, before it is too late, when they have to bail out or change the course of the game. In this game White just drifted into a lost position. His last real chance was probably to play 20 b3 here, while earlier he could have played 17 Bd3 or 18 Be3.

20...Qa6!



Now White is struggling just to keep his head above water. He would like to play 21 Kb1 but can't as this loses a piece.

21 Bb3 b5!?

Black would have seen the variation 21...Nxb2!? 22 Qxa6 bxa6 23 Kxb2 Bxe4 but he was loath to cash in a fine middlegame position for an ending with a extra doubled pawn.

22 h5 Rd7 23 Nf2?!

White probably couldn't bring himself to take the knight because this leaves the bishop on h7 in total control, but his choice is no better.

23...Nxb2!? (Diagram 6)

Black was spoilt for choice as 23...Nxd2 24 Rxd2 Rxd2 25 Qxd2 c4 picks up the a-pawn.

24 Kxb2 c4 25 a4

Unfortunately for White, 25 Bc2 is impossible.

25...cxb3 26 Qxb5 Qxb5 27 axb5 Bc2

Black wins the exchange and the game. The remaining moves were:

**28 Be3 Bxd1 29 Nxd1 Rhd8 30 Bd4 Rb7 31 b6 axb6 32 Nf2 Bc5
33 Ne4 Bxd4 34 cxd4 Rxd4 35 Nd6+ Kb8 36 Nxb7 Kxb7 37 Rf1
Rd3 38 g4 Rg3 39 g5 hxg5 40 f5 Rh3 41 fxe6 fxe6 42 Rd1 Rxb5 43
Rd7+ Kc6 44 Rd6+ Kc5 45 Rxe6 Rh6 0-1**

Main Line with 8 Ne5 Bh7 9 Bd3

**1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3
Nf6 8 Ne5 Bh7 9 Bd3**

When everyone realised that 9 Bc4 was not quite as devastating as it was made out to be, White's natural reaction was to investigate the alternatives. And with games like the previous one where White was destroyed by the bishop on h7, it is not surprising that White's attention soon turned to 9 Bd3. The idea is simply to exchange off that nasty bishop loitering in the corner before it can do any damage.

9...Bxd3

There are a couple of alternatives to be looked at:

a) 9...Qxd4? loses to 10 Nxf7! as after 10...Kxf7 11 Bg6+ Black loses his queen. 'What about 10...Bxd3?' I hear you ask, so that after 11 Nxb7 Qe5+ 12 Be3 Bh7 the knight is trapped and will be lost one day. Good point, but White has a rather neat way to extricate the creature: 13 Qd8+!! Kxd8 14 Nf7+ and after 15 Nxe5 Black can resign.

b) 9...Nbd7!? has suddenly emerged as a serious alternative to the text. The idea seems to be to give both sides a bad position after 10 Bxb7 Nxe5 11 dxe5 Qa5+ (11...Qxd1+ 12 Kxd1 Nxb7 13 Ke2 e6 is only very slightly better for White but 13 e6 may be a better try) 12 Kf1 Nxb7. Twelve moves each and White has managed to manoeuvre his knight from b1 to g3 and lose the right to castle, while Black has

managed to transfer his king's knight to h7. Still, White can probably claim to have slightly the better of it after 13 Qe2 0-0-0 14 e6 Qd5 15 exf7 Qxf7 16 Be3, Leko-Bareev, Dortmund 2000.

Incidentally, If White wishes to keep a more coordinated position (and the two bishops) then 11 Bf5 is a possibility as Black has nothing better than 11...Ned7. Still, it is nothing special for White.

10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bd2

This is an important moment. As I pointed out above, Black allowed White to play Ne5 because he plans to either exchange this knight off or, failing that, to undermine the central squares this knight is no longer protecting. White knows that in the coming moves the knight on e5, if it is going to try and maintain its menacing position in the centre of the board, will need additional support. There are basically two ways to do this: with a piece or with a pawn. The text, by leaving the f4-square free, signals White's intention to support his knight with a pawn. The alternative is 11 Bf4. That is examined in Game 11.

11...Nbd7

Recently Epishin, one of the heroes of the Caro-Kann, and a few others have begun to play 11...Be7!? and 12...0-0 before challenging in the centre with ...c6-c5. They delay the development of the queen's knight as in some cases it may be able to go to c6. If White plays in standard fashion then Black seems to be able to equalise but there is one dangerous plan at White's disposal – see Game 12.

12 f4 Be7

a) 12...Bd6 is a less reliable way to develop the bishop as Black no longer has the possibility to play ...Nxe5.

b) 12...c5!? has been favoured by the former Women's World Champion Maya Chiburdanidze. Black should just be careful after 13 0-0-0 to avoid 13...cxd4? (13...Be7) 14 Ng6! fxe6? 15 Qxe6+ Ke7 16 Bb4+.

13 0-0-0 0-0 14 Qf3! (Diagram 7)

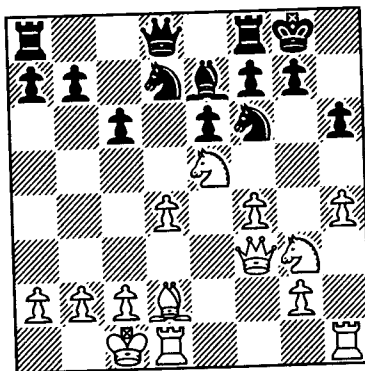


Diagram 7

White has aggressive intentions

The strong and well-supported knight on e5 and the possibility to play f4-f5 give White a pleasant game. See Game 13 for some practical examples from this position

Theoretical?

Theory is developing but it is certainly not omnipresent. Strategy is more important.

Statistics

With 9 Bd3 White scores 55% from 150 games (and he is only slightly higher rated). There are not really enough games to delve any deeper in this new variation

Game 11

□ Ponomarev ■ Conquest

Torshavn 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nf6 8 Ne5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bf4

White renounces any idea of playing f2-f4 and supports his knight with his bishop whilst preparing to castle queenside.



NOTE: White never worries about Black playing ...Nd5 in such positions as he just drops his bishop back to d2 and leaves Black to worry about whether he is going to play c4.

11...Qa5+!?

For a while the idea used in this game almost put Bf4 out of commission as Black drew quite a few games without even breaking sweat. In this game, though, the future FIDE World Champion shows how White can keep some pressure.

Before everyone started to play 11...Qa5+, a typical continuation was something like 11...Nbd7 12 0-0-0 Be7 13 Kb1 0-0. The position is very similar to the ones in the previous chapter where Black castled kingside. There is one important difference, though. The fact that the white pawn is only on h4, as opposed to h5, means that White has use of the h5-square for his pieces, and especially his knight. This means that the black king is in more danger here. For example, Almasi-Stohl, Baden 1999 continued 14 Qe2 Qb6?! (14...a5 may be a better idea) 15 Nxd7! Nxd7 16 Rd3 with excellent attacking chances. The unusual capture on d7 was made to deflect the one black piece that was defending his king.

12 c3 Qa6 (Diagram 8)

This is what the check on the previous move is all about. Black is trying to exchange queens. If White avoids the exchange then the queen will be well placed on a6 where it controls the f1-a6 diagonal and hits the a2 pawn in case White is thinking of castling queenside.

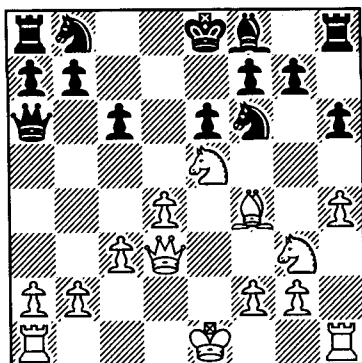


Diagram 8
Black offers a trade

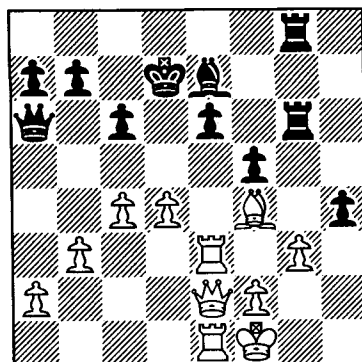


Diagram 9
Black's e6-pawn is under fire

13 Ne4!

An interesting new move. The key game prior to this one had been Svidler-Anand, Wijk aan Zee 1999, which went 13 Qf3 Nbd7 14 Nxd7 Nxd7 15 Ne4 Nf6!. Now White has only a token advantage after 16 Nxf6+ gxf6 while in the game Black drew quite easily after 16 Nd6+ Bxd6 17 Bxd6 Qb5! followed by 18...Qd5.

13...Nxe4?!

Black should have settled for the endgame after 13...Qxd3 14 Nxf6+ gxf6 15 Nxd3. It must be a little better for White but there have been no practical examples yet. It would be nice to have a Ponomarev-Anand game to test this thesis.

14 Qxe4 Nd7 15 Nxd7 Kxd7

It's not so uncommon in this line for Black to recapture with his king on d7. With so few pieces left there is not much danger of a dangerous attack and he has no weaknesses in his position. No weaknesses yet! Ponomarev now came up with an excellent plan that forced a weakening in the black pawn structure so that his pieces could have something to attack.

16 Rh3! Rc8 17 Be5! Qc4 18 Rf3 f6 19 Bg3 f5

Black decides he is not going to sit and wait and searches for counterplay by advancing his kingside pawns. It just makes things worse.

20 Qc2 g5 21 Be5 Rg8 22 b3! Qd5 23 c4 Qa5+ 24 Kf1 Be7 25 hxg5 Rxc5

Black's position is cut in two by White's control of e5 so there is not much chance of any kingside attack working for him. White, meanwhile, soon finds the time to pile up against the pawn on e6.

26 Rd1 h5 27 Qe2 Qa6 28 Bf4 Rg6 29 Re3 Rcg8 30 g3 h4 31 Re1! (Diagram 9) 31...Bb4 32 Rxe6!

The black position caves in.

32...Bxe1 33 Re7+ Kd8 34 Bc7+ Kc8 35 Qe5

White can afford to take such liberties as for all practical purposes Black is just a queen down.

35...b5 36 Bd8! Ba5 37 Rc7+ Kb8 38 Rxc6+ 1-0

Game 12

□ Luther ■ Doettling

Schwerin 1999

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nf6 8 Ne5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bd2 Be7 12 0-0-0 0-0 13 Ne2!

This is the dangerous idea I mentioned above. White is going to show Black the error of his ways by advancing his g-pawn and delivering checkmate. Surprisingly, the idea has not caught on and most games have gone 13 f4 c5 14 dxc5 Qc7!, when Epishin and others have demonstrated that Black is doing fine here.

13...Nbd7

Grandmaster Neil McDonald wrote a book on the *Main Line Caro-Kann* (Everyman 2000) and he was obviously concerned about this variation. He suggested that Black should try 13...c5 14 g4 Qd5 in order to meet 15 g5 with 15...Qxa2 and 15 c4 with 15...Qe4 to exchange queens. However, in this latter variation White can continue 16 g5! Qxd3 17 Nxd3 as the exchange of queens hardly dampens his attack.

14 Nxd7 Nxd7

Black decides that it is too risky to accept the sacrifice after 14...Qxd7 15 g4, so comes up with the plan of grabbing the h-pawn in order to make it more difficult for White to play g5. I suspect he would have had more survival chances after 14...Qxd7.

15 g4 (Diagram 10)

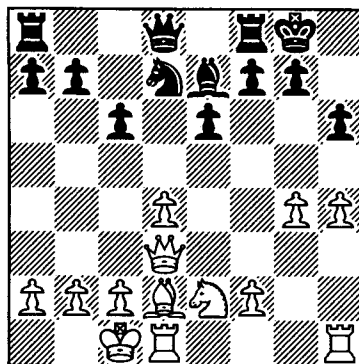


Diagram 10
Charge!

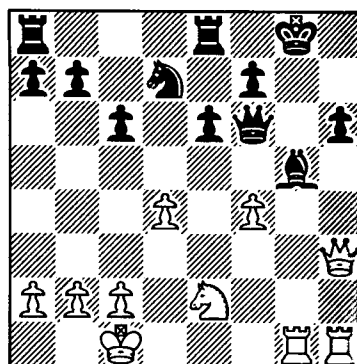


Diagram 11
White misses a chance

15...Bxh4 16 Qh3! Be7 17 Rdg1

White has a massive attack and he will break through on the kingside by either sacrificing a bishop on h6 or by playing g4-g5. He should just be careful to avoid variations like 17 Bxh6 gxh6 18 Qxh6 Bg5+.

17...Re8 18 Bxh6!? gxh6 19 g5

Now White threatens Qxh6. Maybe the best defensive try is 19...Nf8 20 Qxh6 Ng6, when there is no immediate mate but the black position remains highly suspicious.

19...Bxg5+ 20 f4 Qf6 (Diagram 11) 21 Qxh6?

White swaps queens and agrees a draw. Incredible, when the obvious 21 fxg5 hxg5 22 Qe3! gives him a decisive attack.

21...Qxh6 ½-½*Game 13*

☐ Movsesian ☒ Iordachescu

FIDE World Championship, New Delhi 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6 6 h4 h6 7 Nf3 Nf6 8 Ne5 Bh7 9 Bd3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 e6 11 Bd2 Nbd7 12 f4 Be7 13 0-0-0 0-0 14 Qf3

Michael Adams got excellent value out of 14 Qe2, crushing two opponents before it was decided that the move was imprecise. After 14...c5 15 dxc5 Nxc5 16 Bc3 Qc7! (16...Qb6? 17 Ng4! was how the other game went) 17 f5 (now 17 Ng4? is met by 17...Qxf4+) 17...exf5? 18 Nxf5 White had a tremendous attacking position in Adams-Leko, Linares 1999. Instead Black should have played 17...Nd5 18 Bd4 Rad8 when most analysts believe he already has the better game.

14...Qc7

It is no longer easy for Black to break out with ...c6-c5. He may have left it too late (12...c5!). Here, for example 14...c5 15 f5 cxd4 16 Nxf7! causes trouble.

15 c4

White claims more space in the centre and has planned a powerful riposte to the thematic ...c6-c5.

15...c5?!

Dreev's 15...a5 is undoubtedly the lesser evil but Black's position remains cramped and unpleasant.

16 d5! (Diagram 12)**16...Rae8**

One of the main points was that 16...Nxe5 17 fxe5 Qxe5 18 Bf4 costs Black his queen.

17 Rhe1 exd5 18 cxd5 Bd6 19 Bc3

White simply plans Nf5. Black must do something quickly but unfortunately for him, nothing works.

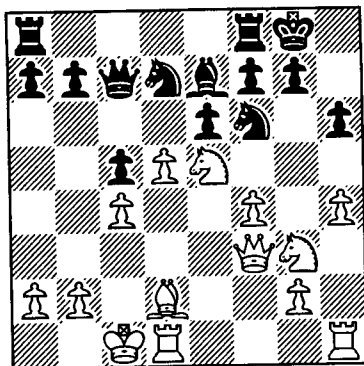


Diagram 12
A powerful pawn on d5

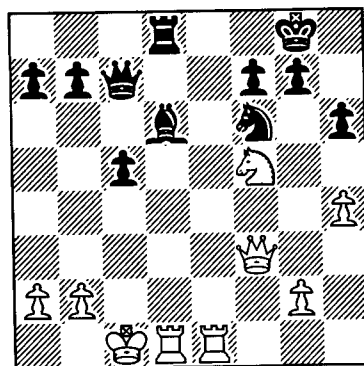


Diagram 13
White has a simple tactic

19...Nxe5 20 fxe5 Rxe5

Black gives up the exchange to take control of the dark squares. This would be a fine idea if there weren't a tactical refutation! Anyway, 20...Bxe5 21 Rxe5! Rxe5 22 d6 also lost.

21 Bxe5 Bxe5 22 Nf5 Rd8 23 d6 Bxd6 (Diagram 13) 24 Rxd6! 1-0

After 24...Rxd6 25 Qg3 White threatens mate and the rook and will emerge a piece to the good.

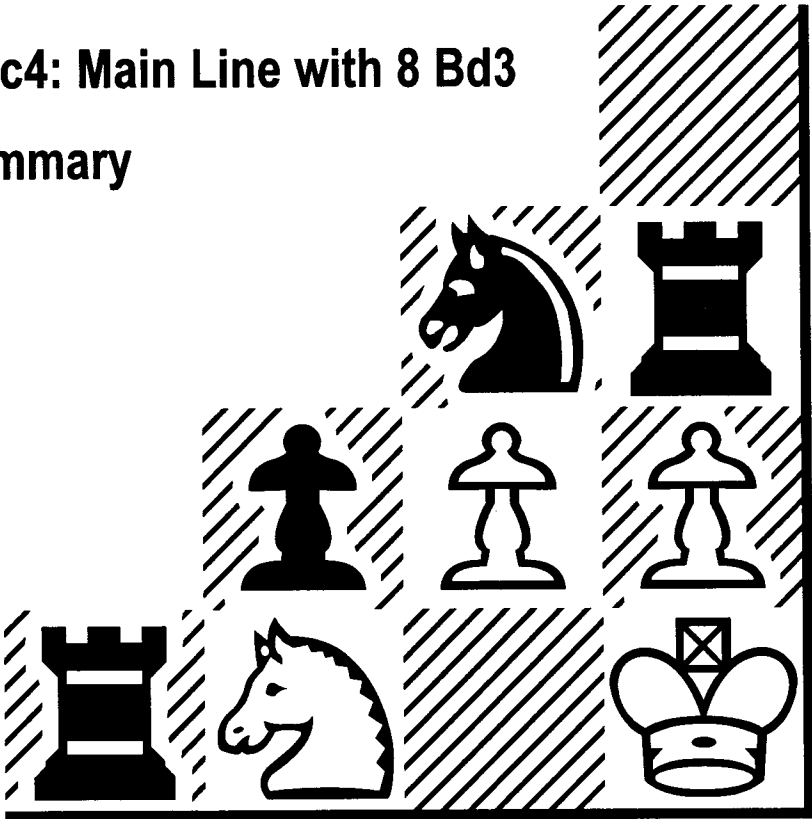
Summary

- 1) I'm not totally convinced that the line with 7...Nf6 will retain its popularity. The line with 0-0 in the previous Chapter seems at least as good a way for Black to play the Classical Caro-Kann.
- 2) Black seems to be doing okay when White plays with Bc4 but he is under a little pressure when White plays with Bd3.

Chapter Three

4...Nd7: Alternatives to 5 Ng5

- Introduction
- The Calm 5 Nf3
- 5 Bc4: Introduction and 8 Bb3
- 5 Bc4: Main Line with 8 Bd3
- Summary



Introduction

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 (Diagram 1)

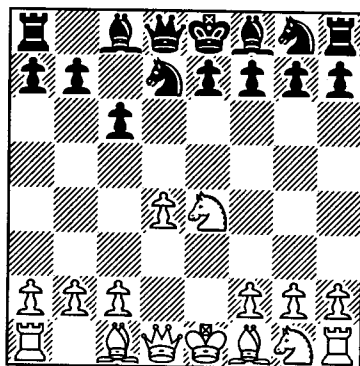


Diagram 1

The starting position for the 4...Nd7 variation

This variation is often named after the former World Champion Vassily Smyslov, who introduced it into his repertoire in the late 1950s. However, I have always associated this variation with two other very strong players. The first is the English Grandmaster Jonathan Speelman who has remained faithful to the variation for over 20 years. The second, and the real hero of the variation, is another former World Champion: Anatoly Karpov.

In the 1987 final eliminator match to challenge Garry Kasparov, Karpov found himself facing the rising star of world chess, Andrei Sokolov. Sokolov looked particularly dangerous when playing his favourite 1 e4 so Karpov's preparation centred on finding a system to blunt his attacking edge. He opted for a variation he had never played before: the ...Nd7 Caro-Kann. During the match Sokolov failed to win a single game against it (although, ironically, he did beat Karpov in a tournament game soon afterwards) while Karpov picked him off with the white pieces. Ever since Karpov has used this variation as his main weapon against 1 e4 and it was mainly due to his efforts that 4...Nd7 became so popular. It is certainly one of the most important lines of the Caro-Kann and in my view deserves to be renamed after Karpov (Smyslov never showed the same commitment to the variation). To avoid confusion, however, I will stick with the ...Nd7 Caro-Kann, which is how I've known it during my chess career.

Why Play 4...Nd7?

The idea of 4...Nd7 is very simple. Black wants to develop his king's knight but without incurring the pawn weaknesses he does in Chap-

ter 5 (where he plays an immediate 4...Nf6). The system is extremely solid; Black's basic plan is to quietly develop his pieces and then to counter in the centre with ...c6-c5. After exchanging his c-pawn for White's d-pawn Black should be left with a 1-0 central pawn majority (usually he has a pawn on e6) which may prove to be an advantage in the long run.

Who Should Play it?

This is not a variation that will suit all styles. Black players are warned that they often have to soak up a lot of early pressure. They should expect to get a compact, sometimes cramped, position but one without any weaknesses. If you are the sort of player who likes activity at all costs then look elsewhere. This is a variation for those who value, above all, a solid structure. I think it would be fair to describe 4...Nd7 as a provocative variation. White is encouraged to attack but Black knows that his rock-solid position won't be easy to breakdown. However, once White starts to attack Black must be ready to counter in a vigorous manner.



WARNING: A sure recipe for disaster is to just sit there passively trying to fend off an attack without any aggressive intentions of one's own.

To sum up, this is a variation where Black is not really looking for a fight but if White starts one...

What does White Play?

There are three main lines that White usually chooses from. The most solid and least ambitious is 5 Nf3. White usually develops quietly and hopes to obtain a small advantage to take into the middlegame. The system based on 5 Bc4 is more aggressive and there are many more dangers for Black in the early stages of the game. These two variations are covered in this chapter.

The third line is 5 Ng5. This is a relatively new and dangerous system that developed because of the problems White was having in the other lines. This is now considered as the main line and is the subject of the next chapter.

There are a couple of other 5th moves that deserve a quick mention. The first is 5 Bd3, which often transposes to the next chapter after 5...Ngf6 6 Ng5. This move order was once popular but White players finally decided that it was less flexible than 5 Ng5 (mainly because of the reply 5...Ndf6) and it is not played so often anymore.

The other move worthy of a quick mention is 5 Qe2. This is occasionally played by those with an infantile sense of humour who are hoping that Black won't notice that 5...Ngf6 allows 6 Nd6 mate. As long as Black stops this (5...e6, 5...Ndf6) then White should have no reason to laugh.

The Calm 5 Nf3

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Nf3 Ngf6 6 Ng3!? (Diagram 2)

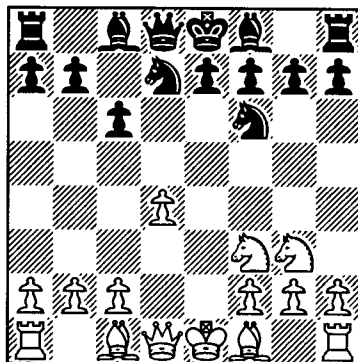


Diagram 2

White avoids the trade

This move makes a lot of sense. White has more space so he keeps as many pieces as possible on the board. The alternative continuation, 6 Nxf6+, is examined in Game 15.

6...c5!?

This natural advance is designed to liquidate White's advantage in the centre. If Black doesn't play this move reasonably quickly he will find himself stuck in an extremely passive position. 6...e6 7 Bd3 c5 would transpose back into the main game.

7 Bd3

After 7 dxc5 Black should avoid 7...Nxc5 8 Qxd8+ Kxd8 with a clearly worse endgame in favour of 7...e6. As White can't hang onto the pawn (8 b4 b6!) he usually settles for 8 c6 as after 8...bxc6 Black's queenside pawn structure has been slightly compromised. However, Black remains very solid and if there is an edge for White it is a small one.

7...e6

A more aggressive plan is to exchange in the centre and fianchetto the king's bishop. For example, 7...cxd4 8 Nxd4 g6 9 0-0 Bg7 was once thought to be quite a good position for Black but the latest view is that 10 Qe2! 0-0 11 Rd1 creates uncomfortable pressure along the d-file.

8 0-0 cxd4 9 Nxd4 Bc5 10 Nb3

10 Be3 and 10 c3 are the two other ways to deal with the attack on the knight. These also offer White chances of a small opening plus.

10...Be7



If Black had played ...Be7 at once then we would have the same position except with the white knight on the more active d4-square.

NOTE: This ...Bc5-e7 manoeuvre is quite common and can be seen in a variety of other openings such as the Sicilian Defence and the French Defence.

Incidentally, 10...Bb6 may look more active but would be dubious as the bishop is likely to be required on the kingside for defensive duties.

11 Re1 0-0 12 Qf3

I am amazed to see this position assessed as equal by *Encyclopaedia of Chess Openings*. Surely it must be a little better for White? If nothing else, he has the more active pieces and a lead development. That is not to say that Black shouldn't be able to draw with accurate play (see Game 14), but at this point White must be slightly better.

Theoretical?

This is a low priority section as far as learning theory goes, but Black will obviously do better if he has worked out lines beforehand against both 6 Nxf6+ and 6 Ng3.

Statistics

Overall after 5 Nf3 Ngf6 White has scored 52% from over 3000 games. Not a particularly good score (remember 54% is average) but what about if we look at the main lines a little more closely. With 6 Ng3 White scores about 54% while with 6 Nxf6+ he also scores around 54% providing he follows up with 7 Bc4 or 7 Ne5.

Game 14

□ Leko ■ Epishin

Dortmund 1994

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Nf3 Ngf6 6 Ng3 c5 7 Bd3 e6 8 0-0 cxd4 9 Nxd4 Bc5 10 Nb3 Be7 11 Re1 0-0 12 Qf3

All this has been examined above in the theoretical section.

12...a5

The a-pawn is an important tool in Black's positional armoury. See the first theoretical section in Chapter 2 for a discussion on this (page 36). Look what happened in a game where Black manoeuvred a knight straight to d5 without including ...a5 and a4: 12...Nb6 13 Bd2 Nbd5 14 Rad1 Bd7? (a horribly passive move) 15 c4 Nb4 16 Bb1 Nc6 17 Bc3 Qc7? (the only chance, albeit a very slim one, was to jettison a pawn with 17...e5) 18 Bxf6 19 Qd3 and White won a piece and the game, Gallagher-Sundararajan, British Championship 1999. Note the variation 19...Rfd8 20 Qxh7+ Kf8 21 Qh8+ Ke7 22 Nf5 mate.

13 a4 (Diagram 3)

It is best not to allow the black a-pawn to advance any further. White also gains control of the b5-square.

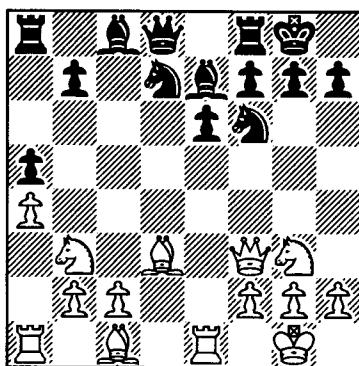


Diagram 3
The a-pawns are blocked

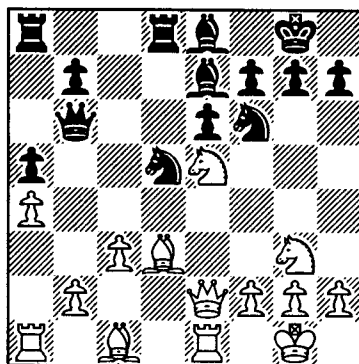


Diagram 4
Black is solid

13...Nd5 14 Bb5 Nb4 15 Qe2 Nf6 16 c3 Nbd5 17 Nd4 Qb6 18 Nf3 Bd7 19 Bd3 Rfd8 20 Ne5 Be8 (Diagram 4)

Peter Leko is one of the strongest grandmasters in the world but is often criticised for his safety first style. Here we have a good example. Black's position is very solid, and will certainly be a tough nut to crack, but White has a clear edge here. Leko, though, just decides to exchange off some pieces and agree a draw.

21 Ne4 Nxe4 22 Qxe4 Nf6 23 Qe2 Nd7 24 Be3 Qc7 25 Nxd7 Bxd7 26 Red1 ½-½

I could have presented a more spectacular game but the point is to show how Black soaks up the pressure in such positions.

Game 15

□ Tiviakov ■ Adams

New York (3rd matchgame) 1994

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Nf3 Ngf6 6 Nxf6+ Nxf6 7 Bc4

7 Ne5 looks very aggressive but may just lead to further simplification. For example, 7...Nd7 and now:

a) 8 Nd3 g6 9 c3 Bg7 10 Bf4 Qa5! and Black will equalise by playing the move ...e7-e5, e.g. 11 Qd2 0-0 12 Be2 e5.

b) 8 Bf4 Nxe5 9 Bxe5 Qd5 10 c4 and now both 10...Qa5+ 11 Qd2 Qxd2+ 12 Kxd2 Bf5 13 Bd3 Bxd3 14 Kxd3 Rd8 15 Kc3 and 10...Qe4+ 11 Qe2 Bf5 12 Qxe4 Bxe4 13 f3 lead to fractionally better endgames for White.

If you prefer to keep a bit more life in the position then 7...Be6 followed by ...g7-g6 and ...Bg7 is a reasonable way to go about it.

7...Bf5

7...Bg4? just loses to 8 Bxf7+ Kxf7+ 9 Ne5+ followed by Nxg4. 8 Ne5 is

also tempting but Black is still kicking after 8...Qa5+ 9 Bd2 Qxe5+! 10 dxe5 Bxd1 11 Rxd1 Nd5.

8 Qe2

White prepares to castle queenside as there is simply not enough life in the position if he castles short.

8...e6 9 Bg5 Be7 10 0-0-0 Bg4

The knight might become a dangerous attacking piece so Black eliminates it.

11 Kb1 (Diagram 5)

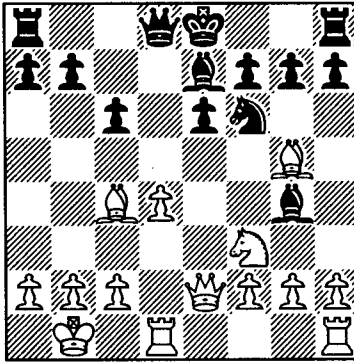


Diagram 5

Black should play ...b7-b5

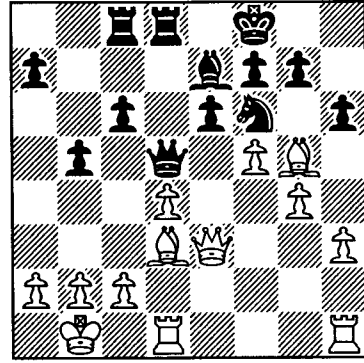


Diagram 6

Black provokes a reaction

11...0-0?!

An inaccuracy. It would have been better to play 11...b5 at once as 12 Bd3 allows 12...Qd5! followed by ...Bxf3 with an easy game for Black. To avoid this White would have to drop his bishop back to b3, but this would later become a target for Black's a-pawn.

12 h3 Bxf3 13 Qxf3 b5 14 Bd3 Qd5 15 Qe3!

White keeps the queens on as he plans to attack on the kingside.

15...Rac8 16 g4 Rfd8 17 f4 Kf8

Black doesn't fall for the oldest trick in the book: 17...Qxd4 18 Bxh7+ and 19 Rxd4. The text defends the bishop on f8 and introduces the possibility of taking on d4.

18 f5! h6?! (Diagram 6)

Black was reluctant to take on d4 because it opened the d-file (18...Qxd4 19 Qe2) but what he plays is even more dangerous for him.

19 Bxh6 Qxd4

This just leads to a totally lost position, although 19...gxh6 20 Qxh6+ Ke8 21 g5 is also excellent for White.

20 Bxg7+! Kxg7 21 Qg5+ Kf8 22 Qh6+ Ke8 23 fxe6

The black king, stuck in the middle with open lines all around it, has no hope to survive.

23...Bf8 24 exf7+ Ke7 25 Qg6 Rd5 26 c3 Qf4 27 Rhe1+ Re5 28 Qf5 1-0

A nice final move. White wins after 28...Qxf5 29 Bxf5 Rxe1 30 Rxe1+ Kd8 31 Bxc8 Kxc8 32 Re8+ .

5 Bc4: Introduction and 8 Bb3

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Bc4 Ngf6 6 Ng5 (Diagram 7)

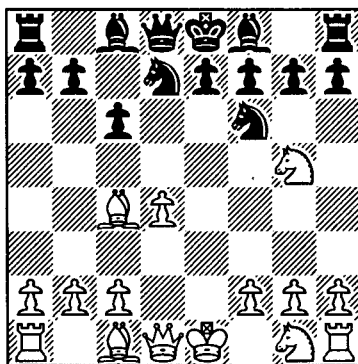


Diagram 7

White threatens 'the big one'

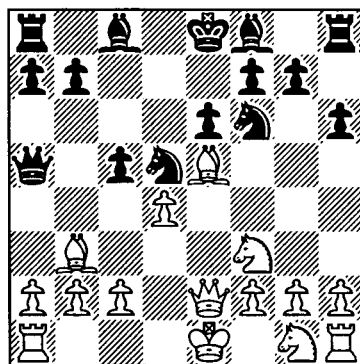


Diagram 8

An irritating check

White avoids simplification and threatens checkmate.

6...e6 7 Qe2

A key move in White's opening strategy. If instead he had just played 7 N1f3 then after 7...h6 he would have no choice but to retreat the knight to h3. After 7 Qe2 Black has to be careful as White is threatening a sacrifice on f7. For example, if Black carelessly plays 7...h6??, then 8 Nxf7! Kxf7 9 Qxe6+ Kg6 10 Bd3+ Kh5 11 Qh3 mate. To avoid such a scenario Black must ensure that his e6-pawn is protected.

7...Nb6

And this is the only sensible way to do it. It may look like Black is gaining time hitting the bishop but White may argue that the knight has just been lured away from d7 where it kept the e5 square under control. Often it will go back to d7 to challenge any white knight that lands on e5.

8 Bb3

Although the text has a large band of supporters, the alternative retreat 8 Bd3 is considered to be the main line. That is the subject of the next section.

8...h6 9 N5f3 c5

When the white bishop retreats to d3 the only plan for Black is to play ...c6-c5. When it retreats to b3 this is still the only plan but Black has the option of first harassing the bishop with his a-pawn. 9...a5, which is equally popular to the text, is covered in Game 16.

10 Bf4

10 dxc5 is well met by 10...Nbd7!. In contrast to the similar line after 8 Bd3, White doesn't even have the possibility to defend his pawn with b2-b4. Black should be able to equalise relatively easily here.

10 Be3 and 10 c3 also occur from time to time.

10...Nbd5

10...Bd6 has been under a small cloud since the game Kasparov-Karpov, Linares 1992. Game 17 has the details.

11 Be5 Qa5+! (Diagram 8) 12 Nd2

Black's check was extremely clever as, with 12 c3 failing to 12...Nxc3!, it forces White to make some sort of concession. White has the choice between exchanging queens (boring and harmless), moving his king (irritating) or retreating his knight. The latter is the lesser evil.

12...b5 13 dxc5

If White wants to spice it up then 13 c4!? is the way. Short-Speelman, Hastings 1988/89 continued 13...bxc4 14 Bxc4 Nb6 15 b4! Qxb4 16 Rb1 Qa5 17 Bb5 Bd7 18 Bxf6 gxf6 19 Ngf3 with attacking chances in return for the pawn. Black eventually won a tense struggle.

13...Bxc5

Black has a comfortable game. Anand-Ivanchuk, Wijk aan Zee 2001 continued 14 c3 Bb7 15 Ngf3 Qb6 16 0-0 0-0 17 Rfe1 a6 18 Rad1 Bd6 19 Bxd6 and a draw was agreed.

Theoretical?

Black should choose between 9...a5 and 9...c5 and do some work. No easy way out and general principles are not enough.

Statistics

Overall White has scored 58% with 8 Bb3. It's interesting that White scores much higher against 9...c5 (61%) than against 9...a5 (53%).

Game 16

□ Anand ■ Macieja

FIDE World Championship, New Delhi 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Bc4 Ngf6 6 Ng5 e6 7 Qe2 Nb6 8 Bb3 h6 9 N5f3 a5!? (Diagram 9)

Many players consider this to be a useful precursor to playing ...c6-c5. White is now forced to weaken his queenside, and if nothing else this will make queenside castling less attractive.

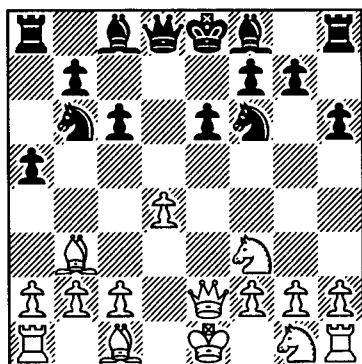


Diagram 9

a3 or a4? That is the question

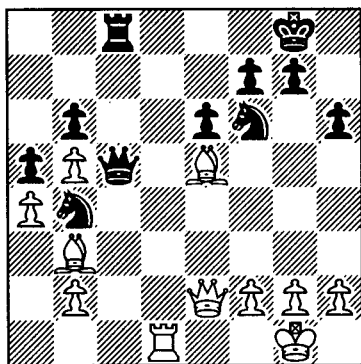


Diagram 10

Black doesn't see the danger

10 a4

Don't expect me to give you an easy answer on whether White should play a3 or a4 in such positions. I can never decide myself. In this particular position, if really pushed, I would opt for 10 a4.

After 10 a3 a4 11 Ba2 c5 White can't make up his mind between 12 c3, 12 dxc5, 12 Bf4 and 12 Be3. They all seem to lead to roughly balanced games.

10...c5 11 Bf4 Bd6

11...Nbd5 12 Be5, the main line with the a-pawns unmoved, is not so good for Black anymore as he no longer has the possibility of a disruptive check with his queen.

12 Ne5

This position should also be compared to the next game where White played Bg3 followed by 0-0-0. This time he opts for a different plan as castling queenside with his pawn on a4 would be very risky.

12...0-0 13 Ngf3 Nbd5 14 Bg3 Qc7 15 dxc5 Qxc5 16 0-0 b6 17 Rfd1 Ba6 18 c4 Rad8 19 Nd4!

So far the two players had been following a blindfold game between Anand and Karpov. White blundered a pawn in this game with 19 Nd3? Bxc4! 20 Rac1 Bxd3 21 Qxd3, overlooking the riposte 21...Nf4!. The text is a rather obvious improvement. Black now decides to relieve some of the pressure by giving up the bishop pair but this leaves him with a permanent disadvantage.

19...Bxe5 20 Bxe5 Nb4 21 Nb5 Bxb5 22 cxb5 Rxd1+ 23 Rxd1 Rc8? (Diagram 10)

A most generous invitation to attack the king! Instead, Black should have played 23...Nbd5 when he retains a solid but inferior position.

24 Bxf6 gxf6 25 Bxe6! fxe6

The alternative is a hopeless endgame after 25...Re8 26 Qg4+ Qg5 27 f4! Qxg4 28 Bxg4.

26 Qxe6+ Kh8

White is also winning after 26...Kg7 27 Rd7+ Kg6 28 Qf7+ Kf5 29 Qh7+! Ke6 30 g4!.

27 Qxf6+ Kg8 28 Qe6+ Kh8 29 Qxh6+ Kg8 30 Qe6+ Kh8 31 h3!

Now that his king has a flight square, White is ready to bring his rook into the attack. In order to have survival chances in such a position Black would need his knight in the vicinity of his king. That is obviously not the case here.

31...Rf8 32 Qh6+ Kg8 33 Qg6+ Kh8 34 Qg3! Qc2 35 Rd4 1-0

Game 17

□ J. Polgar ■ Epishin

Geneva 1996

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Bc4 Ngf6 6 Ng5 e6 7 Qe2 Nb6 8 Bb3 h6 9 N5f3 c5 10 Bf4 Bd6 11 Bg3!

White doesn't mind the bishops being exchanged as long as the exchange takes place on g3 and an open h-file materialises.

11...Qc7

As was mentioned above, this line has been under a cloud since the game Kasparov-Karpov, Linares 1992. That had gone 11...Qe7 12 dxc5 Bxc5 13 Ne5 Bd7 14 Ngf3 Nh5 15 0-0-0 Nxd3 16 hxd3 0-0-0 17 Rh5! and the active rook caused Black all sorts of problems (the immediate threat is 18 Nxf7).

12 dxc5 Qxc5 13 0-0-0 Bxg3 14 hxg3 Bd7 15 Rh4 (Diagram 11)

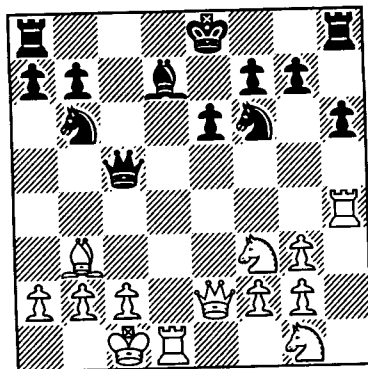


Diagram 11

The white rook is a 'swinger'

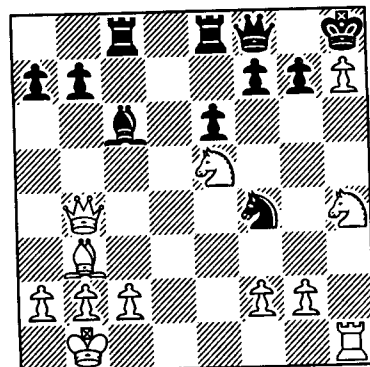


Diagram 12

An offer Black must refuse

Judit Polgar was obviously familiar with the Kasparov-Karpov game and decides to activate her rook in a similar fashion.



TIP: People often talk about rooks and open files but sometimes forget about the strength of a rook on an open rank!

15...Rc8 16 Ne5 Bb5 17 Qe1 0-0 18 Ngf3 Nbd5

Around this point the position is probably not too bad for Black but he soon starts to drift into a precarious situation.

19 Kb1 Bc6 20 Qd2 Rfe8 21 Rdh1 Qf8 22 g4!

The black queen had rushed back to defend against a rook sacrifice on h6 but now White is going to simply open the h-file.

22...Ne4 23 Qe1 Nd6 24 g5 Nf5 25 gxh6! Nxh4 26 h7+ Kh8 27 Nxh4 Nf4

Black defends against the mate in two but gets hit by a thunderbolt.

28 Qb4!! (Diagram 12)

Such deflection sacrifices are always a delight even when they are not very complex. Here 28...Qxb4 loses to 29 Nhg6+ Nxe6 30 Nxf7 mate. Meanwhile, White threatens to take the knight on f4 and it can't move because of mate on g6.

28...g5 29 Qd4 Kg7 30 Nf5+ exf5 31 h8Q+ Qxh8 32 Nxf7+ 1-0

It's checkmate in a few moves.

5 Bc4: Main Line with 8 Bd3

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Bc4 Ngf6 6 Ng5 e6 7 Qe2 Nb6 8 Bd3 h6

It's much too risky to play 8...Qxd4?! as after 9 N1f3 Qd5 10 Ne5 the f7 pawn drops.

9 N5f3

If this knight were to hang around here for any length of time then he might have some explaining to do to his mate on g1. However, he is not planning to do that and is merely in transit to e5 after which his colleague will be able to support him with Ngf3.

9...c5

The thematic freeing move that Black needs to play to gain some space for his pieces.

10 dxc5

Over the years this has been White's most popular choice. True, it does help Black to develop his kingside, but on the other hand it also allows White to improve the position of his own knights without further delay. The alternative, 10 Be3, is considered in Game 18.

10...Bxc5

It is surprising that the pawn sacrifice 10...Nbd7!? is not played more often. After 11 b4 (11 Ne5 is played sometimes but the game is level after 11...Nxe5 12 Qxe5 Nd7 and 13... Nxc5) 11...Nd5 12 Bd2 Qf6 (12...a5!?) 13 Rb1 a5 14 a3 g5 Black has a strong central position in

return for his pawn. The critical continuation is now 15 Be4.

11 Ne5

At one point the plan of 11 Bd2 and 12 0-0-0 was considered to be very dangerous for Black. Then a new idea from Michael Adams forced the theoreticians to revise this view – see Game 19.

11...Nbd7

The knight returns to contest White's control of e5.

12 Ngf3 Qc7

More accurate than the old main line 12...Nxe5 13 Nxe5 0-0, when both 14 Bd2 followed by 14 0-0-0 and 14 0-0 b6 15 b4! are quite dangerous for Black.

13 Bf4 Bb4+! (Diagram 13)

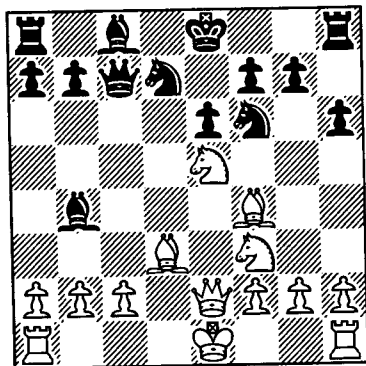


Diagram 13

White must make a choice

This check proves surprisingly awkward for White to deal with and is the move that is chiefly responsible for this variation's decline in popularity. Let's take a look at White's options.

- 14 c3? just fails to 14...Bxc3+ 15 bxc3 Qxc3+ and the rook on a1 drops off.
- 14 Kf1 is better but after 14...Bd6 White will have to lose time getting his king's rook into play. Black has a comfortable game.
- 14 Nd2 is the only real try for an advantage, even if after 14...Bxd2+ White must recapture with the king. He then has the long-term advantage of the bishop pair but the short-term disadvantage of having to secure his king position before the black rooks get active. Practice suggests the position is about level.

Theoretical?

If you check the statistics below, White scores well in this line but

this is only because quite a few Black players are playing the opening inaccurately. Black has to study theory in this line. How else are you going to find moves like 13...Bb4+?

Statistics

With 8 Bd3 White has scored 58% from around 850 games. This is the same score as with 8 Bb3. Looking in a little more detail, White has just scored 51% with 10 Be3 (Game 18) and 54% in the main line position after 13...Bb4+.

Game 18

□ Hector ■ Akesson

Stockholm 2001/02

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Bc4 Ngf6 6 Ng5 e6 7 Qe2 Nb6 8 Bd3 h6 9 N5f3 c5 10 Be3!?

A good developing move, but one which has always played second fiddle to 10 dxc5. The main reason for this is that white players don't feel comfortable playing with their knights on g1 and f3 any longer than is necessary.

10...Nbd5

Black usually plays a combination of ...Nbd5, ...a7-a6 (to prevent a potentially annoying check on b5) and ...Qc7 over his next few moves. It is not clear what the best move order is.

11 Ne5 a6

Black is in no rush to take the bishop on e3 as after the pawn recapture 12 fxe3 White's centre has been strengthened and the f-file opened.

12 Ngf3 Qc7 13 0-0 Bd6! 14 Nc4 Be7 15 dxc5 Bxc5 16 Bxc5 Qxc5 (Diagram 14)

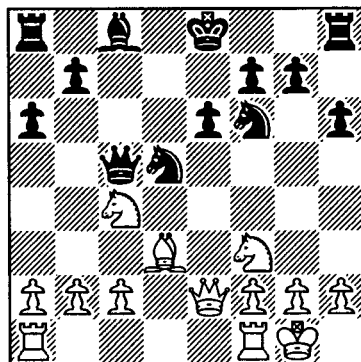


Diagram 14
Equal but unbalanced

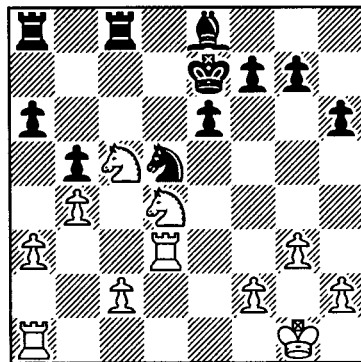


Diagram 15
Black can strike on the queenside



NOTE: A typical position from the ...Nd7 Caro-Kann. White has the initiative but Black is very solid. The pawn structure is interesting. White's 3-2 majority on the queenside could prove dangerous if the pawns become mobile while Black's 1-0 advantage in the centre gives him more control in this sector of the board. The unbalanced nature of the position means that it is perfectly possible to play for a win with either colour.

This was, in fact, not the first time Hector had reached this position. Previously he had played 17 Qe5 but, having lost to Speelman with this move, he decided it was time for a change. What will he do next time?

17 Nfe5 0-0 18 a3 b5 19 Nd2 Nf4 20 Qf3 Nxd3 21 Nxd3 Qd5 22 Qxd5 Nxd5 23 Nc5 Rd8 24 Rfd1 Kf8 25 Nf3 Bd7 26 Nd4 Ke7 27 Rd3 Be8 28 g3 Rdc8

White's only real trump in this endgame had been the strong position of his knight on c5. Through careful defensive play Black has managed to minimise the effect of this piece and after Black's last move it was time for the knight to retreat and for White to accept he has no advantage. Unfortunately (on this occasion), that is not Hector's style.

29 b4? (Diagram 15) 29...a5!

Now White is in trouble because of the potential pin on the a-file. He would like to play 30 Rb1 but then 30...axb4 31 axb4 Nxb4! wins a pawn. Instead he feels obliged to go in for some doubtful complications, but after the star move 32...axb4! it is apparent that they have failed.

30 Nf5+ Kf8! 31 Nd6 Rc6 32 Nxe8 axb4! 33 Nb3 Kxe8 34 Re1 Kf8 35 Nd4 Rc4 36 Nxb5 Rc5 37 Nd4 bxa3 38 Rf3 Kg8 39 Ra1 a2 40 Rb3 Rc4 0-1

Game 19

□ Kir.Georgiev ■ Adams

Groningen 1993

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Bc4 Ngf6 6 Ng5 e6 7 Qe2 Nb6 8 Bd3 h6 9 N5f3 c5 10 dxc5 Bxc5 11 Bd2

An aggressive continuation. White prepares to castle queenside and then launch a kingside attack.

11...0-0 12 0-0-0 Na4! (Diagram 16)

But after this move his own king will be the first to come under fire. Prior to this game Black usually played 12...Qc7 to evacuate his queen from the same open file as white's rook. However, Adams shows that the threats on the d-file are not so serious that Black hasn't got time for 12...Na4 followed by the more active deployment of his queen.

13 Bb5 Bd7 14 Bxd7

Here are a few key variations:

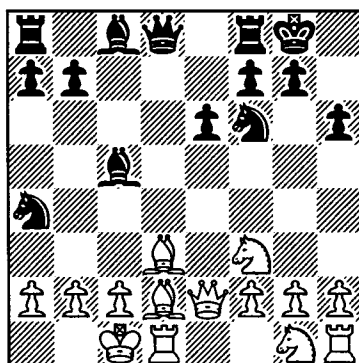


Diagram 16
An important novelty

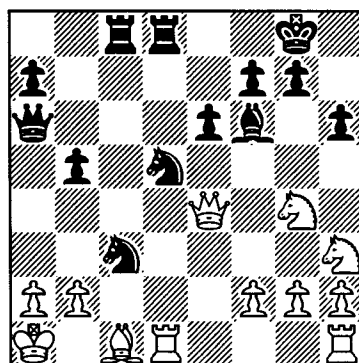


Diagram 17
Black has a winning attack

a) 14 Bxa4 Bxa4 15 Bxh6 wins a pawn because of the discovered attack on the black queen. However after something like 15...Nd5 16 Bg5 Qb6 Black has excellent attacking chances against the white king.

b) 14 Bxh6 at once is also playable because after 14...gxh6 15 Bxa4 Black cannot recapture because of the pin on the d-file. Instead, he should counter-sacrifice with 14...Nxb2!.

c) On 14 Ne5 Black has a choice between the complications of 14...Nxb2!? or simplifying with 14...Bxb5 15 Qxb5 Qe8! The latter position is about equal.

14...Qxd7 15 Nh3?!

And why not the obvious 15 Bxh6 here? Well, Black just calmly moves his queen (15...Qc7 or 15...Qc6) and then starts to create threats on the queenside. The white king does not have much protection. Georgiev prefers to get his kingside pieces out rather than wasting time taking a pawn but he ends up facing an attack without anything to show for it. 15 Ne5 Qc7 16 Nd3 is a better way to try and shore up his defences.

15...Rac8 16 Kb1 Qc6 17 Bc1 Nd5

Threatening to win the white queen.

18 Qc4 Rfd8 19 Ka1 b5! 20 Qe4 Be7 21 c3 Qa6 22 Ne5 Bf6 23 Ng4?

Perhaps White though he was going to take the bishop on f6 with check, but allowing this beast even the merest glimpse of the queenside is fatal. He should have played 23 f4.

23...Naxc3! (Diagram 17) 24 bxc3

There is no time for 24 Nxf6+ Nxf6 as then White loses his king or his queen.

24...Bxc3+ 25 Bb2 Rc4 26 Qf3 Bxb2+ 27 Kxb2 Rc2+!

An elegant finale.

28 Kxc2 Qxa2+ 29 Kd3 Qc4+ 0-1

After 30 Kd2 Nb4+ both 31 Ke3 and 31 Ke1 are met by 31...Nc2 mate.

Summary

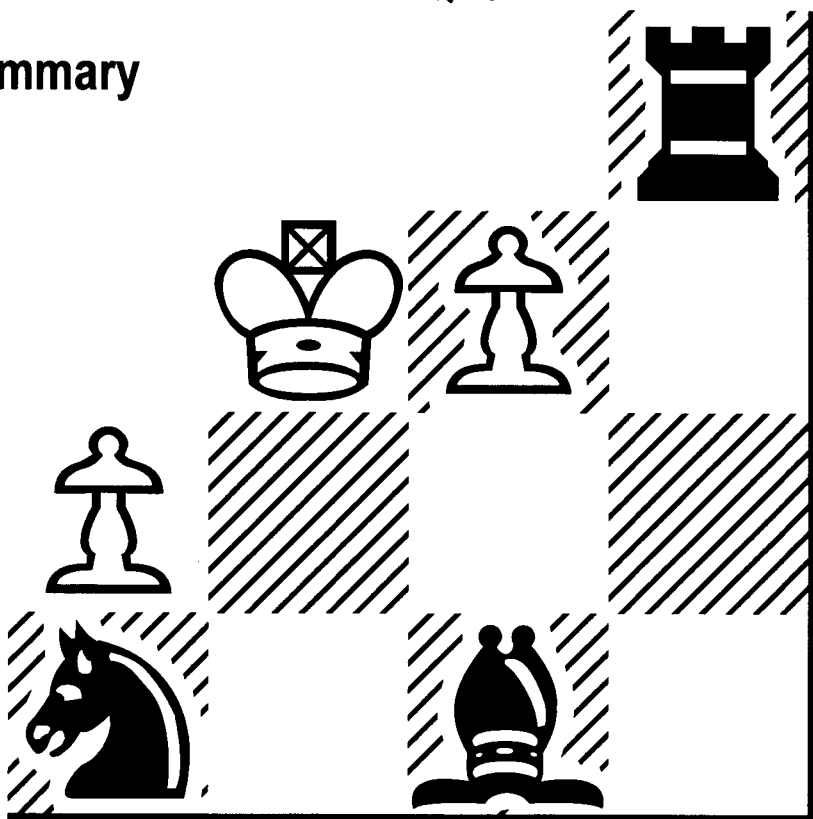
1) After the calm 5 Nf3 it is more promising for White to follow up with 6 Ng3 than 6 Nxf6+. He has more space and should keep as many pieces as possible on the board.

2) The lines with 5 Bc4 are not as popular as they used to be and if he knows his stuff Black can equalise whether White plays with 8 Bb3 or 8 Bd3.

Chapter Four

4...Nd7 5 Ng5

-  Introduction
-  Early Deviations
-  The Main Line after 10 Qxe4
-  Summary



Introduction

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 (Diagram 1)

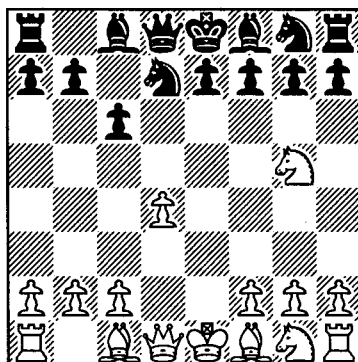


Diagram 1

White has a busy knight

This variation exploded on to the chess scene in the mid-1980s after a couple of sensational wins by Efim Geller and Mikhail Tal. For a while the general feeling was that the ...Nd7 Caro was on its deathbed. However, as is often the case, once the initial shock wore off, the variation began to slowly recover. The drubbings became less frequent and black players gradually began to work out a system of development where White couldn't sacrifice anything. Soon things were back to normal and Ng5 was just another variation where White might have an edge but Black has a resilient position with counter-chances. That is where the variation remains today.

In the first section below we shall examine all the deviations from the main line. This section makes pretty grim reading for Black and contains many of his early disasters, and one more recent disaster by a World Champion who should have known better.

The second section deals with the main line. This is a carefully worked out sequence which takes Black to about move 10 before he has to start thinking for himself.

Early Deviations

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 Ngf6

The first goal for Black in this line is quite simple: to drive away the irritating knight on g5. To do this he has to play ...h7-h6 but this has the drawback of weakening g6, an important square in the vicinity of his king. That means that after ...h7-h6 White may be able to play a dangerous sacrifice on e6 or f7 that would not have been available to

him with the black pawn still on h7. After some painful experiences Black eventually worked out a scheme of development that avoided all the dangerous sacrifices. That is the main line and the subject of the next section. Here we shall look at the early deviations, quite a few of them involving Black playing an inappropriate ...h7-h6 and getting punished for it. The alternatives to 5...Ngf6 are dealt with in the following manner:

Game 20 deals with 5...h6?.

Game 21 deals with 5...Ndf6.

Game 22 deals with 5...e6.

6 Bd3

In fact it is only after this move that the variation really becomes independent as 6 Bc4 just transposes to the previous chapter.

6...e6

The most solid and obvious move. Black prepares to develop his kingside. 6...h6 is discussed in Game 23.

7 N1f3 Bd6

7...Be7 is less active and also leaves Black more exposed to sacrificial attacks (even the immediate 8 Nxf7 is interesting) What about 7...h6? here. Can Black get away with attacking the knight yet? Game 24, one of the most famous chess games of recent times, has the details.

8 Qe2

This is considered more accurate than 8 0-0 as after the sequence 8...h6 9 Ne4 Nxe4 White would like to be able to recapture with the queen. That gives him, in certain lines, the option of playing Qg4 to attack the black kingside. After 8 0-0 h6 9 Ne4 Nxe4 10 Bxe4 Black's best plan is probably to play 10...Qc7 followed by ...b7-b6, ...Bb7 and ...0-0-0.

8...h6! (Diagram 2)

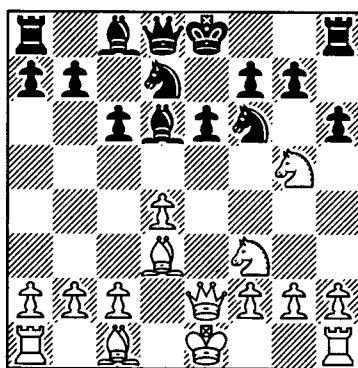


Diagram 2

It's safe to play ...h7-h6

Finally Black gets to attack the knight without having to face serious repercussions. And he should make sure that he doesn't miss the boat as 8...0-0? runs into 9 Nxe6 fxe6 10 Qxe6+ and 11 Qxd6. True, Black can play 9...Bb4+ but the position after 10 c3 is still good for White.

9 Ne4 Nxe4 10 Qxe4

This is the main line and it is covered in the next section.

Theoretical?

The vast majority of lines in this section don't have to be learnt by Black although it is useful for him to know what can happen if he strays from the beaten track. Don't touch your h-pawn before move 8 and you should be all right.

Statistics

With 5...e6 and 5...Ndf6 Black has managed just over 40%. This is a much better score than Black gets if he allows the piece sacrifice Kasparov did in Game 5. Then he only manages a miserable 30%.

Game 20

□ Nunn ■ Kir.Georgiev

Linares 1988

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 h6?! 6 Ne6! (Diagram 3)

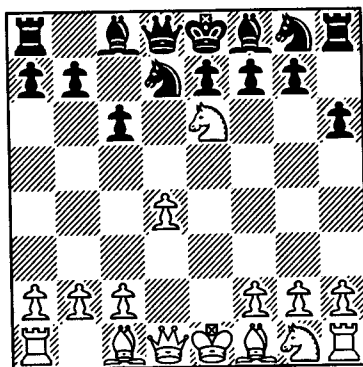


Diagram 3

White springs the main trick

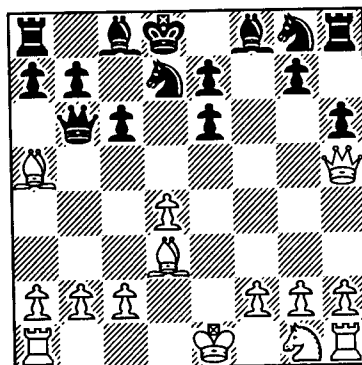


Diagram 4

White pins and wins

Now Kiril Georgiev is a very strong player and he knew the knight wasn't going to run away when he attacked it. So why did he do it? Well, he probably thought that White would just end up taking the bishop on f8 and emerging from the opening with no more than a slight pull. And maybe this is what should have happened.

6...Qa5+

I hope that you have spotted the variation 6...fxe6?? 7 Qh5+ and mate next move. However, the immediate 6...Qb6 might be a slight improvement. Did Black really force White to develop his bishop to d2 because he was thinking of grabbing the b-pawn? Anyway, he soon regrets his decision, while after 6...Qb6 White can choose between 7 Nxf8 or speculate à la Tal (see Game 23) with 7 Bd3.

7 Bd2 Qb6 8 Bd3! fxe6??

Oh dear! If we don't count time trouble this is probably one of the worst blunders ever made by a 2600+ grandmaster. Anything else is better.

9 Qh5+ Kd8 10 Ba5! (Diagram 4)

Yes, that's right. Black loses his queen. For some reason Georgiev continued till move 42 but I'll spare you the rest.

Game 21

□ Nunn ■ Tal

Brussels 1988

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 Ndf6

In the early days of this variation Black couldn't make up his mind which knight to play to f6 but after this game most players gave up on 5...Ndf6.

6 N1f3 e6

The solid but passive 6...Bg4 7 h3 Bxf3 8 Nxf3 e6 is probably the best Black can do after his 5th move.

Note that 6...h6? is still bad as 7 Nxf7! Kxf7 8 Ne5+ Ke8 9 Bd3 leaves Black facing a fearsome attack.

7 Ne5 (Diagram 5)

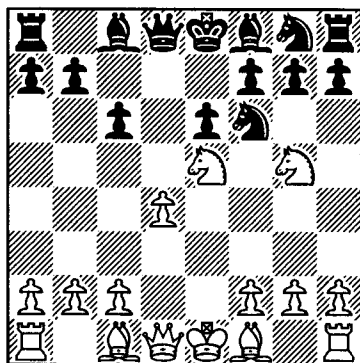


Diagram 5
White targets the f7-pawn

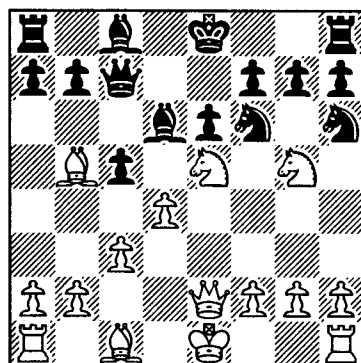


Diagram 6
A nasty check

7...Nh6 8 Bd3 Bd6

Black avoids 8...Qxd4 because of 9 Ngxf7! Nxf7 10 Nxf7, when he can't play 10...Kxf7 because 11 Bg6+ wins the queen.

9 c3 Qc7 10 Qe2 c5

This gets Black into trouble but his whole set-up is very suspicious. He would like to castle kingside but is too scared to do so. White would just play Ngf3 and follow up with g2-g4. It is unlikely that Black would survive long.

11 Bb5+! (Diagram 6) 11...Ke7

No choice as 11...Bd7 invites all kinds of sacrifices. The most accurate according to Nunn is 12 Bxd7+ Nxd7 13 Nxf7!.

12 0-0 cxd4 13 cxd4 Nf5 14 Be3 Nxe3 15 fxe3?

15 Qxe3 was the better choice, when Black would have been left facing a powerful attack.

15...Bxe5 16 dxe5 Qxe5 17 Qd3 Qxg5?

Black misses a chance. After 17...a6! 18 Qa3+ Qd6 19 Qxd6+ Kxd6 20 Nxf7+ Ke7 21 Nxh8 axb5 he escapes to an ending with good chances to hold the game.

18 Qa3+ Kd8 19 Rad1+ Bd7 20 Bxd7 1-0

Black resigned because 20...Nxd7 21 Rxf7 Qb5 22 Qd6 leads to mate and other variations are almost as bad.

Game 22

□ J.Polgar ■ Seirawan

Bali 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 e6

This, a speciality of the American Grandmaster Yasser Seirawan, is the most solid of the 5th move alternatives available to Black. In fact, it is probably the only fully viable alternative to the main line.

6 Bd3 Be7 7 N1f3 h6 8 Ne4

8 Nxe6?! fxe6 9 Bg6+ Kf8 doesn't look quite good enough here.



TIP: The sacrifice on e6 is usually insufficient if the black king can go to f8 as there it doesn't interfere so much with the rest of Black's pieces. If the king has to go to e7, then it is a different story.

8...Ngf6 9 Nxf6+

9 c3 and 9 Qe2 are reasonable alternatives.

9...Bxf6

The correct way to recapture. The black knight remains on d7, from where it keeps e5 under control and facilitates the advance ...c6-c5.

10 0-0 b6

Seirawan takes it nice and easy. He only wants to play ...c6-c5 once he has mobilised his forces.

11 Bf4 Bb7 12 Be4

White tries to prevent ...c6-c5 but he can't do so in the long run. There is an argument, then, for just playing 12 Qe2 in order to keep the position more complicated once the inevitable ...c5 is achieved.

12...Qc8! (Diagram 7)

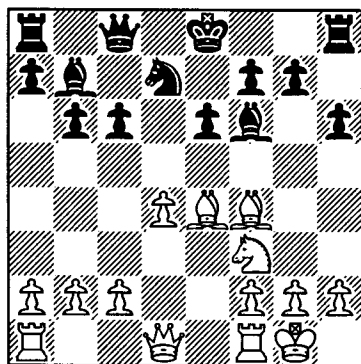


Diagram 7

Black prepares ...c6-c5

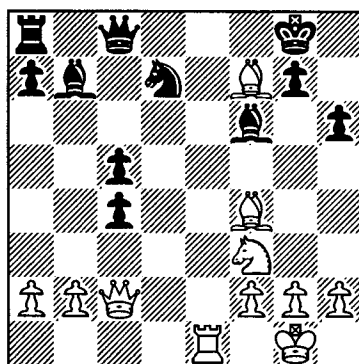


Diagram 8

Forcing a perpetual check

13 Qe2

Are you wondering why White didn't play 13 Bd6 to prevent Black from castling? Well, this was tried in Ivanov-Seirawan, US Championship 2000, just a few months after the Polgar game. Seirawan just played the calm 13...Be7, not fearing 14 Bxe7 Kxe7 as White is in no position to launch an attack. In fact the game was drawn very quickly after the further moves 15 Ne5 c5 16 Qf3 Nxe5 17 dxe5 Bxe4 18 Qxe4 Qc7 19 Rad1 ½-½.

13...0-0 14 c4 c5 15 d5

15 Bxb7 Qxb7 is just dead level so Polgar makes an attempt to complicate the game.

15...exd5 16 Bxd5 Re8 17 Qc2 b5!? 18 Rae1 Rxe1 19 Rxe1 bxc4 20 Bxf7+!? (Diagram 8)

But suddenly she has a change of heart and forces a draw.

20...Kxf7 21 Qxc4+ Kg6 22 Qd3+ Kf7 23 Qc4+ ½-½

Game 23

□ Tal ■ Oll

USSR 1986

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Bd3 Ngf6 6 Ng5 h6?!

We continue our theme of mistimed ...h6's. This game, or segment of a game, is important for the history of this variation, as it was one of the two games (the other was Geller-Meduna) that catapulted it into the public imagination.

7 Ne6! Qa5+ 8 Bd2 Qb6 9 Nf3!? (Diagram 9)

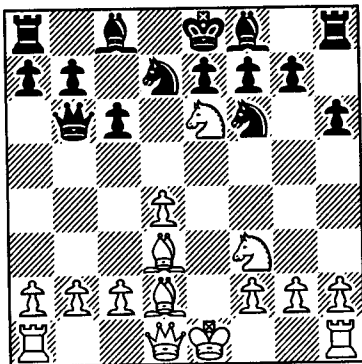


Diagram 9
Take my knight!

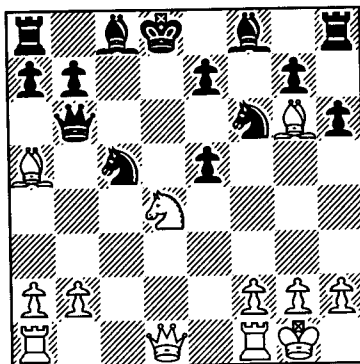


Diagram 10
Ba5 wins again!

9 Nxf8 is, of course, a safe edge for White but one would have been extremely disappointed if the genius of attack had played like that. The position is of course the same as in Game 20 except for the fact that the king knights are developed. That means that Black can take the knight and get to keep his queen. Well, for a few moves at least.

9...fxe6 10 Bg6+ Kd8 11 0-0

This is quite a remarkable position. White doesn't even have a pawn for the piece and the black king is in no particular danger, yet over the next few moves Lembit Oll, who was an extremely strong grandmaster, plays like a man in desperate trouble. Why did he voluntarily open the centre and expose his king to attack? The answer can be found, above all, on the kingside. Just look at that bishop on f8. How on earth is it going to get out? And if that can't get out what about the rook on h8. I almost called these pieces spectators but on reflection they are not even at the game. That is why Oll now made a desperate bid for freedom before White could complete his development and secure a total bind on the position.

11...c5 12 c4 cxd4 13 Nxd4! e5

13...Qxd4 14 Ba5+.

14 c5!

Tal could have won the queen at once with 14 Ba5 (14...Qxa5 15 Ne6 mate) but the text is even stronger as it opens the c-file.

14...Nxc5

14...Qxc5 obviously allows 15 Ne6 mate, while 14...Qa6 15 Ba5+! b6 16 Ne6 mate is not an improvement.

15 Ba5! (Diagram 10)

Unfortunately there are no further moves available for the game. Anyway, White has an overwhelming advantage after 15...exd4 16

Qxd4+ Nfd7 17 Bxb6+ axb6 18 Rfd1. Quite often three minor pieces are a good match for the queen but not in a position like this.

Game 24

□ **DEEP BLUE** ■ **Kasparov**

New York (6th matchgame) 1997

Deep Blue was a silicon monster created by IBM. Kasparov had been the reigning champion of the world for 12 years. This was the final, decisive encounter in a six game match (the score tied at 2½-2½) where Kasparov had been portrayed by the mass media as the defender of humanity.

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7

Kasparov chooses the solid Caro-Kann. A sensible choice if he is trying to avoid defeat.

5 Ng5 Ngf6 6 Bd3 e6 7 N1f3 h6?!

But what is this? Incredible! No-one could quite believe that Kasparov would dare to play this variation which, for over a decade, had been known to be fraught with danger for Black. Afterwards Kasparov struggled to explain himself. To some people he said it was a slip of the hand – he had been intending to play the main line with 7...Bd6 and 8...h6 but got his moves in the wrong order. That is hard to believe and would certainly be a tad careless whilst defending humanity. A second explanation was that he didn't believe the machine would sacrifice as he had some information that it had been programmed to play the boring 8 Ne4. Did somebody set him up?

8 Nxe6!

If the second explanation is true then this must have come as a shock.

8...Qe7?!

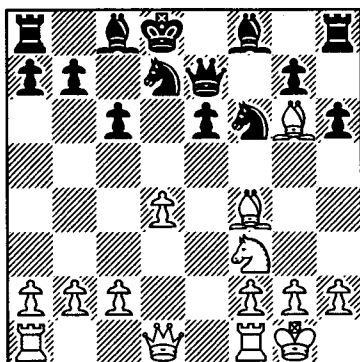
I think this move is the proof that Kasparov didn't expect to reach this position. Black has lost virtually every game he has played with this move. It was quite well known that 8...fxe6 9 Bg6+ Ke7 10 0-0 Qc7 followed by ...Kd8 offers a better chance of a successful defence (although not enough to actually want to play this line with Black).

9 0-0 fxe6

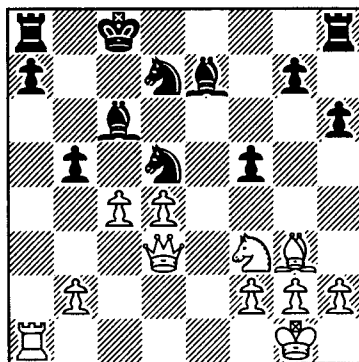
Of course 9...Qxe6 10 Re1 costs Black his queen.

10 Bg6+ Kd8 11 Bf4 (Diagram 11)

There is a certain type of player who might not mind grovelling around with Black in such a position. Some people are willing to suffer horrendously for even small amounts of material. Kasparov is not one of them. He always strives for the initiative, he sacrifices material to obtain it and he simply doesn't play positions like this. In reality Black's game, with his horrible pawn structure, clumsy pieces and misplaced king, is just a nightmare. Kasparov's next move, which was designed to prevent White taking total control of the centre with c2-c4, presents White with a target to open lines on the queenside.

**Diagram 11**

The suffering begins

**Diagram 12**

Defeat for mankind

11...b5 12 a4! Bb7 13 Re1 Nd5 14 Bg3 Kc8 15 axb5 cxb5 16 Qd3 Bc6 17 Bf5! exf5

Kasparov gives up his queen as he knows that if e6 drops the white pieces will soon be all over him.

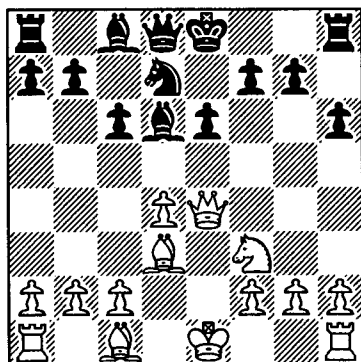
18 Rxe7 Bxe7 19 c4 1-0 (Diagram 12)

A slightly premature resignation, perhaps, but there is no way back against a machine that sees everything in open tactical positions. The pieces have no hope against the queen in such a position.

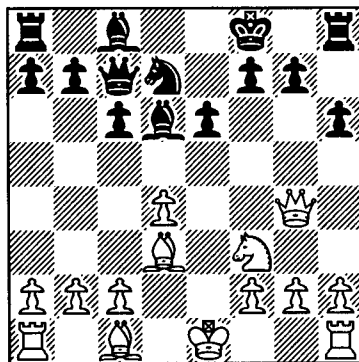
History was made but life continued.

The Main Line after 10 Qxe4

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 Ngf6 6 Bd3 e6 7 N1f3 Bd6 8 Qe2 h6 9 Ne4 Nxe4 10 Qxe4 (Diagram 13)

**Diagram 13**

Black has survived the opening

**Diagram 14**

Black loses his castling rights

The first thing to say about this section is that, for those of you playing Black, you have done well just to get here unscathed. You have already, unlike Garry Kasparov, successfully negotiated all the pitfalls of the previous section. The position after 10 Qxe4 has become the main battleground in the ...Nd7 Caro-Kann. Black has managed to exchange off one pair of minor pieces, which is good news in his more cramped position. His objectives are the standard ones in this line. Get his king to relative safety and free his game with ...c6-c5.

10...Qc7

The most obvious choice is 10...Nf6, a move which appears to improve the position of the knight whilst gaining time hitting the white queen. Well, appearances can be deceptive. 10...Nf6 did indeed used to be the main line but after some rather depressing results most Black players have switched to 10...Qc7. The problem with ...Nf6 is that it cedes control of e5 and allows White to establish a powerful knight on this square. True, Black can take the knight but other problems will arise after White replies dxe5. No, the best cure is prevention and by resisting the temptation to attack the white queen, Black should be able to keep the white knight out of e5. That is not to say that the variations after 10...Nf6 are not complex and important. They are both of these and it is examined in Games 25 and 26.

10...Qc7 has the advantage of increasing Black's control over e5 and Black will usually follow up with ...b7-b6, ...Bb7 and ...c6-c5, though not necessarily in that order. He would like to castle queenside but this ambition is rarely achieved.

11 Qg4

This is the obvious way to exploit Black's omission of ...Nf6. There is no particularly comfortable way for Black to defend his g-pawn. Quieter continuations such as 11 0-0 or 11 Bd2 are usually met by 11...b6. White has had some success with 11 0-0 b6 12 Qg4, and Black should probably play 12...g5 now as he has more play than in the variations below where White's king was still in the centre.

11...Kf8 (Diagram 14)

Obviously it is a concession to forgo one's castling rights but most Black players judge this to be the lesser evil. What are the other possibilities then? Well, firstly 11...0-0 and 11...g6 can be dismissed because of the respective replies 12 Bxh6 and 12 Bxg6. 11...Bf8 is unthinkable so that just leaves 11...g5 and 11...Rg8. These two moves have actually been tried against Kasparov by other elite players:

a) 11...g5 takes control of quite a few squares around the black queen and threatens to win material with ...Nf6 followed by ...g5-g4. However, by beating an immediate retreat White can leave Black regretting his rash advance on the kingside. After 12 Qh3! (threatening to take on g5) 12...Rg8 13 Nd2! (and not 13 Qxh6?? Bf8) White has an excellent game. The knight will re-emerge on e4 or c4 and Black's

kingside pawns are simply a target for White to attack. White won convincingly in Kasparov-Kamsky, Linares 1994.

b) 11...Rg8 is a more solid alternative, first seen in Kasparov-Anand, Linares 1998. It keeps open the important possibility of castling queenside. White can win a pawn with 12 Bxh6 but it is more trouble than it is worth after 12...Nf6. Kasparov settled on a similar plan to the one he used against Kamsky and played 12 Nd2 Nf6 13 Qf3 although after 13...e5 14 dxe5 Bxe5 15 Nc4 Be6 White's advantage was only minimal. Instead, 13 Qe2 would have prevented the freeing move ...e6-e5. Kasparov thought that Black would meet this with 13...c5 but this should still be an edge for White.

12 0-0

12 Bd2 and 12 Be3, with the idea of castling queenside, are also played from time to time but there is no need for the king to give added impetus to Black's queenside counterplay.

12...c5 13 c3

13 b3 is an attempt to maximise the power of White's dark squared bishop. This would be played more often if it wasn't for the response 13...cxd4 14 Qxd4 Ne5 when White has a few problems on the long diagonal. He should now avoid 15 Nxe5 Bxe5 as although 16 Qb4+ saves material it leaves the White army rather uncoordinated. It is better to play 15 Bb2!, accepting the destruction of the kingside pawn structure after 15...Nxf3+ 16 gxf3 as in return White has active pieces. This latter variation all occurred in Leko-Karpov, Linares 2001. Karpov drew reasonably comfortably but when he had to face this variation recently (Topalov-Karpov, Cannes 2002) he switched to 13...e5 and lost.

Note that the move order 13 Re1 b6 14 c3, just transposing back into the main line, is often used.

13...b6 14 Re1

14 Qh4 used to be the main line but Black has made an important new discovery there – see Game 27.

14...Bb7

This position is usually assessed as level by most theoretical sources. This may be true but by pushing his h-pawn White can at least create some problems for Black to solve. Game 28 has the details.

Theoretical?

Yes, this is quite a theoretical line. Considering how much theory you have to know just to get to this chapter you may as well go the extra mile and learn it properly.

Statistics

From the diagram position White has scored a very healthy 59% from

over 800 games. If you just take the line with 10...Nf6 then the White score is an even healthier 62%. With 10...Qc7, though, things improve for Black. White scores only 55% as a whole and in the real main line after 11 Qg4 Kf8 12 0-0 c5 White can only manage 46% from 100 games.

Game 25

□ Hector ■ Olsen

Copenhagen 1998

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 Ngf6 6 Bd3 e6 7 N1f3 Bd6 8 Qe2 h6 9 Ne4 Nxe4 10 Qxe4 Nf6 11 Qh4 Ke7!? (Diagram 15)

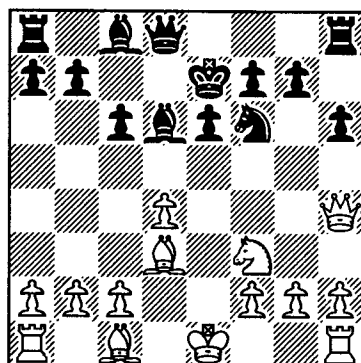


Diagram 15

Do not adjust your chess set

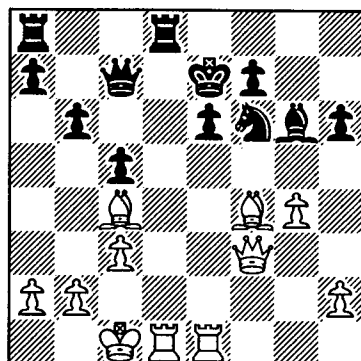


Diagram 16

Black has no defence

Quite a shocking move. At first sight one gets the impression that Black touched his king by mistake and was forced to move it (11...0-0 would simply be begging for a sacrifice on h6). A closer inspection, however, will reveal the reason behind this amazing move of Anatoly Karpov. The point is, quite simply, to defend the rook on h8. With the rook defended Black threatens to win a piece with 12...g5 (13 Qh3 g4). The threat is surprisingly awkward for White to deal with which is why Black is willing to risk a move such as 11...Ke7.

Black has not fared that well with other moves in this position. The most solid continuation is 11...Qa5+ 12 Bd2 Qh5 which forces the exchange of queens (White is slightly better).

12 Ne5!

It turns out that White has no choice but to sacrifice a pawn.

12...Bxe5 13 dxe5 Qa5+ 14 c3 Qxe5+ 15 Be3

However, with his bishop pair and attacking chances against the black king he obviously has compensation, but how much? Well that is difficult to say but, after struggling in the early games against 11...Ke7, White has begun to turn things around and more and more

games are been decided in his favour.

15...b6

Black tries to patch up the dark squares that have been weakened by the departure of his bishop.

16 0-0-0 g5 17 Qh3 c5 18 Rhe1 Bb7 19 Bc4 Be4?

19...Ne4 is a better way to try and block White's threats in the centre as after 20 f3 the knight can drop back to d6. The position is supposed to be unclear. I would prefer White but that may be just a matter of taste.

20 f3 Bf5 21 g4 Bg6 22 Bd2!?

This position had already been reached in the game Morozevich-Iordachescu, Chisinau 1998 and in that game White produced a combination that won Black's queen: 22 Bd5! interferes with the black queen's protection of c5 and leaves Black with nothing better than 22...Qxd5 (22...Nxd5 23 Bxc5+) 23 Rxd5 Nxd5. White has a technically winning position but it will take some time. This was not enough to satisfy Hector. It seems that winning is not sufficient for him – he must win quickly!

22...Qc7 23 f4! gxf4 24 Qf3 Rhd8 25 Bxf4 (Diagram 16) 25...Qc8 26 Rxd8 1-0

With his ...b6 and ...c5 moves Black managed to close off one of the dangerous dark-squared diagonals but Hector's clever play has prised open another. After 26...Qxd8 27 Rd1 Black will be slain by the bishop.

Game 26

□ Nedev ■ Nisipeanu

Yerevan Olympiad 1996

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 Ngf6 6 Bd3 e6 7 N1f3 Bd6 8 Qe2 h6 9 Ne4 Nxe4 10 Qxe4 Nf6 11 Qe2

This is more popular than 11 Qh4. White prefers to attack without giving up material and there is no chance for Black to swap queens.

11...Qc7

Black plans to castle queenside as the other side of the board is far too hazardous. The problem on the kingside is the position of that pawn on h6. Once White advances his g-pawn, files are going to open.

12 Bd2 b6 13 0-0-0 Bb7 14 Ne5

14 Kb1 is more solid and avoids complications but White shouldn't be looking to avoid them anyway. Now, as the white knight makes itself comfortable on e5 we get to see the drawbacks of playing ...Nf6.

14...c5

Black attempts to destabilise the white centre straight away as if he delays with 14...0-0-0, then White can reinforce it with 15 f4!.

15 Bb5+ Ke7 16 dxc5! (Diagram 17)

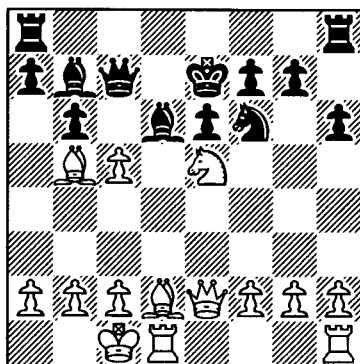


Diagram 17

White's knight cannot be touched

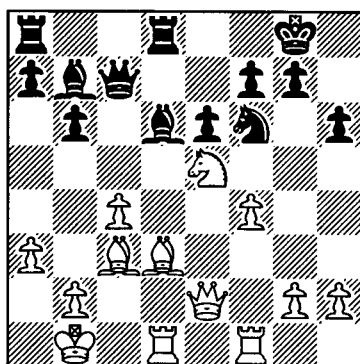


Diagram 18

White's bishops point the right way

16...Qxc5

An extremely important tactical point is that after 16...Bxe5 17 cxb6! Qc5 White can win with 18 Qxe5! Qxe5 19 Bb4+. True, Black can try 17...Bxb2+ 18 Kxb2 Qc5 but White is still winning after 19 a3! Nd5 20 c4 axb6 21 Qd3.

17 a3!

An excellent move threatening to play Bb4. Of course there was still no need to protect the knight because White wins after 17...Qxe5 18 Qxe5 Bxe5 19 Bb4+.

17...Nd5

This has been the latest try but it doesn't seem any better than what has gone before. Karpov has played both 17...a5 and 17...Qc7 but never managed to get a fully satisfactory game.

18 Kb1!

White would like to bring the bishop on b5 in from the cold – its job is done on b5. However, after the immediate 18 Bd3 Black has demonstrated that he can equalise with 18...Qd4! 19 Nf3 Qf6 20 Kb1 Nf4. Therefore white players went back to work and discovered that the white knight on e5 is still immune.

18...Qc7

The rather neat point is that 18...Bxe5 is met by 19 Bb4! Nxb4 20 axb4 when 20...Qc7 fails to 21 Rd7+ and 20...Qxb4 21 Qxe5 is excellent for White.

If Black plays 18...a6 and only after 19 Bd3 tries 19...Qd4, then the position of the pawn on a6 makes all the difference as White has the move 20 Bxa6!. I'll leave you to work out the details.

19 f4 Rhd8 20 Bd3 Kf8 21 c4 Nf6 22 Rhf1 Kg8 23 Bc3 (Diagram 18)

The position has settled down and it is obvious that White has a massive advantage. His pieces are wonderfully coordinated and although the black king has made it to the kingside it doesn't look much safer over there. Black's next move is a rather desperate attempt to change the course of the game before the white g-pawn joins the party.

23...Bxe5 24 Bxe5 Qe7 25 Ka1 Nd7 26 Bd6 Qf6 27 g4 Nc5 28 Bc2 Qh4 29 b4 Qh3 30 Kb2

Of course White wouldn't have even examined 30 bxc5 Qxa3+.

TIP: When you have an overwhelming position, keep it simple.

30...Na6 31 g5 Nb8 32 g6 Nc6 33 gxf7+ Kxf7 34 f5 e5 35 f6 gxf6 36 Qe4 1-0



Game 27

□ Ganguly ■ Sasikiran

Penta Media 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 Ngf6 6 Bd3 e6 7 N1f3 Bd6 8 Qe2 h6 9 Ne4 Nxe4 10 Qxe4 Qc7 11 Qg4 Kf8 12 0-0 c5 13 c3 b6 14 Qh4

The idea of this move is to be able to meet 14...Bb7 with 15 Be4 in order to exchange off Black's active bishop. This is not possible with the queen on g4 because of the reply ...Nf6.

14...Bb7 15 Be4 Be7!

An improvement over 15...Bxe4 16 Qxe4 Rd8, a line that had been played many times previously. It is not so easy for Black to maintain the balance there because of his kingside situation.

16 Bg5! Bxg5 17 Nxg5 Kg8! (Diagram 19)

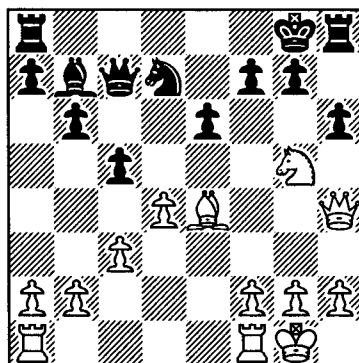


Diagram 19

Black's position is better than it looks

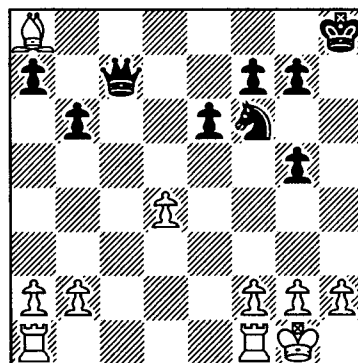


Diagram 20

Level or not?

17...hxg5 is not out of the question as after 18 Qxh8+ Ke7 White can't defend the bishop with 19 Qh7 because of 19...Nf6. However, by playing 19 Qxg7 Bxe4 20 Qxg5+ Nf6 and now either 21 f3 or 21 Qe5,

White should be able to claim an edge. A rook and two pawns are usually slightly better than two minor pieces.

18 Bxb7

White heads for a two rooks against queen position, but more through necessity than desire. The problem is that after 18 Nf3 g5! Black just wins a piece (19 Qg4 Nf6). Even 19 Nxc5 hxc5 20 Qxc5+ Kf8 doesn't offer any hope because Black threatens mate on h2 as well as the bishop on e4.

18...hxc5 19 Qxh8+ Kxh8 20 Bxa8 cxd4 21 cxd4 Nf6 (Diagram 20)



NOTE: Sometimes two rooks are better than a queen and sometimes a queen is better than two rooks. It all depends on the specifics of the position.

This position has been assessed as level but 4-0 to Black tells another story. Queen and knight are a famously potent combination and here White has a weak d-pawn and Black a favourable kingside pawn structure which makes life difficult for the white bishop.

22 Rac1 Qd8 23 Bf3 Qxd4 24 Rc2 g4 25 Rd1 Qe5 26 Bc6 g6 27 g3 Kg7 28 Kg2 Nh7 29 Rc4 Qe2 30 Rdd4 Nf6 31 Rb4 e5 32 Rd6 e4 33 Rb3 Qc2 34 Re3 Qxb2 35 a4 Qc2 36 Bb5 Nh7 37 Bd7 f5 38 Rc6 Qd1 39 Rc7 Kh6 40 Bb5 Ng5 41 Be2 Qxa4 42 Rc8 Qa1 43 Rec3 Nh3 44 Bf1 Qe1 0-1

I think we will be seeing a lot less of this Qh4 idea in the future.

Game 28

□ Gallagher ■ Nisipeanu

Cappelle la Grande 2002

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nd7 5 Ng5 Ngf6 6 Bd3 e6 7 N1f3 Bd6 8 Qe2 h6 9 Ne4 Nxe4 10 Qxe4 Qc7 11 Qg4 Kf8 12 0-0 c5 13 c3 b6 14 Re1 Bb7 15 h4!? (Diagram 21)

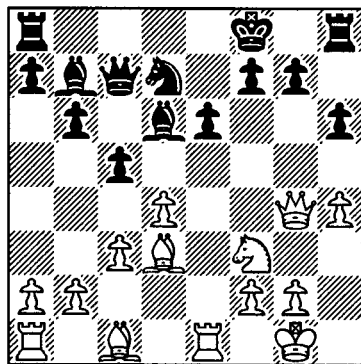


Diagram 21
A useful lunge

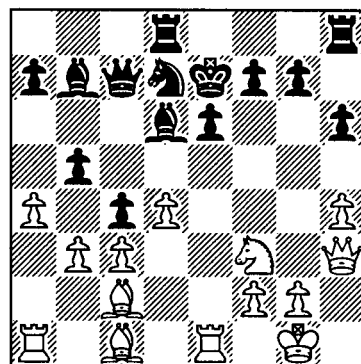


Diagram 22
White blasts open the queenside

15...Rd8

15...c4 16 Bc2 b5 has been played a couple of times, including once by Karpov. It secures the d5-square but also takes pressure off White as he doesn't have to worry about the tension in the centre anymore. I would assess the position as slightly better for White, even though others say it is level.

16 Qh3

It is nice for the queen not to have to worry about been attacked by ...Nf6. I felt this was more important than playing h4-h5 at once.

16...Ke7?!

Black's idea is to get his king's rook into play and then retreat the king again but that is wildly optimistic. Of course after such a move my combination scanner was on red alert.

17 Bc4!

Threatening 18 Rxe6+!.

17...Nf6

Variations for Black to avoid were 17...Bxf3 18 Rxe6+! Kf8 19 Qxf3, when Black still has to deal with the threat of Re8+ followed by Qxf7 mate, and 17...cxd4 18 Nxd4 (the simplest) 18...Qxc4 19 Nf5+ and Nxd6 with advantage to White. After the text the queen defends along the second rank so there is no mate, but we shall soon see that Nisipeanu wasn't too happy with this move.

18 Bb3 c4

My opponent spent absolutely ages on this move. I was waiting for him to play 18...Rhe8? so that I could hit him with 19 Bxh6!, the main point being 19...gxh6 20 Rxe6+! fxe6 21 Qxe6+ Kf8 22 Qxf6+ Qf7 23 Qxf7 mate. There are other, more complicated, variations but they are also good for White. In the end my opponent said that he didn't see any of that but just sensed it was time to close down the centre.

19 Bc2 Nd7!?

He was afraid of Ne5, but it is rather extreme to play ...Nf6 and then back to d7 a couple of moves later.

20 b3! b5 21 a4 (Diagram 22)

White is trying to blast open as many lines as possible and break Black's blockade of the centre so that he can get at Black's king.

21...Bd5 22 Nd2 cxb3 23 Bxb3 Bxb3 24 Nxb3 bxa4 25 Nd2! Nf6 26 Rxa4 Rd7 27 c4 Re8! 28 Ba3 Kf8 29 Qc3 Kg8 30 Bxd6 Qxd6 31 Nf3

Black has defended like a Trojan and White was unable to find a knockout blow. However, he still has a clear positional advantage due to Black's weak a-pawn and the dangerous passed c-pawn. If the white h-pawn were pushed back a square then the black position would be hopeless. With it on h4, though, Black has some tactical chances.

31...Rb8 32 Qa3 Qc7 33 Ra1 Ng4 34 Rb4?

Oh dear. I fall straight into it. After 34 c5! Black is in trouble.

34...Rxb4 35 Qxb4 Rxd4! 36 Rc1

The point was, of course, that after 36 Nxd4 Qh2+ 37 Kf1 Qh1+ 38 Ke2 Qxa1 Black regains the rook with a winning position.

36...Rd3 37 c5 h5 38 Qc4?

Another mistake. After 38 Kf1 or 38 Rb1 White's c-pawn keeps him in the game. As you may have guessed, we were in the middle of a massive time scramble.

38...Rxf3! 0-1

Chess can be a cruel game!

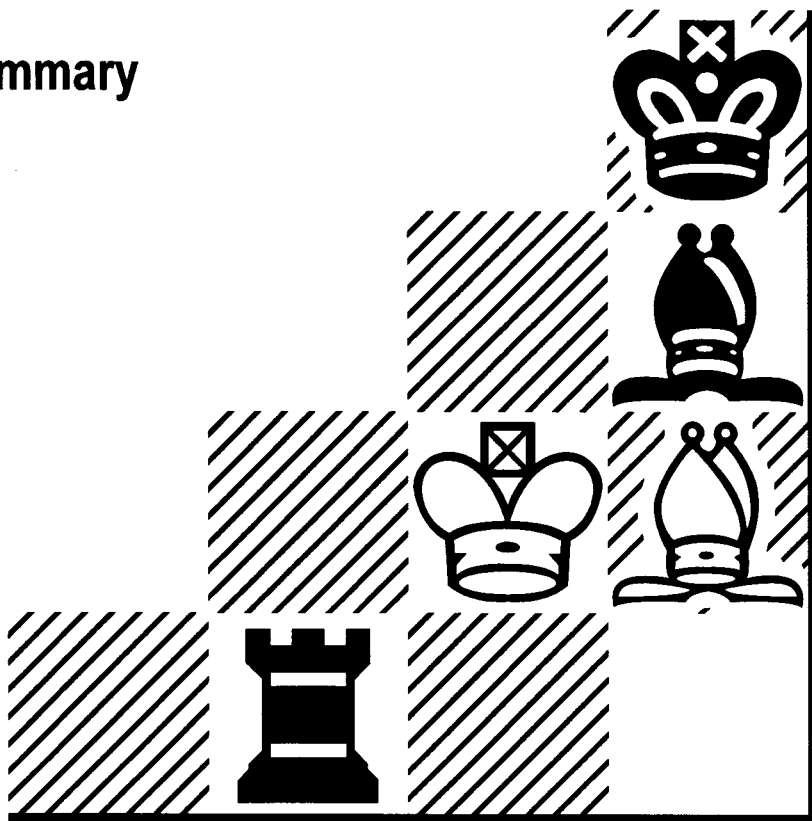
Summary

- 1) Black should not touch his h-pawn before move 8. If he does then the white knight is much more likely to go forwards than backward.
- 2) The lines from the first section are more or less only of historical interest at master level and the position after 10 Qxe4 (and beyond) is usually reached after a few seconds play.
- 3) The main line of 10 Qxe4 (Game 28) seems quite solid for Black and many strong players are willing to defend in this fashion. Black has good chances of taking over the initiative if White plays inaccurately.

Chapter Five

4...Nf6

- ▨ 5...gxf6: Introduction and Various Plans
- ▨ 5...gxf6: White Plays g2-g3
- ▨ 5...exf6: The Tartakower Variation
- ▨ Summary



1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6

This knight move leads to two quite distinct variations of the Caro-Kann. After 5 Nxf6+ (which is almost always played) 5...gxf6 leads to the Bronstein-Larsen Variation while 5...exf6 leads to the Tartakower Variation. The only similarity between them is that the Black pawn structure has been compromised. The chess purists do not think too highly of either variation. They are less popular today than they once were but remain important lines. The Bronstein-Larsen Attack is dealt with in the first two sections below whilst the third tackles the Tartakower.

5...gxf6: Introduction and Various Plans

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ gxf6 (Diagram 1)

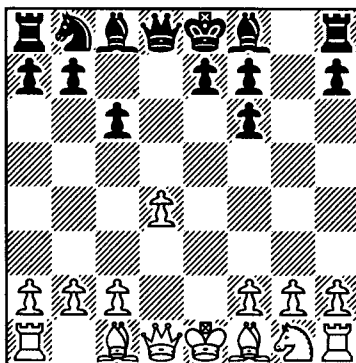


Diagram 1
The Bronstein-Larsen Variation

The Dynamic Duo

The Bronstein-Larsen Attack is named after two of the most inventive grandmasters ever to have graced the chessboard. David Bronstein is best known for his performance in the 1951 World Championship match where he failed by a whisker to wrestle the crown from compatriot Mikhail Botvinnik. The final result was a 12-12 draw, which allowed Botvinnik to retain his title. The Great Dane, Bent Larsen, was for many years one of the strongest grandmasters in the world. In 1970, for example, he played Board 1 ahead of Bobby Fischer in the USSR-Rest of the World 'match of the century'.

A Controversial Line

The variation named after this dynamic duo is, not surprisingly, one of the most controversial lines in the Caro-Kann. Black has allowed

his pawn structure to be seriously compromised but in return he hopes to gain active play for his pieces. In particular, he will want to make good use of the semi-open g-file and of his extra central pawn. So why is the line so controversial? Well, the main problem is not the actual pawn structure, although this can certainly come into play as the game goes on, but the fact that there is nowhere really safe for the black king to settle down. Its natural home is on the kingside but that part of the board is no longer very welcoming for him. More often the king goes to the queenside, but he is not very safe there either as White will be able to drum up an attack by advancing his queenside pawns. The fact that there is already a black pawn on c6 will give the pawn-storm something to latch onto and make it easier to open lines.

The Bronstein-Larsen Attack has declined in popularity since its heyday in the 1970s. The reason for this is that White players have finally settled on the same simple but effective plan of fianchettoing the king's bishop. This is an excellent idea as it combines both defence and attack. Defensively it blunts Black's play along the g-file while offensively the bishop on g2 will lend strong support to any queenside attack White may launch. The lines with g2-g3 will be considered in the next section while here we shall deal with White's other tries.

6 Ne2

In this line Black likes to develop his queen's bishop to f5. This knight move is the start of a plan to harass this bishop when it gets there.

The alternatives:

- a) The immediate 6 Nf3 allows 6...Bg4 and is rarely played.
- b) 6 c3 is the most common move these days. The idea is to wait for Black to play 6...Bf5 before playing 7 Nf3. White usually follows up with 8 g3 and this is the subject of the next section.
- c) 6 Bc4 is covered in Game 29.

6...Bf5

Left to his own devices Black would be looking at a set-up with ...Bf5, ...e7-e6, ...Nd7, ...Qc7, ...Be7 (or d6), ...0-0-0 with, perhaps, ...Rg8 flicked in.



NOTE: This is the basic set-up but one must remain flexible and react to what happens on the board. There is usually some sort of spanner thrown into the works.

7 Ng3 Bg6 8 h4

With the grave threat of 9 h5 trapping the bishop on g6. Black must create some 'luft' by moving his h-pawn.

8...h5!

Black realises that he is liable to lose this pawn but he hopes to gain some active play. At any rate, he deems this preferable to 8...h6 9 h5 Bh7 when the pawn on h6 would be fixed under the eye of the white bishop and need permanent protection. It could well drop off under much worse circumstances.

9 Be2 Nd7

Setting a little trap. If White now takes on h5 (either way) he will lose a piece after 9...Bxh5 and ...Qa5+.

10 c3 Qa5 (Diagram 2)

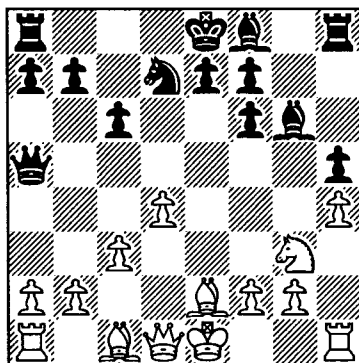


Diagram 2

11 b4 or 11 a4?

There are two main continuations for White now:

a) He can win a pawn with 11 b4 Qc7 12 Nxh5. However, practice has shown that Black gets plenty of compensation. This is examined in Game 30.

b) Recently 11 a4 has been tried more often. The idea is to be ready to launch an attack against the black king once it has castled queenside. Black should not be bluffed out by this – there is nowhere else for his king to go and he can obtain sufficient counterplay in the centre. A typical continuation has been 11...0-0-0 12 b4 Qc7 13 a5 e5 14 a6 b6 15 0-0 and now the best move is 15...e4!, after which White should probably try and block it up with 16 f4. The chances are about level.

Theoretical?

There is a little bit of work to be done and some traps to avoid.

Statistics

After 10...Qa5 White has scored 65% from 48 games but this is mainly because Black players have reacted poorly against 11 a4. With 6 Bc4 White has only managed 50% in over 500 games.

Game 29

□ Berzinsh ■ Zabystrian

Trinec 1999

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ gxf6 6 Bc4

A natural developing move which has been criticised in some quarters for not putting the black position under enough pressure.

6...Bf5 7 Ne2

The tactical genius Mikhail Tal once won a nice game against Larsen with 7 Bf4, but mainly because Larsen replied with the risky 7...Qb6 instead of the solid 7...e6 followed by ...Bd6.

7...e6 8 0-0

Another typical continuation is 8 Ng3 Bg6 9 h4 h5 10 Bf4 Bd6 11 Qd2 Qc7 12 Bxd6 Qxd6 with a roughly level game.

8...Bd6

In view of the game continuation it may be more accurate to play 8...Nd7. This keeps the g7-square protected so that an incursion by a white knight to h5 is less menacing. If White plays 9 Bf4 then Black can still oppose the bishop by playing 9...Nb6 followed by 10...Bd6.

9 Ng3 Bg6 10 Nh5!? (Diagram 3)

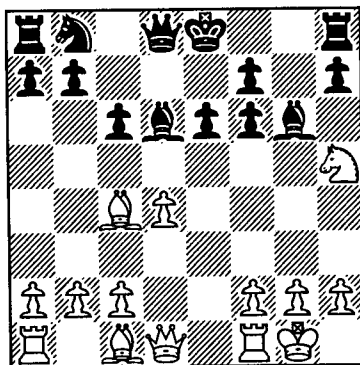


Diagram 3
Attacking from the edge

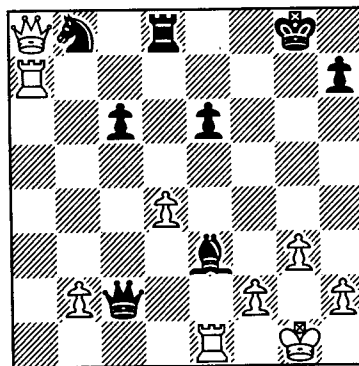


Diagram 4
Too desperate

10...f5

Black now threatens tactics based on ...Qh4 but this move has been criticised and 10...Nd7 suggested instead. Maybe this is better but after 11 Ng7+ Ke7 (11...Kf8 12 Bh6) and now either 12 Qe2 or 12 Re1, Black will have sacrifices on the e6-square hanging over him.

11 g3 Bxh5 12 Qxh5 Qf6 13 Re1 Qg6 14 Qf3 0-0

Black would prefer not to have to castle yet but White is threatening to open the position with d4-d5. For example, 14...Nd7 15 d5 Ne5 16 Qc3 is good for White.

15 Qb3 b5 16 Bxe6

16 Bf1 is good enough for a safe advantage.

16...Rd8

Black can't take the bishop (16...fxe6 17 Rxe6 Qf7 18 Rxd6) and the attempt to pin the bishop with 16...Re8 backfires after 17 Bxf7+. Strangely enough the bishop now remains trapped in the middle of the board.

17 a4 bxa4!?

Black's last move defended the bishop on d6 so it was now possible to take the bishop. However, after 17...fxe6 18 Rxe6 Qf7 19 axb5 cxb5 20 Bg5 Rd7 White has excellent compensation for the piece (21 Qe3 looks like a strong move).

18 Qb7 fxe6 19 Qxa8 f4

Black's plan is to launch an attack while White's queen is far away. White's next move is a good practical decision that ensures him of some advantage and diminishes the risk of an accident.

20 Bxf4! Bxf4 21 Rxa4 Qxc2 22 Rxa7 Be3? (Diagram 4)

A panicky move. Perhaps Black thought he was losing if he retreated his bishop but there is nothing clear, e.g. 22...Bg5 23 Qb7 Nd7.

23 Rxe3?

23 fxe3! would have won as after 23...Rf8 24 Rf1 Rxf1+ 25 Kxf1 Qd1+ there is no perpetual check. The white king eventually escapes via g5 and f6. Check it for yourselves.

23...Rf8 24 f3 Nd7?

Because of White's 28th move, it was better to do without this move. After 24...Qc1+ 25 Kf2 Qxb2+ Black is still in the game.

25 Qb7 Qd1+ 26 Kf2 Qd2+ 27 Re2 Qd3 28 Ra8!

Well calculated this time. The black queen won't be able to much damage on her own. The pin forces the exchange of rooks after which the exposed position of the white king won't matter so much. The rest was easy for White.

28...Qxf3+ 29 Ke1 Qh1+ 30 Kd2 Qd5 31 Rxf8+ Kxf8 32 Rf2+ Ke7 33 Kc3 e5 34 Qb4+ Ke8 35 dxe5 Qxe5+ 36 Kc2 c5 37 Qg4 1-0

Game 30

□ Boskovic ■ Rohde

New York 1979

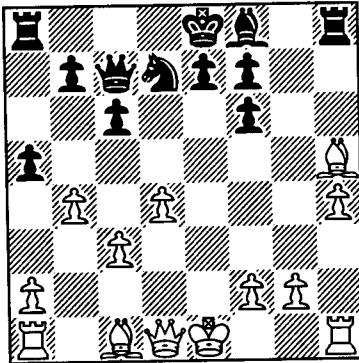
1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ gxf6 6 Ne2 Bf5 7 Ng3 Bg6 8 h4 h5 9 Be2 Nd7 10 c3 Qa5 11 b4 Qc7 12 Nxb5

Black's 10...Qa5 and 11...Qc7 is an instructive manoeuvre. If Black had just played 10...Qc7 straight away, then White could have captured on h5 with impunity. But by playing 10...Qa5 Black forced White to weaken his queenside before collecting his pawn. This means, with the kingside already compromised, that White no longer has a safe haven for his king, who will have to lead a nervous existence wherever he goes.

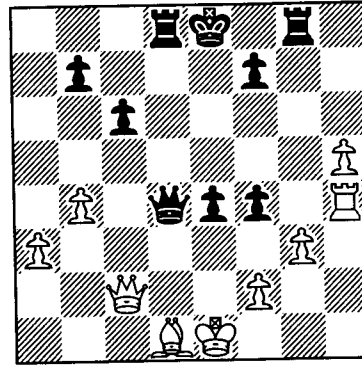
It was also possible for White to play 12 Bxb5 Bxb5 13 Nxb5, when play is quite similar to the game after 13...a5 or 13...e5.

12...Bxh5

An interesting decision. Black could play 12...a5 at once but then White would reply 13 Nf4 followed by 14 Nxg6. Black would still have compensation but of a more shaky nature as the pawn structure around his king would have been loosened. Black could also play 12...e5!?. That would prevent the knight from returning to f4 and keep the bishop pair, but also let slip the opportunity to gain a real positional advantage on the queenside.

13 Bxh5 a5! (Diagram 5)**Diagram 5**

Striking at White's weakened queenside

**Diagram 6**

Black has a pretty finish in mind

14 Bg4

14 Be2 at once is better. White must have overlooked Black's reply, which gains a useful extra tempo.

14...axb4 15 cxb4 f5! 16 Be2

After 16 Bxf5 e6 both the bishop and the pawn on b4 are attacked. Still, this was probably better than the game.

16...Qd6 17 Qb3 Nb6

What Black's ...a5xb4 manoeuvre has achieved is to isolate White's d-pawn and carve out an outpost on d5 for a black piece.

18 Bb2 Na4! 19 Rd1 Nxb2 20 Qxb2 Bg7

Now the white d-pawn will be lost and Black has a clear advantage because his rooks are more active and his king is safer.

NOTE: Positions with opposite coloured bishops are famous for their drawish tendencies. Whilst this may be true in the ending (where two extra pawns may not be enough to win), in the middle-game they heavily favour the side who is attacking.

21 a3 Rd8 22 Qc2 e6 23 Rh3 Bxd4 24 h5 Qf4 25 Bf3 e5 26 Rd2 e4 27 Bd1 Rg8 28 g3 Qe5 29 Re2 Bc3+ 30 Kf1 Qd4 31 Re1 Bxe1 32 Kxe1 f4 33 Rh4 (Diagram 6) 33...Rxg3! 34 fxg3 Qg1+ 35 Ke2 f3 mate

5...gxf6: White Plays g2-g3

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ gxf6 6 c3

As mentioned in the previous section, White delays Nf3 until Black has played ...Bf5. The immediate 6 g3 is suspect because of the reply 6...Qd5 so White settles for 6 c3 as the most useful waiting move he can find.

6...Bf5 7 Nf3 e6

The other move Black often plays is 7...Nd7. Sometimes this just transposes but Game 31 features 7...Nd7 going its own way.

8 g3! (Diagram 7)

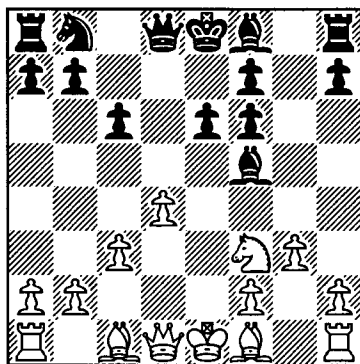


Diagram 7
Preparing the fianchetto

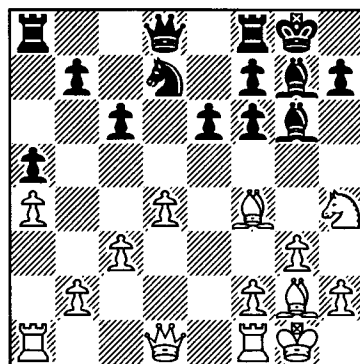


Diagram 8
White has an edge

Finally White starts the fianchetto, the most reliable and strongest way for White to tackle the Bronstein-Larsen Attack. By playing g2-g3 and Bg2 White makes it difficult for Black to generate play on the kingside without taking excessive risks. Such a risk would be to castle queenside as the bishop on g2 is pointing at the black king.

8...Nd7

A natural developing move but there are a couple of other less standard lines that have to be taken into account:

- a) 8...Qd5 is a misguided attempt to exchange queens – see Game 32.
- b) 8...h5!? is more ambitious and can be seen in Game 33.

9 Bg2 Bg7

This is the most solid plan for Black. Despite the open g-file his king will be much safer on the kingside. The drawback is that Black will have to renounce any kingside attacking ideas he may have had.

10 0-0 0-0 11 Nh4

Now White can seize the bishop pair at a moment's notice.

11...Bg6 12 a4 a5 13 Bf4 (Diagram 8)

This position, which occurred in Adams-Spraggett, Hastings 1989/90, can be assessed as slightly better for White.

Theoretical?

It's not extremely theoretical. It should be enough to get by with theory up to about move 8 or 9 and knowledge of the key ideas.

Statistics

The statistics make grim reading for Black and explain the decline in popularity of the Bronstein-Larsen Attack. When White plays with g2-g3 and Bg2 he has scored a whopping 68%. The problem for Black is that this is now well known and most white players play this way. Consequently, I think Black should steer clear of this line.

Game 31

□ Campora ■ Morozevich

Moscow Olympiad

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ gxf6 6 c3 Bf5 7 Nf3 Nd7 8 g3 Nb6

This innocent-looking knight move may not look like the prelude to a kingside attack but that is exactly what it is. Black now plans ...Qd7 and ...Bh3, to swap off White's light squared bishop, followed by ...h7-h5-h4 to open the h-file. Is White quaking in his boots? Certainly not! Black's plan is in fact very risky. It is time consuming and the black knight on b6 is a very tempting target for the white a-pawn.

9 Bg2 Qd7 10 0-0 h5?! (Diagram 9)

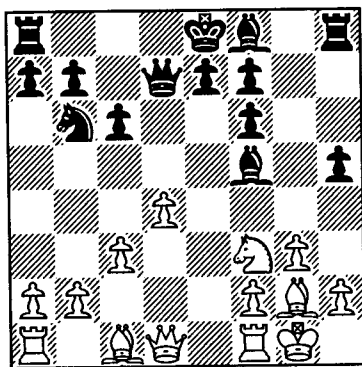


Diagram 9
Too slow!

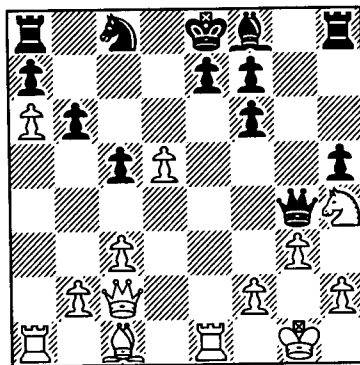


Diagram 10
White targets the f5-square

This is just too slow. Black should have just exchanged bishops with 10...Bh3 and, after 11 Bxh3 Qxh3 12 a4, brought his queen straight

back (12...Qd7) in order to prevent White breaking through in the centre.

11 a4! Bh3?! 12 Bxh3

The queen is lured away from the centre.

12...Qxh3 13 a5 Nc8

13...Nd5 would just run into c3-c4.

14 a6 b6 15 d5! c5

Black tries to block the position. Look at what can happen to him if he opens it: 15...cxd5? 16 Qxd5 Rb8 17 Qb7!! and White will emerge a rook to the good.

16 Re1 Qd7

White's pawn structure is vastly superior. The a6-pawn ensures him of a permanent positional advantage on the queenside while the pawn on d5 cramps Black and prevents him from relieving the pressure.

17 Nh4!?

The f5-square is the perfect home for the knight. If Black plays 17...Nd6 then White just plays 18 Bf4 and Bxd6 to simplify into a good knight versus bad bishop situation.



NOTE: A bad bishop is one whose activity is restricted by its own pawns. It looks particularly poor when its opposite number is a knight with an excellent central outpost.

17...Qg4 18 Qc2 (Diagram 10) 18...Qd7 19 Bf4 Bh6

Black probably considered 19...Nd6 20 Bxd6 Qxd6 21 Nf5 to be hopeless so he tries to exchange the dark-squared bishops. But in doing so he walks straight into a little tactic. The knight on h4 had more than one string to its bow.

20 Ng6! Rg8

20...fxg6 21 Qxg6+ Kd8 Bxh6 loses but the text is equally hopeless.

21 Nxe7! Nxe7 22 d6 1-0

Game 32

☐ Van den Doel ☒ Konings

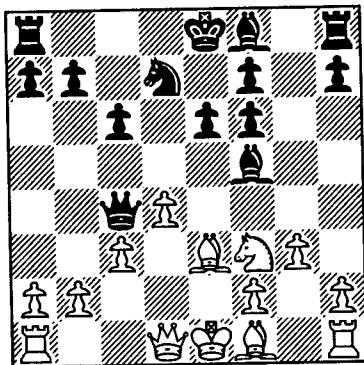
Dutch League 2002

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ gxf6 6 c3 Bf5 7 Nf3 e6 8 g3 Qd5

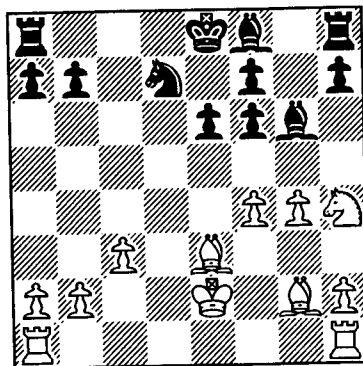
One of the first things we learn in chess is not to develop the queen prematurely as it can get pushed around by inferior pieces. So why do so many Black players play 8...Qd5 in this position? Frankly, I don't know! As far as I can see this is not one of the times when the rules should be broken. There are two main ideas behind 8...Qd5 but neither of them are very promising. The first is to try and exchange queens but Black has to waste too much time to achieve this. The other idea is to take control of the f1-a6 diagonal in order to prevent White from castling kingside. This is wildly optimistic.

9 Bg2 Qc4

Plan B. After 9...Qe4 10 Be3 Qc2 Black succeeds in exchanging queens, but following 11 Nh4 Qxd1+ 12 Rxd1 Bg6 13 0-0 Nd7 14 f4 f5 15 c4 White has the better game.

10 Be3 Nd7 11 Bf1 (Diagram 11)**Diagram 11**

White's bishop heads home

**Diagram 12**

Black has no defence on the queenside

I once played 11 Nd2 Qa6 12 c4 and achieved a pleasant position, while the big theoretical works such as *NCO* and *ECO* give 11 Nh4 Bg6 12 Nxg6 hxg6 13 Qd2 Rd8 14 b3 Qb5 15 c4 Qb4 16 Qxb4 Bxb4+ 17 Ke2 with an edge for White. Van den Doel's idea seems even more dangerous for Black.

11...Qd5 12 Qe2!

White is now ready to play Bg2 again and this time the queen will be really misplaced on d5.

12...c5?

The move of a man who won't admit things have gone wrong. By opening the diagonal for the bishop on g2, Black is signing his own death warrant.



TIP: Don't be afraid to admit your mistakes. Black should have just cleared out of the centre with his queen (...Qa5 on move 12 or 13). The time lost would have rendered his position just difficult, as opposed to fatally flawed.

13 Bg2 cxd4 14 Bxd4 Qe4 15 Be3 Qd3 16 Nh4! Qxe2+ 17 Kxe2 Bg4+ 18 f3 Bh5 19 g4 Bg6 20 f4 (Diagram 12) 20...a5 21 Bxb7!

White calculates that the coming pin is going to be decisive.

21...Rb8 22 Bc6 Rxb2+ 23 Kf3 Bd6 24 Rad1 Ke7 25 Bxd7! h5 26 g5 Bc2 27 Rd2 1-0

After 27...Kxd7 28 Rc1 is the simplest.

Game 33

□ Riemersma ■ Pietersee

Dieren 1989

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ gxf6 6 c3 Bf5 7 Nf3 e6 8 g3 h5!?

The direct approach. Black seeks to open lines on the kingside as quickly as possible.

9 Bg2 Be4

If Black doesn't play this move, then Nh4 is awkward.

10 0-0 Be7 11 Re1 f5 12 Qe2!

This move may look strange but White has a very nasty idea in mind. It was almost certainly the fruit of home preparation as this was not the first time the two players had reached this position. In the previous game White played 12 Bf1, intending to follow up with Nd2xe4. It is worth taking a look at because of Black's remarkable queen sacrifice: 12 Bf1 c5 13 Be3 Nc6 14 Bb5 h4 15 Nd2 hgx3 16 fxg3 Qb6 17 Qa4 0-0-0 18 Nc4 Qc7 19 Bf4 (Diagram 13)

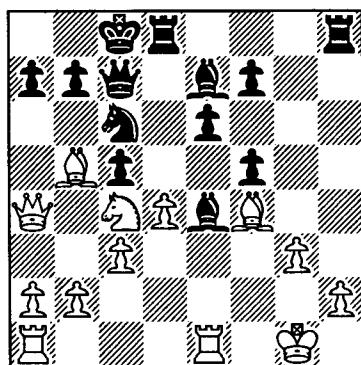


Diagram 13

Black sacrifices a queen

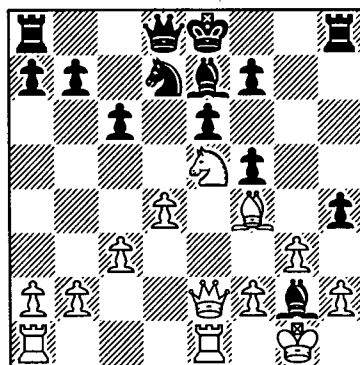


Diagram 14

White is not forced to recapture

19...Qxf4!! 20 gxf4 Rdg8+ 21 Kf1 Rxh2 22 Nd6+? (22 Rxe4 fxe4 23 Bxc6 Rh1+ 24 Kf2 Rh2+ is a draw) 22...Bxd6 23 Rxe4 fxe4 24 Re1 Be7 25 Re2 Rh1+ 26 Kf2 cxd4 27 cxd4 Rh2+ (27...Rh3! is a good winning attempt) 28 Kf1 Rh1+ 29 Kf2 Rh2+ 30 Kf1 Rh1+ ½-½ Riemersma-Pietersee, Holland 1987.

12...h4 13 Bf4 Nd7 14 Ne5! Bxg2? (Diagram 14)

This just loses so Black had to play 14...Nxe5 15 Bxe5 f6, although White has a serious advantage after 16 Bf4 Bxg2 17 Kxg2. It seems to me that 12 Qe2 casts doubt on Black's whole set-up.

15 Nxf7!

Now you can understand 12 Qe2!.

15...Kxf7 16 Qxe6+ Kf8

16...Ke8 17 Qg6+ Kf8 18 Bh6+ just comes to the same thing.

17 Bh6+ Rxh6 18 Qxh6+ Kg8 19 Qe6+ Kf8 20 Qh6+ Kg8 21 Qe6+ Kf8 22 Kxg2

White's little combination has netted him a decisive material advantage as he will soon have rook and three pawns against two pieces. The rest is just a mopping up process.

22...Nf6 23 Re5 Qd7 24 Qxd7 Nxd7 25 Rxf5+ Kg7 26 Re1 Bf6 27 Re6 Rf8 28 g4 Rf7 29 f4 Be7 30 Rxf7+ Kxf7 31 Re2 Nf6 32 Kf3 Nd5 33 g5 b5 34 Kg4 Bd6 35 f5 Nf4 36 Re4 Nd3 37 g6+ Kg7 38 Kg5 1-0

5...exf6: The Tartakower Variation

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ exf6 (Diagram 15)

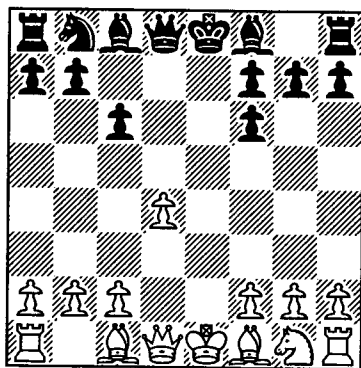


Diagram 15
The Tartakower Variation

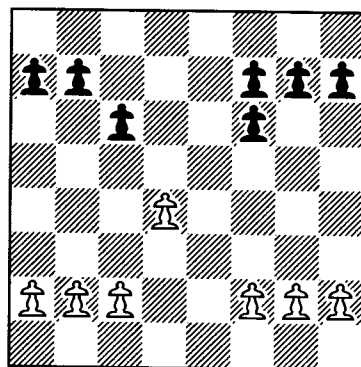


Diagram 16
The Tartakower structure

For some reason recent publications have started to call this line the Korchnoi Variation. This strikes me as somewhat odd as Korchnoi only played it four times. And not, it seems, with any particular enthusiasm. Raymond Keene relates how, in his role as chief second, he persuaded a sceptical Korchnoi to try this line in the 1978 World Championship match against Anatoly Karpov.

I always knew this line as the Tartakower Variation. Tartakower was the first famous player to play this line regularly although Horatio Caro also used it, most notably to lose against the American genius Pillsbury at Vienna 1898.

So enough about the name, is it any good? Well, it is certainly very solid, much more so than the alternative capture 5...gxf6, but it's not thought of too highly these days. Variations where Black accepts a disadvantage and just tries to hang on for the draw are not very popu-

lar nowadays. That is, perhaps, a slightly harsh but basically true assessment of the Tartakower Variation.

The Pawn Structure

The variation is defined by the pawn structure. After 5...exf6 White has a 4-3 majority on the queenside and Black has 4-3 on the kingside. **(Diagram 16)**

The problem for Black is that he is unable to create a passed pawn with his majority. White, of course, can easily make one in the centre. This means that, unless he develops some other sort of compensation, endgames are going to be unpleasant for Black. So why does Black accept such a positional disadvantage? Well, firstly, he gets free and easy development for his pieces. He will not end up in a cramped position as Black so often does. Secondly, the two f-pawns are not totally useless as Black will be able to advance the front one without weakening his own king position.

Strategies

White has two main ideas. One is to swap of all the pieces and play an endgame with his advantageous pawn structure. The other is to attack the black king. Sometimes he plays with both ideas in mind, i.e. his attack scares Black into exchanging pieces which is what White really wanted all along. His favourite scheme of development is to play c2-c3, Bd3, Ne2, Qc2 and either 0-0 or 0-0-0, depending on how Black plays (Game 35). In Game 36 White plays the same way but without Qc2. Another White idea is to play 6 Bc4, which is usually followed by Qe2+ in order to try and exchange as many pieces as possible – see Game 34.

Black will just develop his pieces rapidly (often ...Bd6, ...0-0, ...Be6, ...Nd7 and ...Qc7) and bring his rooks to the centre. A well timed ...c6-c5 is an important part of his plans. The idea is to either exchange off White's extra central pawn or to force it to advance, after which it will have less influence on the centre. On other occasions Black will seek counterplay by advancing his front f-pawn.



WARNING: If Black plays with ...c6-c5 he must have the d6-square under control so that the passed pawn on d5 can go no further.

Theoretical?

Not very theoretical, although Black should probably know beforehand how he's going to react to the lines with 9 Qc2. White should choose one line and learn it. It's not too complicated.

Statistics

Overall White has scored 56% from around 1500 games. This is just

above average but when he starts playing the main line with 6 c3 and 7 Bd3 his score rises to 61% from around 500 games.

Game 34

□ Matulovic ■ Smyslov

Siegen Olympiad 1970

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ exf6 6 Bc4 Bd6

a) 6...Nd7 is Korchnoi's choice in this position. The knight is heading for the d5-square (via b6) whilst 7 Qe2+ is no longer serious as Black just replies 7...Be7. The above-mentioned Karpov-Korchnoi, World Championship Game 20, Baguio 1978 continued 7 Ne2 Bd6 8 0-0 0-0 9 Bf4 Nb6 10 Bd3 Be6 11 c3 Nd5 12 Bxd6 Qxd6 13 Qd2 Rad8 14 Rfe1 with an edge for White.

b) 6...Qe7+ is a tricky move as 7 Be3?? or 7 Ne2?? loses a piece to 7...Qb4+. White must play 7 Qe2 when play often continues 7...Be6 8 Bb3 a5. Now I like 9 Bf4! a4 10 Bxe6 Qxe6 11 0-0-0, taking advantage of the fact that the black queen is pinned so she cannot take on a2. White's plan is to follow up with d4-d5. For example, 11...Nd7 12 d5 and 11...Be7 12 d5! cxd5 13 Bxb8 Rxb8 14 Qb5 are both very good for White.

b) 6...Qd6 is another move which threatens 7...Qb4+. White should be able to retain an edge by playing 7 c3 Be6 8 Bb3.

Black should probably choose one of these three alternatives rather than going straight into the ending as he does in the main game.

7 Qe2+ Qe7 (Diagram 17)

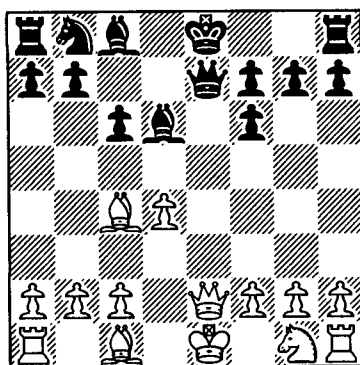


Diagram 17
Off come the queens

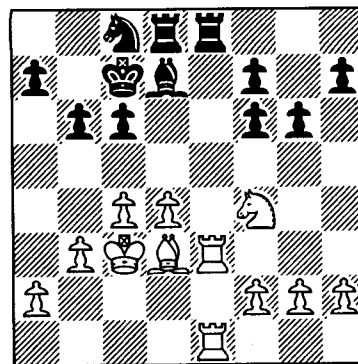


Diagram 18
White has a pleasant ending

8 Qxe7+ Kxe7 9 Ne2 Be6 10 Bd3 Nd7 11 Bf4 Nb6 12 Bxd6+ Kxd6 13 b3!

White plans to take maximum control by playing c2-c4. In effect, he is just a pawn up in such an ending. It is not that easy to win because it



is difficult to make a passed pawn whilst Black has control of d5.

13...Kc7 14 c4 Rad8 15 Kd2

TIP: One doesn't castle in such positions. A centralised but safe king position is ideal.

15...Rhe8 16 Rae1 Nc8 17 Kc3 b6 18 Nf4 g6 19 Re3 Bd7 20 Rhe1 (Diagram18)

This is more or less the maximum White can achieve out of this variation – and he still didn't win! In this case I think it is more to do with the respective strengths of the two players. The former World Champion playing Black is, quite simply, one of strongest endgame players of all time. The same cannot be said about Milan Matulovic, the Yugoslav Grandmaster conducting the white pieces in this game. In fact, one well-known story about him suggests the opposite. When asked once by an amateur why he didn't make the obvious simplification into a winning king and pawn endgame he replied, 'I haven't studied them yet!'

20...Rxe3 21 Rxe3 Kd6 22 b4 c5 23 dxc5+ bxc5 24 Be2 cxb4+ 25 Kxb4 Bf5 26 g4 Bb1 27 c5+ Kc7 28 Bc4 Bxa2 29 Kc3 Bxc4 30 Kxc4 Rd2 31 Nd5+ Kc6 32 Nb4+ Kd7 33 Rf3 a5 34 Nd5 Rc2+ 35 Nc3 Ne7 36 Kb3 Rc1 37 Kb2 Rg1 38 Rxf6 Rxc4 39 Rxf7 Ke6 40 Rxh7 Rb4+ 41 Ka3 Rc4 42 Na4 ½-½

Game 35

□ Kudrin ■ King

London 1988

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ exf6 6 c3

This is the most popular continuation. White plans to develop his bishop to d3 and knight to e2 but first must defend his d-pawn.

6...Bd6 7 Bd3 0-0 8 Ne2 Re8 9 Qc2

This is usually considered as one of the key positions in the whole variation. In the past 9 Qc2 (or 8 Qc2 Re8+ 9 Ne2 with the same position) was thought to be an important move which forces Black to make some sort of concession on the kingside. Nowadays White is not so sure. 9 0-0 is the subject of the following game.

9...g6

There are two other ways to deal with the threat to h7: 9...h6 and 9...Kh8. The latter defends the pawn indirectly as after 10 Bxh7 g6! the bishop is trapped and will be lost for insufficient compensation. After both these moves White should probably just continue with 10 0-0 and Bf4 and then just keep exchanging pieces at every opportunity. After 9...g6, though, it would take a strong-minded and, perhaps, over-cautious individual to resist the temptation to go for a kingside attack.

10 h4!? (Diagram 19) 10...Be6 11 h5 f5 12 hxg6 fxg6 13 Bh6 Nd7

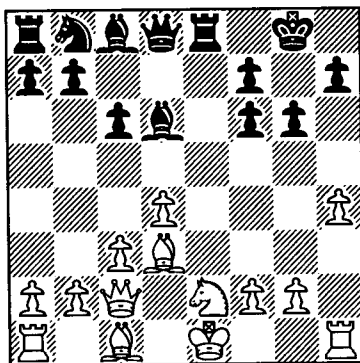


Diagram 19

White's intentions are clear

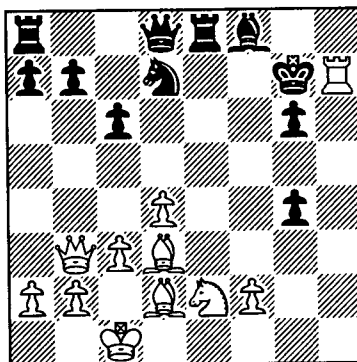


Diagram 20

Take my rook!

The position is very sharp and unclear, a far cry from the rather tedious technical exercises the variation often produces. 13...Qf6 would have prevented White's next move, although that does not mean it is objectively stronger.

14 g4!? Bd5

14...fxg4 loses to 15 Bxg6 so Black hopes to gain time for defence by attacking the rook.

15 0-0-0!

But White just sacrifices it!

15...Bxh1 16 Rxh1 Bf8! 17 Bd2 fxg4?

White gave up the exchange because he hoped that, with his light-squared bishop missing, Black would succumb on the g8-a2 diagonal. After the text this is indeed what happens. Black should have played 17...Nb6! as after 18 gxf5 Qd5 he attacks both the rook and the pawn on a2. The position is very unclear.

18 Qb3+! Kg7 19 Rxh7+! (Diagram 20) 19...Kxh7 20 Qf7+ Kh8 21 Nf4 1-0

22 Nxg6 mate can only be prevented by 21...Re6 but after 22 Qxe6 the white attack rages on. Black preferred to resign at once.

Game 36

□ Khalifman ■ Seirawan

Wijk aan Zee 1991

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 dxe4 4 Nxe4 Nf6 5 Nxf6+ exf6 6 c3 Bd6 7 Bd3 0-0 8 Ne2 Re8 9 0-0 (Diagram 21)

As we saw above, things are not so clear if Black plays correctly after 9 Qc2. More and more white players are omitting this move now.

9...Qc7?!

This is already an inaccuracy as the threat to h2 just encourages White to bring his knight to the kingside. And, as we shall see in the next note, this pawn is not so important that the knight cannot move. It would have been better to play 9...Nd7, when White should probably settle for 10 Bf4.

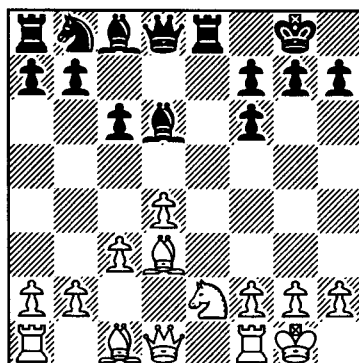


Diagram 21
The quieter approach

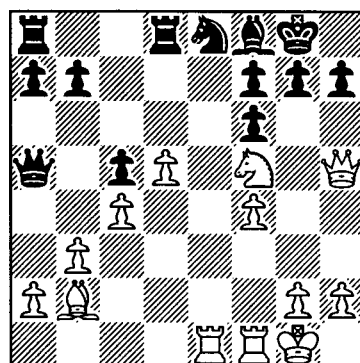


Diagram 22
A sacrifice suggests itself

10 Ng3 Be6?!

Seirawan must have completely missed the follow-up. However, 10...Nd7 11 Nf5! is also very dangerous for Black. The game Loeffler-Dichev, Cannes 2000 continued 11...Bxh2+ 12 Kh1 Bd6 13 Nxg7! Kxg7 14 Qg4+ Kh8 15 Bh6 Rg8 16 Qh4 Rg6 17 Rae1 with a massive attack for White.

11 f4! c5

Black attempts to change the course of the game as he realises that after something like 11...Nd7 12 f5 Bd5 13 Nh5 the pressure against g7 will soon become intolerable (Qg4, Bh6 etc.).

12 d5 Bd7 13 c4

The opening has been a tremendous success for White. He has a clear positional advantage, plenty of attacking chances against the black king and all the black pieces are stepping on each other's toes.

13...Na6 14 Qf3 Qb6 15 b3 Bf8 16 Bb2 Nc7 17 Bf5! Bxf5 18 Nxf5 Red8 19 Rae1 Ne8 20 Qh5 Qa5 (Diagram 22)

Not surprisingly there is now a combination to blast through Black's fragile defences.

21 Rxe8! Rxe8 22 Nh6+ gxh6

After 22...Kh8 23 Qxf7 Be7 there is the famous smothered mate: 24 Qg8+ Rxg8 25 Nf7.

23 Qg4+ 1-0

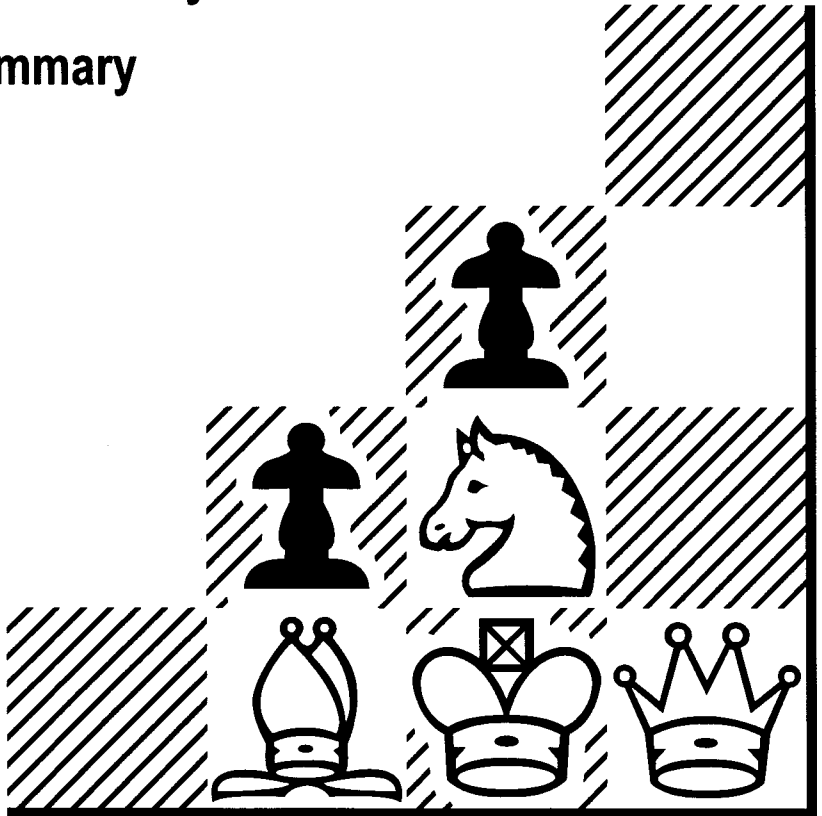
Summary

- 1) The Bronstein-Larsen Attack is a double-edged variation whose popularity has been on the decline ever since white players started to fianchetto their king's bishop with alarming regularity.
- 2) In the Tartakower Black allows his pawn structure to be compromised in return for easy development. As White's development is also easy and his pawn structure healthy, he has the advantage.

Chapter Six

The Advance Variation: 3...c5 and the Short System

-  Introduction
-  3...c5
-  The Short System
-  Summary



Introduction

The Advance Variation is probably the line in the Caro-Kann that has expanded the most in recent times. Until about twenty years ago it had the reputation of been a rather timid variation that didn't put Black under enough pressure in the opening. This all changed when the sharp line with 4 Nc3 followed by g4 (see the next chapter) replaced the rather dull 4 Bd3 as the main line against 3...Bf5. The 1980s saw many hair-raising theoretical battles with 4 Nc3 but by the end of the decade White appeared to have exhausted his ideas in this line. But the Advance didn't stay out of the limelight for long as Nigel Short suddenly started to play the variation in a new way. He just developed his pieces very quietly (Nf3, Be2, 0-0 etc.) and relied on his extra space to make Black's life difficult. At first no-one believed this was a serious try for the advantage, but eventually it really caught on and by the mid 1990s it was dominating the Caro-Kann. Around this period Black players began to question the opinion that 3...c5 was a mistake and the efforts of players such as Igor Khenkin and Keith Arkell have now turned that into a fully viable alternative to 3...Bf5. And, as a final twist, in the last few years the star of the Short system has faded slightly and the sharp 4 Nc3 has risen, phoenix like, from the ashes.

The material on the Advance Variation has been split up into two chapters. In this chapter we shall examine 3...c5 and the Short system while the next shall be devoted to 4 Nc3.

3...c5

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 c5!? (Diagram 1)

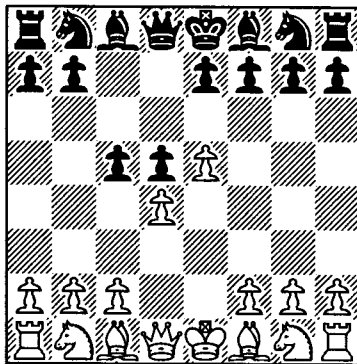


Diagram 1

A second move by the c-pawn

This is a very thematic move but it has taken a surprisingly long time

for Black to realise its potential. In the past it was often said that the Advance Variation was no good because Black could play a French Defence with his bishop outside the pawn chain. The move 3...Bf5 just became a given. Nobody saw beyond the fact that 3...c5 loses a pawn. But things have changed now and 3...c5 is gaining in popularity. Some Caro players are beginning to feel that developing the bishop outside the pawn chain just gives White something to attack. Before we go any further:



WARNING: 3...c5 should be played only by those who are comfortable in French-style positions.

4 dxc5

The only testing move. After 4 c3 Black does indeed get an easy game by playing a sort of French defence with his light squared bishop actively deployed outside the pawn chain. For example, 4...Nc6 5 Be3 cxd4 6 cxd4 Bf5 7 Nc3 e6 with equality.

4...e6

After this move the position is the same as after 1 e4 e6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 c5 4 dxc5 except that it is still White to move. In effect, White has gained a tempo on an innocuous line of the Advance French. Is it still innocuous with the extra tempo? That is what we shall be endeavouring to answer.

Black has an equally important alternative in 4...Nc6 and that is covered in Games 37 and 38.

5 Be3

White defends the attacked pawn with a developing move – very natural. Still, there are some players who prefer to let the pawn go. The reason is they don't like putting their bishop on a square that becomes a target for a black knight landing on f5. 5 Nf3 is examined in Game 39 while 5 Qg4!? is another move worthy of attention.

5...Nh6!?

Previously Black used to play 5...Nd7 but once Dautov produced 5...Nh6 Black players seemed to have ditched 5...Nd7 en masse. There is nothing particularly wrong with 5...Nd7. The main line runs 6 Bb5 Qc7 7 Nf3 Bxc5 8 Bxc5 Qxc5 9 Nc3 Ne7 and now I think 10 0-0 0-0 11 Re1 Ng6 is unclear but 10 Qd4 gives White chances of an edge.

And what about the move ...Nh6? Isn't Black worried about Bxh6 and the shattering of his kingside pawn structure? The answer is, not really. Connoisseurs of the French Defence will know that the knight often takes this route to f5. The move Bxh6 is an option for White, though an irritating one after having just played Be3, but it just leads to unbalanced positions where Black hopes his control of the dark squares will compensate for his pawn structure.

6 c3

White prepares to meet ...Nf5 with Bd4. Recently there have been quite a few games with 6 Nf3. After 6...Nd7 White players got excited

about the continuation 7 Bxh6 gxf6 8 c4 dxc4 9 Bxc4 as the position after 9...Nxc5 10 Qe2 seems to be in his favour. However, in the most recent game in this line Caro-Kann expert Igor Khenkin demonstrated that instead of recapturing the c-pawn Black should go after the e-pawn with 9...Bg7!. After 10 Qe2 Qc7 11 Bb5 0-0 12 Bxd7 Bxd7 13 0-0 Qxc5 14 Nc3 Bc6 15 Ne4 Qb4 16 Rfe1 Bxe4 a draw was agreed in Rabiega-Khenkin, Berlin 2001. At most White has a token edge in the final position.

6...Nf5 7 Bd4 Nxd4!?

At first glance it looks like an absolutely terrible move to take this bishop and straighten out White's pawn structure. However, you will see Black's reason as the play unfolds. In fact, most black players prefer 7...Bd7 to the text, the current view being that after 8 Nf3 Nc6 9 Qd2 f6 10 exf6 gxf6 11 Be3 White has slightly the better of a very complex game. However, such theoretical views are in a permanent state of flux.

8 cxd4 b6!

Black's idea is to exchange off the powerful pawn on c5 and develop play on the c and b-files as well as against the weak pawn on d4.

9 Bb5+

A few unambitious white players have simply returned the pawn with 9 c6 here. Although that does keep the position relatively closed, Black has an easy game.

9 b4 leads to much sharper play and is obviously the critical test of Black's strategy, but as can be gauged from Game 40, Black appears to be coping fine.

9...Bd7 10 Bxd7+ Nxd7!?

This may well be an improvement on 10...Qxd7 11 cxb6 axb6 12 Ne2, which gave White an edge in Nisipeanu-Kachiani, Bad Wiessee 1997.

11 cxb6

After 11 c6 Nb8 Black wins back the pawn with a level game, while 11 b4 is still met by 11...a5.

11...Qxb6 (Diagram 2)

It may look as if White is a pawn up for not much but the real question is, in fact, if he can survive the next few moves unscathed. Black threatens to take on b2. The obvious move is 12 Qd2, but after 12...Rb8 13 b3 (what else?) Black has the tactical shot 13...Nxe5!, the point being that after 14 dxe5 Bb4 15 Nc3 Black can now play 15...d4 with the better game. White probably should play 12 b3 but after 12...Bb4+ he will have to play 13 Kf1. I would prefer Black in this position.

We have, in fact, just rewritten chess theory as most sources claim that White is doing well after 9 Bb5+. Don't forget, though, that there are still various alternatives that lead to a roughly equal game.

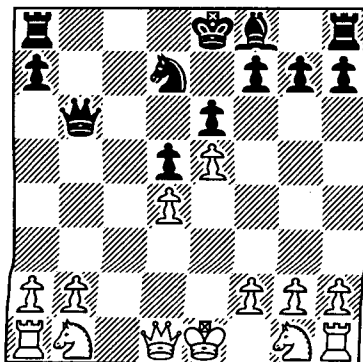


Diagram 2
Black has compensation

Theoretical?

It certainly helps to know what you are doing as the play can get quite sharp, but it would be fair to say that Black does not need to work as much to learn 3...c5 as 3...Bf5. White has less options here.

Statistics

Overall after 3...c5 White has scored 52% from 943 games. Not a very good score, but if we look in a bit more detail things start to improve for White. 25% of White players, for example, didn't play 4 dxc5 and they only managed a paltry 42% with their collection of inferior lines. So if we take the position after 4 dxc5 as the starting point of the variation then White has managed a far healthier 56%.

Game 37

□ Beshukov ■ Turov

Moscow 2002

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 c5 4 dxc5 Nc6 5 Nf3

This move is slightly frowned upon as it allows Black to play ...Bg4. The struggle in this variation often revolves around the e5-square so normally the knight on f3 is considered to be a superior minor piece to Black's bishop. As we shall see, though, other factors come into play, the most important being White's chance to hang on to his extra pawn.

Another idea for White, if he wants to develop his pieces without getting pinned, is 5 Bf4!?. A typical continuation then is 5...e6 6 Nd2 Nge7 7 Ngf3 Ng6 8 Bg3 Bxc5 9 Bd3 with a pure French position.

5...Bg4 6 Bb5 e6

Black has to decide, either now or on the next move, whether he

wants to flick in ...Qa5+. He probably should. After 6...Qa5+! 7 Nc3 e6 8 Be3 Arkell's move 8...a6 is interesting. The point is that after 9 Bxc6+ bxc6 10 a3 Bxf3 11 Qxf3 Black can simply play 11...Bxc5 with a level game as 12 b4 fails to 12...Bxb4. If White wants to keep his extra pawn he has to play 11 gxf3 but Black's superior structure gives him obvious compensation.

7 Be3

After 7 b4 Black won't get his pawn back but can instead develop positional compensation by playing 7...Qc7 8 Bb2 b6! 9 cxb6 Qxb6 10 Bxc6+ Qxc6. The white queenside is full of holes.

TIP: This ...b7-b6 idea is an important resource when White grabs the c5-pawn and supports it with b4. It often leads to good compensation and this is not the only example that you can find in this part of the book.

7...Nge7 8 c3 (Diagram 3)

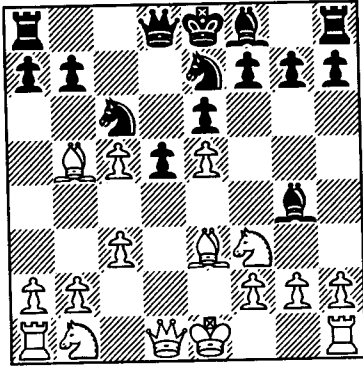


Diagram 3
Not so innocent

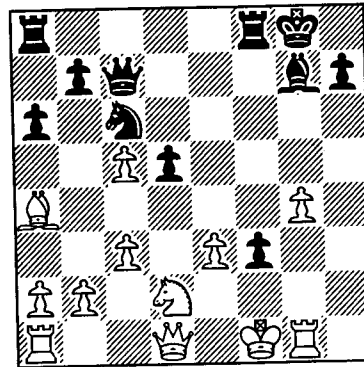


Diagram 4
White's in a mess

8...a6

White's last move wasn't quite as innocent as it looked as it opened a path to the queenside for the white queen. A careless player who played 8...Nf5 or 8...Ng6 would find himself in trouble after 9 Qa4!.

9 Ba4

White should keep his bishop and the pin. At first glance it may look like a good idea to simplify with 9 Bxc6+ Nxc6 10 Bd4, but this position contains surprising hidden resources for Black. For example, after 10...Bxf3 11 Qxf3 not only is 11...Qg5 good but also 11...b6!? 12 cxb6 Nxd4 13 cxd4 Qxb6 14 Qd1 Rc8.

9...Qc7 10 Bd4 Ng6 11 Nbd2 f6?!

From a practical point of view Black's decision to sacrifice another pawn to get his centre rolling is not a bad idea. Objectively speaking,

it was better to play something simple like 11...Be7 12 0-0 0-0. True, Black is a pawn down in a relatively quiet position but the compensation is there, mainly because the white position is so inflexible. The bishop on d4, in particular, is doing a very nice impersonation of a pawn.

12 exf6 e5! 13 fxg7 Bxg7 14 Be3 Nh4

After 14...e4 15 h3 exf3 16 hxg4 fxg2 17 Rg1 White stands well as 17...Qh2 is simply repulsed by 18 Nf3.

15 Rg1!

Much safer than 15 0-0 because then 15...e4 would be dangerous.

15...e4 16 h3?

A very careless move which soon lands the white king in hot water. White had another way to save the pinned piece, namely 16 Bxc6+ bxc6 (16...Qxc6 17 Nd4!) 17 Qa4!. I think Black is in serious trouble here as after 17...exf3 18 Qxg4 Nxd2+ 19 Kd1 his king is worse off and White is still a pawn up.

16...exf3 17 hxg4 Nxd2+ 18 Kf1 Nxe3+ 19 fxe3 0-0 (Diagram 4)

Now White's position is an uncoordinated mess with an exposed king. Not surprisingly, he didn't last long.

20 Bb3 Kh8 21 Bc2 Rae8 22 Nb3 Rxe3 23 Rh1 h6 24 Rh3 Qf4 25 Bf5 Rxf5! 26 gxf5 Qc4+ 27 Kf2 Re2+ 0-1

Game 38

□ Greet ■ Arkell

British Championship, Millfield 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 c5 4 dxc5 Nc6 5 Bb5

In the previous game White defended his e-pawn. This time he uses a pin to save his pawn and 5 Bb5 is by far White's most popular choice.

5...e6 6 Be3 Nge7

The knight heads for f5.

7 c3

White prepares to park his bishop on d4 after which it won't object to been taken by a black knight.

7...Bd7

Black unpins and threatens to take on e5. It is no good for White to defend this pawn as after 8 Nf3 or 8 f4 Black still plays 8...Nxe5!. Therefore White has little choice but to take on c6.

8 Bxc6 Nxc6

The right way to recapture as 8...Bxc6 9 Nf3 Nf5 10 Bd4 Nxd4 11 Qxd4! is in White's favour. Anyway, Black has quite a special idea in mind.

9 f4

White tries to give his e-pawn firm support. If instead 9 Nf3, then

Black obtains counterplay by 9...Qc7 10 Bd4 Nxd4 11 cxd4 b6!. We saw a similar idea above in the theoretical section.

9...g5! (Diagram 5)

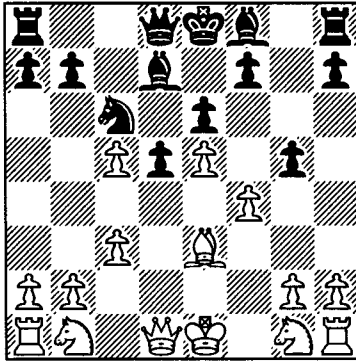


Diagram 5
Nibbling at the centre

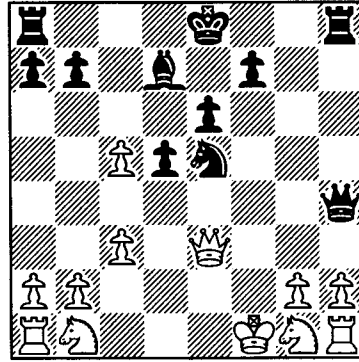


Diagram 6
A brilliant sacrifice

Excellent! This move has become quite commonplace now but it made quite a stir when it first appeared. Black is more than happy to give up wing pawns if he can take control of the centre.

10 fxg5

At first White tried to maintain his strong pawn on e5, even at the expense of giving up his c-pawn. For example, Glek-Khenkin, Werfen 1990 continued 10 Nf3 gxf4 11 Bxf4 Bxc5 12 Nbd2 Qb6 13 Nb3 Bf2+ 14 Ke2 Na5! 15 Nxa5 Bb5+ 16 Kd2 and now Khenkin played 16...Qxa5 but eventually lost. A few years later he reached this same position again (David-Khenkin, Geneva 1996) and unleashed the powerful novelty 16...d4!. White simply couldn't cope and was crushed. Here are the moves: 17 b4 dxc3+ 18 Kc2? (18 Kxc3) 18...Rd8 19 Qc1 Ba4+ 20 Nb3 Qxb4 21 Qf1 Bxb3+ 22 axb3 Qe4+ 23 Kxc3 Rc8+ 0-1.

10...h6!?

This very interesting idea from Arkell looks as if it might resurrect this variation. Black had been on the back foot as 10...Nxe5 11 Nf3 Nxf3+ 12 Qxf3 Bg7 13 0-0 0-0 14 Nd2, which was considered as the main line, seemed to be turning in White's favour. With 10...h6 Black decides to play a mirror image Benko Gambit in order to get at the open files on the kingside. The initiative is what counts in such positions, not material.

NOTE: The Benko Gambit is the name given to the variation 1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 c5 3 d5 b5 4 cxb5 a6, where Black sacrifices a pawn to gain pressure along the open a- and b-files.

11 gxh6?!



Mr Greet knows no fear. Other Arkell games have gone 11 Nf3 hxc5 12 Bxc5 Be7, with good compensation for Black after both 13 Be3 Bh4+ 14 Kd2 Qc7 and 13 Bxe7 Qxe7 14 Qe2 Qxc5.

11...Bxh6 12 Qe2 Qh4+ 13 Kf1

Neither 13 g3 Qe4 nor 13 Bf2 Qg5 are improvements, while 13 Qf2 Bxe3 just loses a piece.

13...Bxe3 14 Qxe3 Nxe5!! (Diagram 6)

An excellent move which literally destroys Black's position.

15 Na3

The main line was 15 Qxe5 Bb5+ 16 Ne2 Rh5! 17 Qe3 (17 Qg3 Qxc3) 17...Rf5+ 18 Kg1 Qe1 mate. White's position is hopeless now whatever he does.

15...Ng4 16 Qd2 Nxh2+ 17 Ke2 Qg4+ 18 Ke1 Nf3+ 0-1

Game 39

□ Arizmendi ■ Bauer

European Team Championship, Leon 2001

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 c5 4 dxc5 e6 5 Nf3 Bxc5 6 Bd3 Nc6 7 0-0

This natural move is not immune from criticism in view of Black's reply. 7 Qe2!? is certainly worth considering as then White can meet 7...f6 with 8 Be3.

7...f6! (Diagram 7)

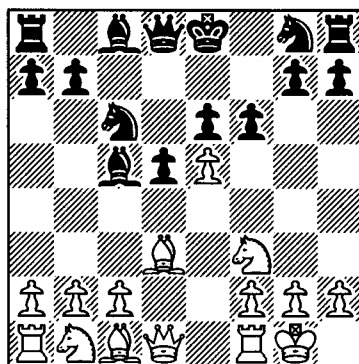


Diagram 7
Attacking the centre

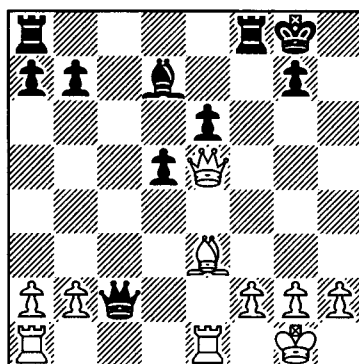


Diagram 8
White has the better of the draw

Many games have gone 7...Nge7 8 Bf4 Ng6 9 Bg3 but it is better for Black to challenge in the centre at once. If Black delays ...f7-f6 then White will be better prepared to face it.

8 Qe2

White doesn't want to take on f6 as this just helps Black's development, but neither is he overjoyed about having to defend the e5 pawn

with his queen. He would much prefer to defend it with pieces but after 8 Bf4 he has to contend with 8...g5!. Then 9 Nxc5 is at best speculative and after 9 Bg3 g4 White's centre will collapse. Admittedly, the position isn't totally clear after 10 Nfd2 fxe5 11 Qxc4, but losing control in this fashion was probably not what White had in mind when he sat down a few moves earlier.

8...fxe5 9 Nxe5 Nxe5 10 Qxe5 Nf6 11 Nd2

The knight is rushing around to f3 in order to relieve the queen from its onerous task of blockading the black centre. Note that 11 Bb5+ Kf7 doesn't help White as the bishop is misplaced on b5 and Black can easily castle by hand.

NOTE: The queen is a terrible blockader but knights, on the other hand, just love blockading opposing centres.

11...Bd6 12 Qe2 0-0 13 Nf3 Qc7 14 Re1 Bd7?!

Black misses his chance and, strangely enough, this was the second time Bauer had failed to play the enterprising pawn sacrifice 14...e5!. After 15 Nxe5 Re8 it is probably too risky for White to play 16 Bf4 as it won't be easy to escape the pin. The safe alternative is 16 f4 but then Black wins back the pawn with 16...Ng4. There will follow mass exchanges on the e5 square and a likely early draw, e.g. 17 Kh1 Bxe5 18 fxe5 Rxe5 19 Bf4! Rxe2 20 Bxc7 Rxe1+ 21 Rxe1 Nf2+ 22 Kg1 Nxd3 23 cxd3 Bf5 with an equal endgame.

15 Ne5 Ne4!?

Probably better than the 15...Rae8 Bauer had played previously but it doesn't alleviate all suffering.

16 Bxe4 Bxe5 17 Bxh7+! Kxh7 18 Qh5+ Kg8 19 Qxe5 Qxc2 20 Be3 (Diagram 8)

White has a small but enduring advantage as he has the better bishop. However, with the reduced material and opposite coloured bishops, a betting man would have to put his money on the draw. The remaining moves were:

20...Rf5 21 Qd4 Qc7 22 f4 Bc6 23 Bd2 Qf7 24 Rac1 a6 25 Rc3 Re8 26 h3 Qf6 27 Qxf6 Rxf6 28 Rd3 Rf7 29 g3 Rc7 30 Bc3 Bd7 31 Re5 Rf8 32 Rg5 Rf7 33 Kf2 Bb5 34 Rd4 Bc4 35 a3 Rf5 36 Rxf5 ½-½

Game 40

□ Peng Xiaomin ■ Khenkin

Geneva 1997

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 c5 4 dxc5 e6 5 Be3 Nh6 6 c3 Nf5 7 Bd4 Nxd4 8 cxd4 b6 9 b4!?

See the theoretical section for a discussion on the play up to here and the alternatives to 9 b4. Black now needs a good move or he will just be lost.

9...a5! (Diagram 9)

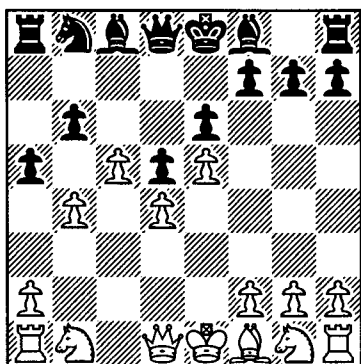


Diagram 9
Black attacks the base

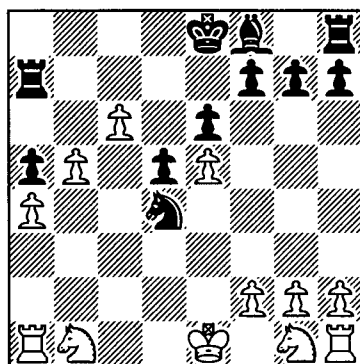


Diagram 10
A brave decision

10 Qa4+

White cannot hold his queenside pawn structure together as both 10 a3 axb4 and 10 cxb6 Bxb4+ are good for Black.

10...Bd7 11 Bb5 Bxb5 12 Qxb5+ Qd7 13 Qxb6

White shows no fear and is willing to take chances with his queen's safety in order to get a second strong passed pawn. Instead after 13 Qxd7+ Kxd7 Black will soon regain his pawn for the same reasons quoted in the previous note.

13...Nc6! 14 b5 Nxd4 15 c6 Qa7

The only move as it protects the knight on d4.

16 Qxa7 Rxa7 17 a4!? (Diagram 10)

A remarkable move. White understood that if he took a time out to save his rook (17 Kd1 or 17 Kd2) then he would not only lose his b5-pawn but also the one on c6 soon afterwards. Faced with the choice of being a pawn down for nothing (probably) or a rook down for compensation, White goes for the latter. Note that 17 b6 was no good as after 17...Ra6 both pawns will be lost.

17...Nc2+ 18 Kd2 Nxa1 19 Kc3 g5?!

This move seems a bit pointless. The immediate 19...Bc5 suggests itself. It's hard to believe that White is okay here.

20 Nf3 g4 21 Nd4 Bc5 ½-½.

I'm pretty sure that Khenkin would have had no time left around here while Peng probably didn't quite trust his position. Anyway, that is my attempt to explain why they chickened out.

The Short System

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nf3 (Diagram 11)

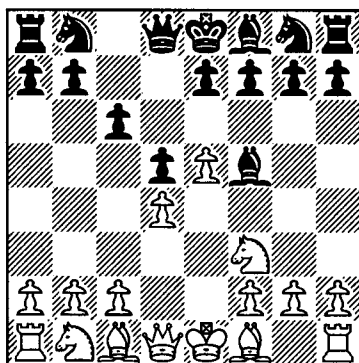


Diagram 11
The Short System

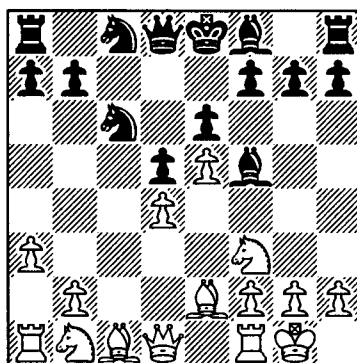


Diagram 12
The knight heads for the queenside

This system was virtually unheard of until around 1990, when Nigel Short started to play it in top class tournaments. At first people thought it was just a feeble variation that would soon disappear, but when Vishy Anand repeatedly employed it to make the great Anatoly Karpov suffer the system really took off. At one stage, in the early to mid 1990s, it was the most fashionable line in the whole of the Caro-Kann. That is no longer the case and the variation has settled down to become another one of the respectable lines at White's disposal.

The Short system is, at heart, a quiet line with lots of manoeuvring, and one certainly shouldn't expect the same kind of fireworks as after 4 Nc3. Basically, White concentrates on his development and relies on the extra space afforded by his advanced pawn on e5 to provide his chances in the middlegame. Although it is a modern system, I can detect the influence of one of the historical greats in its conception.

Aaron Nimzowitsch was a devoted fan of such pawn centres and Nigel Short a great fan of Nimzowitsch.



TIP: Nimzowitsch's legendary book *My System* is a must read for any aspiring chess player, even if not all of his theories have stood the test of time.

4...e6

Again we have a French Defence where Black has managed to deploy his 'bad bishop' outside the pawn chain. One would think that this should make Black's life easier but this is not always the case. There are occasions when the bishop is actually better off inside the pawn chain. For example, it may be required for defensive duty on the queenside, it may become a target for White's kingside pawns, or it can even end up in a sort of fool's paradise, occupying a seemingly nice diagonal but in reality just staring into thin air. On balance, though, Black would prefer to have his bishop outside the pawn chain and the main reason that he is not especially better off here than in

the Advance French is that he is going to spend two moves, instead of one, playing ...c5.

5 Be2 c5

Very natural, but there are alternatives. Game 41 features other plans for Black.

6 c3

White supports his centre. This solid move was the original idea of Short, but later other white players began to wonder if it wasn't a little premature for Black to be playing ...c6-c5 and they formulated a plan based on countering in the centre with c2-c4. They usually started here with 6 Be3. This can be examined in Game 42.

6...Nc6 7 0-0 cxd4

Black plans to continue his development with ...Nge7 and doesn't want to leave the c-pawn loose. The main alternative is to play 7...Bg4 in order to exchange on f3. White should reply 8 Nbd2 as it's important for him to be able to recapture with a knight on f3. A knight there is well placed protecting the centre while a bishop there would just be redundant.

8 cxd4 Nge7 9 a3

After 9 Nc3 Black can either play 9...Nc8, with similar ideas to those discussed below, or he can play 9...Bg4, which is a slight improvement on the previous note as White can no longer play Nbd2.

The text demonstrates White's hunger for space. This time he is looking to expand on the queenside.

9...Nc8! (Diagram 12)

It took a while for Black to discover the correct idea. The knight heads for b6 and away from the kingside logjam.

10 Nbd2

White has also tried 10 Be3 and 10 Bg5 but without great success.

10...Be7 11 b4

Shirov once played the passive 11 b3 against Karpov. This keeps the black knight out of c4 but, on the other hand, doesn't grab any space on the queenside. He was soon fighting for equality.

11...Nb6 12 Bb2 0-0 13 Rc1 Rc8

The game is level.

Theoretical?

Not extremely theoretical. It is a relatively quiet line where it is more important to understand the strategy than memorise concrete variations, although it's best if you can do both of course.

Statistics

White's overall score in this system is 57% from around 3000 games.

Game 41

□ Gallagher ■ Polak

Bern 1995

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nf3 e6 5 Be2 Nd7

Certain players prefer to delay ...c6-c5 until they are better developed. The most popular set-up is to play ...Nd7 and ...Ne7 followed by ...c6-c5 and ...Nec6.

6 0-0 Ne7

There are two main ideas behind the alternative 6...h6. The first is to preserve the bishop in the event of it been attacked by Nh4 and the other is to prepare ...g7-g5. This kingside advance is perfectly feasible when the centre is blocked. Most white players now play 7 b3, preparing to gain space on the queenside with c2-c4. After 7...Ne7 8 c4 Black usually prefers the solid 8...Ng6 over 8...g5. After 9 Na3 Nf4!? 10 Bxf4 Bxa3 11 Bd3 Black should now preserve his bishop with 11...Bg4. It is not thought that White has a serious advantage here, although Black will need a few more accurate moves before he can claim equality.

7 Nh4! Bg6

7...Be4 is best met by 8 Nd2 and after 8...Nf5 White just plays 9 Nh3. Black still won't be able to hold onto his bishop.

8 Nd2

White usually delays Nxg6 until Black has moved his knight from e7. The reason for this is that he wants to force Black to recapture with a pawn on g6.

8...c5

Or 8...Nf5 9 Nxg6 hxg6 10 Nf3 with a small plus for White. 10...c5 would now be a mistake on account of 11 c4!, so Black should settle for the solid 10...Be7.

9 c3 Nc6 10 Nxg6 hxg6 11 Nf3 cxd4

Perhaps Black could have maintained the central tension a little longer. If nothing else this would at least have prevented the set-up White used in this game. You can't put a bishop and pawn on the same square!

11...Be7 or 11...Qb6 are the alternatives.

12 cxd4 Be7 13 Bd2!

A better square than e3 for the bishop as, if necessary, it can go to c3 to defend the d-pawn and block Black's counterplay on the queenside.

13...0-0? (Diagram 13)

Perhaps the decisive mistake. It is simply too risky for Black to castle. He should have played something like 13...Qb6.

14 Bd3 a6 15 g3!

The first key move. White's main idea is to play Kg2, h2-h4, Rh1 and h4-h5 to open the h-file. It is slow but Black is bereft of counterplay.

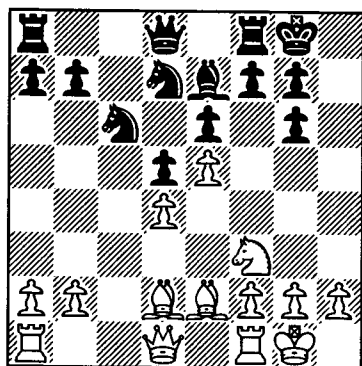


Diagram 13
Castling into it

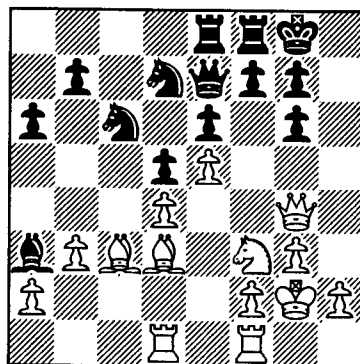


Diagram 14
White's attack gathers momentum

15...Qb6 16 Bc3 Rae8?!

I was pleased to see him box his king in even more. Black was obviously planning a break for freedom with his f-pawn but then thought better of it.

17 Qd2 Qd8

17...f5 18 exf6 Rxf6 19 Ne5! is awful for Black.

18 Kg2

Another attacking move.

18...Nb6 19 b3 Ba3

Pretty desperate stuff. Black can't find anything constructive to do so comes up with the plan of ...Ba3, ...Qe7 and either knight or bishop to b4.

20 Rad1

A final move to ensure that the queenside can look after itself. Now, if need be, the bishop can drop back to b1 and the d-pawn has added protection. I was also waiting for Black's next move as it just leaves the bishop stranded on a3.

20...Qe7 21 Qf4 Nd7 22 Qg4 (Diagram 14)

I had delayed the move h2-h4 as I was toying with the idea of trying to mate him with the more direct Ng5, Qh4 and Qh7. Finally I decided to stick with the original plan. Incidentally, my opponent had about a minute left to get to move 40 so I could no longer concentrate properly.

22...Rc8 23 Bd2 Rfe8 24 h4 Nf8 25 h5 1-0

Not a great performance by Black (who is no mug, by the way).

TIP: Remember this g2-g3, Kg2, h2-h4, Rh1, h4-h5 attacking plan against the f7, g7, g6 structure.





WARNING: But don't forget that such a slow build-up is only likely to work in blocked positions. I don't want any letters about how you played g2-g3 and Kg2 only to be torn apart on the long diagonal.

Game 42

□ Ni Hua ■ Wu Shaobin

Beijing 2001

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nf3 e6 5 Be2 c5 6 Be3 cxd4

Black can also defend his pawn with 6...Nd7, while those who like to indulge in a spot of pawn hunting can try 6...Qb6. Very few white players are willing to waste their time defending the pawn, especially as the position after 7 Nc3 Qxb2 8 Nb5 Na6 9 dxc5 is in his favour.

And then Black produced a remarkable new idea. Instead of preventing the threatened knight check on c7, a Moscow master just played 8...c4!?. Now after 9 Nc7+ Kd7 10 Nxa8 Bxc2 11 Qc1 Bb4+ White is in trouble. Remember that the knight on a8 is not going to get out alive so Black is only going to be the exchange down for his attack. Anyway, the idea impressed no less an authority than Anatoly Karpov. Not noted for his pawn-hunting skills, he nevertheless decided to give this line a try in a high profile simultaneous display in China. His game went 9 Rb1 Qxc2 10 Qxc2 Bxc2 11 Rb2 Ba4 12 Nc7+ Kd7 13 Nxa8 Kc8 and after he eventually rounded up the knight in the corner he had excellent compensation for the exchange.



WARNING: Still, I wouldn't bet the mortgage on this line just yet. Remember that chess theory is in a permanent state of flux and today's star novelty may be tomorrow's busted flush.

Before moving on, 7 c4!? has emerged recently. This may well be White's best move as after 7...Qxb2 8 Nbd2 he has a significant lead in development in an open position.

7 Nxd4 Ne7

7...Bg6 is a luxury Black cannot afford as after 8 0-0 and 9 c4 he is lagging seriously behind in development. Anyway, White has no real intention to take the bishop on f5.

8 c4

As Black appears to have got his defences in order against this attempt to open the position, a number of white players have taken to playing 8 Bg5. However, it doesn't look very convincing as after 8...Qa5+ 9 Nc3 Bg6 10 0-0 a6!. White has no pawn breaks or piece sacrifices with which to assault the black position.

8...Nbc6 9 Qa4

After 9 Nc3?! Nxd4 10 Bxd4 dxc4 11 Bxc4 Nc6 12 Bb5 Be7 13 0-0 0-0 Black probably has an edge as he has the more effective minor pieces.

9...a6! 10 Nc3

The ending after 10 Na3 Qa5+ 11 Qxa5 Nxa5 12 cxd5 Nxd5 is thought to be about level while 10 cxd5 b5! is an important intermezzo.

10...dxc4 11 Rd1 Bd3! (Diagram 15)

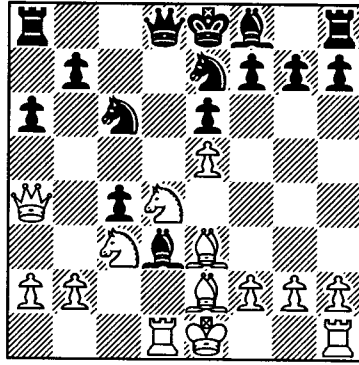


Diagram 15
A temporary blocker

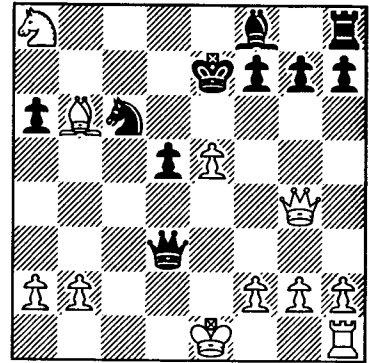


Diagram 16
Draw?

Black simplifies the position. After 11...Qa5 12 Qxa5 Nxa5 13 Nxf5 Nxf5 14 Bb6 White has very good compensation for the pawn.

12 Bxd3 cxd3 13 Rxd3 b5 14 Ndxb5!?

14 Qb3 Nxe5 15 Rd1 Qc8 occurred in a game Svidler-Leko, Tilburg 1998. It appears that White has just enough play for the pawn to comfortably hold the draw. The text is a rather wild move that had already been analysed in the chess press and dismissed as doubtful before it occurred for the first time in this game.

14...Qxd3 15 Nc7+ Kd7 16 Nxa8 Nd5! 17 Nxd5 exd5 18 Qg4+ Kd8 19 Bb6+ Ke7 20 Bc5+ Kd8 21 Bb6+ Ke7 (Diagram 16) 22 Qe2?

White should have taken the draw as within a few moves he finds himself in a totally lost position.

22...Qb1+ 23 Qd1 Qe4+ 24 Be3 Qxg2 25 Ke2 Nxe5

White must have missed something pretty obvious when he avoided the repetition. He surely wasn't aiming for this position.

26 Nc7 Qg4+ 27 Kd2 d4 28 Nd5+ Kd6 29 Qb3 Qf3 30 Rc1 Qxd5 31 Qb6+ Ke7 32 Rc7+ Nd7 33 Bxd4 Kd8 34 Qa7 Qa5+ 35 Rc3 Bd6 36 Kc1 Re8 37 Qa8+ Bb8 38 Qb7 Re1+ 39 Kd2 Re6 40 Bc5 Qb5 0-1

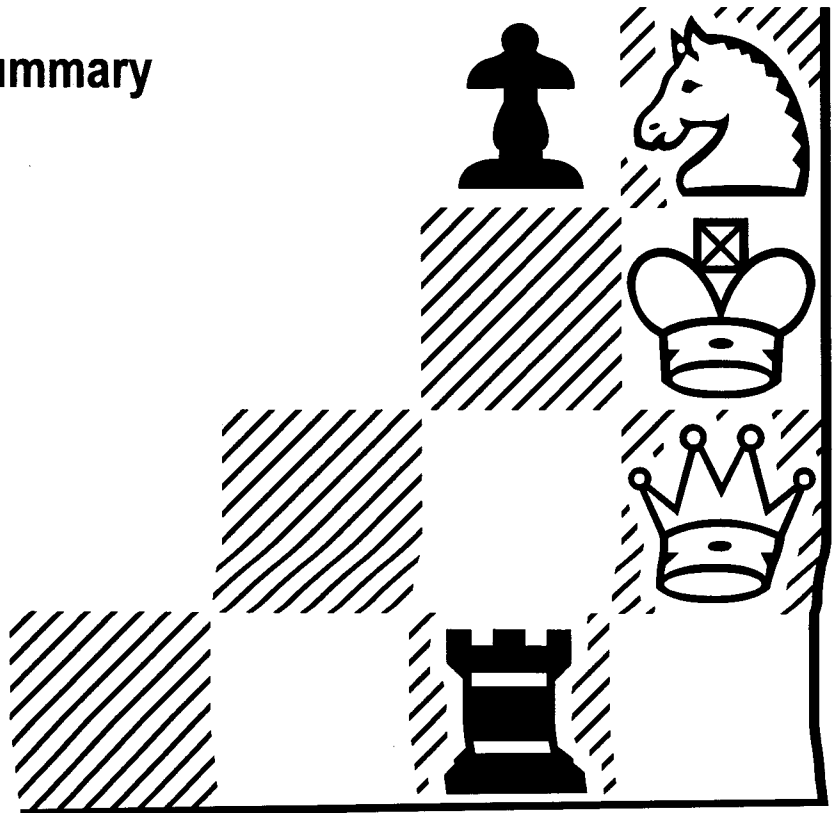
Summary

- 1) 3...c5 is becoming an increasingly popular way for Black to meet the Advance Caro. If nothing else it cuts down on the workload.
- 2) The Short Variation looks a little past its sell-by-date now. White's more aggressive lines appear to have been neutralised while Black is also holding his own in the lengthy manoeuvring lines. Most top players have moved on to fresh pastures, and that includes Nigel himself.

Chapter Seven

Advance Variation: The Sharp 4 Nc3

- ▨ Introduction and Alternatives to 4...e6
- ▨ Main Line with 4...e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2 c5
- ▨ Main Line: Alternatives to 6...c5
- ▨ Summary



Introduction and Alternatives to 4...e6

4 Nc3 is the introductory move to the sharpest line in the Caro-Kann. The move itself is not particularly vicious, but the intentions behind it are. The plan is to go all in on the kingside using the bishop on f5 as his conduit. He wants to play g2-g4 but to do so at once would be premature. Not only because of the reply 4...Bd7, but also because of 4...Be4, forcing the undesirable move 5 f3 before withdrawing to g6. In fact, the knight on c3 is not particularly well placed but apart from covering the e4 square it also has the benefit of bringing the white king a step closer to the queenside.

The variation has built up a massive body of theory that is permanently in flux. At the moment the variation is highly fashionable amongst the sharpest young guns of world chess (Shirov, Morozevich, Grischuk and Sutovsky, for example) and each new game seems to force a reassessment of old lines. If you wish to play this line with either colour you will have to keep up with all the latest developments. This chapter can make a good starting point but it will soon need updating.

The remainder of this section is devoted to unusual 4th moves for Black, while the next two sections deal with the main lines.

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 (Diagram 1)

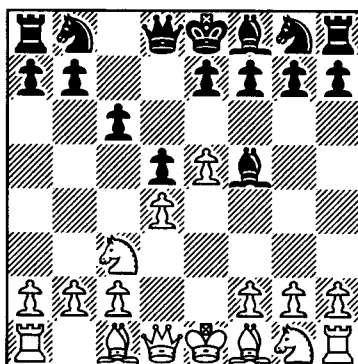


Diagram 1
White plays 4 Nc3

4...Qb6

The main point of this move is that it isn't 4...e6. That means that when the bishop is attacked by g2-g4 it doesn't have to settle on the troublesome g6-square, where it just provides a target for White's kingside pawns, but can retreat back to the safety of d7.

4...h5 is the subject of Game 43, whilst black players have also begun to experiment with 4...a6!? recently. Again White doesn't play g2-g4



while the bishop can retreat to d7. Most of the early games have centred around 5 Be3 with uncertain consequences. This could be a line for the future.

WARNING: Just to make it crystal clear, White should only play g2-g4 after Black has played ...e7-e6.

5 Bd3!?

A modest-looking move, but White is aiming for a position with a space advantage and an active queen on the third rank.

Of course many people still play 5 g4, either through ignorance or stubbornness – see Game 44.

5 Nf3 e6 6 Be2 is another option where White transposes into a sort of Short system with the extra moves Nc3 and Qb6. White will look to develop his game with Na4, b2-b3 and c2-c4. This line is beginning to become more popular. A recent example: 5 Nf3 e6 6 Be2 Ne7 7 0-0 Bg4 8 Na4 Qc7 9 b3 b5 10 Nb2 Nd7 11 c4 with an edge for White, Grischuk-Karpov, Linares 2001.

5...Bxd3

Did you notice that White's last move was actually a pawn sacrifice? After 5...Qxd4 White can't play 6 Bxf5 on account of 6...Qxe5+.

White's idea is just to play 6 Nf3 Qg4 7 h3 and now:

a) 7...Qxg2? 8 Rg1 Qxh3 9 Bf1! Bxc2 10 Qe2 Qh5 11 Rg5 Qh1 12 Qxc2 and White wins a piece as after 12...Qxf3? 13 Bg2 the queen is trapped. Even if Black avoids losing his queen his position is pretty hopeless. Although he has four pawns for a piece, the main factor is his lack of development.

b) 7...Qh5 8 0-0 Bxd3 9 cxd3 is the critical position for the assessment of the pawn sacrifice. It seems that White has the advantage but he must make something happen before Black completes his development. His main ideas are Qb3, to attack the black queenside, and Ne2-g3 (or Nf4) to attack the black queen.

6 Qxd3 e6 7 Nge2 Nd7

The other move Black plays is 7...Qa6 but after 8 Qh3 White has the freer game. Note that Black can't play 8...c5? because the sacrifice 9 Nxd5! gives White a winning attack.

8 0-0 Ne7 9 a4

9 b4!?, to prevent Black playing ...c6-c5, has been tried recently and we may well see more of it in the future. 9...Qxb4 10 Rb1 followed by Rxb7 is good for White so Black should probably play 9...a5.

9...c5 10 a5 Qa6

Until recently Black usually played 10...Qc6 but this is not so good because of the reply 11 dxc5!. The queen, which would be perfectly comfortable on c6 in a closed position, now becomes a target for the white pieces.

11 b4!? (Diagram 2)

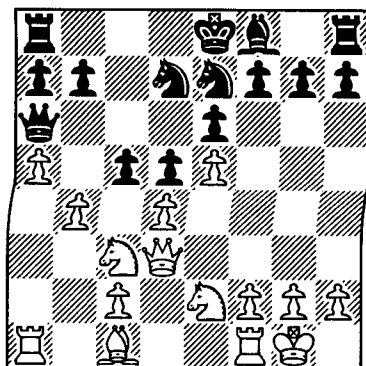


Diagram 2
What's this?

This move needs some explaining. At first glance 10...Qa6 looks like a losing blunder because of the reply 11 Nb5, threatening both Nc7+ and Nd6+. But Black has a resource, 11...c4!, when 12 Nc7+ Kd8 13 Nxa6 cxd3 is winning and 12 Nd6+ Qxd6! very promising for him. So White's primary idea is to deflect the c-pawn. 11...cxb4, for example, is met by 12 Nb5! and Black no longer has the move 12...c4. After 11...cxd4, however, 12 Nb5 is less convincing because after 12...Nxe5 13 Nc7+ Kd7 14 Qxa6 bxa6 15 Nxa8 N7c6 Black will collect the knight in the corner and have good compensation for the exchange. The move 11 b4 contains another idea. After 11...cxd4 12 b5! Nxe5 13 bxa6 Nxd3 14 cxb7 Rb8 15 cxd3 dxc3 16 a6 White should be winning. Exchanging queens doesn't help Black either as he is still left facing the threat of Nb5. Therefore that just leaves...

11...c4 12 Qh3 b5

Black takes advantage of the pin on the a-file to block up the whole queenside. This will now become a safe home for his king. Normally such a position should still be favourable for White because of his space advantage, but here I am not so sure for a number of reasons:

- 1) White's light squared bishop, an important player in any kingside breakthrough, has been exchanged.
- 2) His king is on the wrong side of the board as he will want to advance his kingside pawns.
- 3) He will have to watch out for potential sacrifices on the b4 square (even after he has played Nd1 and c3, which are usually his next two moves).

I consider the chances to be about equal.

Theoretical?

Less so than the rest of the chapter.

Statistics

White's score against 4...Qb6 is only 52%, mainly because there are 160 games with 5 g4 in which he only managed 43%. If White sticks to 5 Bd3 or 5 Nf3 his score rises to 59%. Black scores extremely well with 4...h5 (52%) and 4...a6 (61%) but this latter example is based on only 30 games.

Game 43

□ Nunn ■ Dlugy

London 1986

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 h5

A pretty drastic move obviously designed to prevent g2-g4. Black is basically saying that he doesn't think much of White's position if he can't play g4. There is some truth in this but, on the other hand, ...h7-h5 is a very committal move that weakens Black's kingside and reduces his options. White's main decision now is whether or not to exchange off Black's active but theoretically bad bishop on f5.

5 Bd3

After 5 Be2 e6 it is risky for White to play 6 Bxh5 as after 6...c5! the combination of a blazing queenside and an open h-file gives Black a dangerous initiative. White should probably play 6 Be3.

5...Bxd3 6 Qxd3 e6 7 Nf3

The position is quite similar to the theoretical section above except for that pawn sticking out on h5. With the g5-square vulnerable, it makes more sense for White to play with Nf3 than with Ne2.

7...Nh6

Black can also play 7...Qb6 8 0-0 Qa6, when White should keep queens with 9 Qd1.

8 0-0 Nf5?!

This move has been criticised as it presents a clear plan to White. 8...Nd7 is an alternative.

9 Ne2! (Diagram 3)

The idea is to exchange his passive knight on c3 for Black's active one on f5. At the same time he clears the way for the advance of his c-pawn.

9...Nd7 10 Ng3 Nh4

Black prefers to exchange the more active knight on f3 but loses time.

11 Nxh4 Qxh4 12 Be3 Qd8

12...Be7 would be nice if it didn't leave the queen stranded on h4.

13 Rfd1

White's plan is to play b2-b3 and c2-c4 but first he needs to defend his queen. Why? Well, after 13 b3 Be7 14 c4 dxc4 15 bxc4 Black has the little trick 15...Nxe5!.

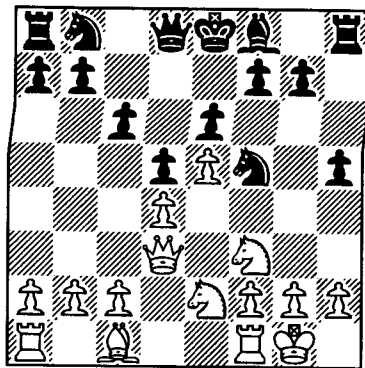


Diagram 3
The knight heads for g3

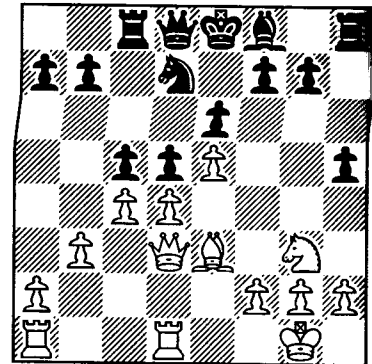


Diagram 4
Blasting open the centre

13...Rc8?

Black plans to meet fire with fire. The only problem is that he is up against an opponent who is far better armed. 13...Be7, followed by ...g7-g6 and walking his king to g7 would be the solid way to play such a position.

14 b3 c5 15 c4! (Diagram 4) 15...cxd4 16 cxd5! Nxe5

After 16...dxe3 17 dxe6 exf2+ 18 Kf1 White has a crushing attack. For example, 18...fxe6 19 Qg6+ Ke7 20 Rd6 and 18...Rc7 19 exf7+ Kxf7 20 e6+! Kxe6 (20...Kg8 21 Qd5 is also hopeless) 21 Qf5+ Ke7 22 Re1+!. In both cases Black can resign.

17 Qxd4 Qxd5 18 Qa4+ 1-0

Black probably overlooked 18...Qc6 19 Rac1 Qxa4 20 Rxc8+ but his position had already been on the way down for some time.

Game 44

□ **Klinger** ■ **Hodgson**

Oakham 1984

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 Qb6 5 g4?! Bd7! (Diagram 5)

After this retreat into the bosom of Black's position the pawn on g4 looks totally out of place.

6 Na4

White formulates a plan based on preventing, or at least delaying, Black's thematic advance ...c6-c5.

6...Qc7 7 Nc5

White gives himself the option of either taking the bishop on d7 or dropping the knight back to the useful d3-square.

7 Be3 is probably best met by 7...h5!? 8 gxh5 e6. The ideas are to gain control of the f5-square for later use and to virtually rule out kingside

castling by White. The doubled and isolated extra pawn is not of much use. We shall soon meet ...h5 again.

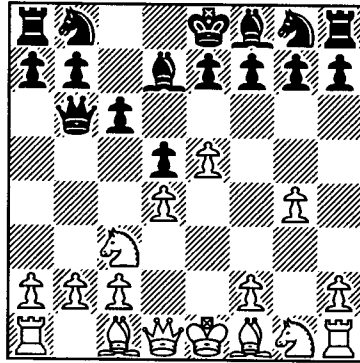


Diagram 5
White's g-pawn looks silly

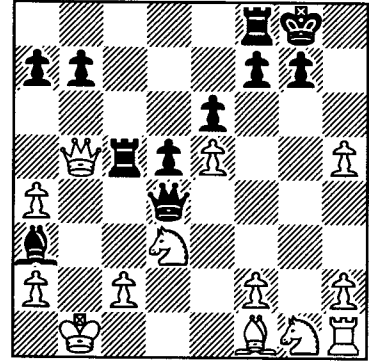


Diagram 6
The rook cannot be captured

Finally, some players believe that 7 Bg2 is the best move as this doesn't waste time like 7 Nc5, and allows 7...h5 to be met by 8 h3.

7...e6 8 Nd3

8 Nxd7 Nxd7 9 f4 c5 10 c3 Ne7 11 Nf3 h5 12 f5 hxc4 13 fxe6 gxf3 14 exd7+ Qxd7 15 Qxf3 cxd4 16 cxd4 Nc6 17 Be3 Bb4+ 18 Kf2 was the continuation of Velimirovic-Kasparov, Moscow 1982. Black should have now played 18...0-0-0, when his safer king position would have given him the advantage.

8...h5!?

A typical reaction from Hodgson, a man who craves the initiative, but perhaps it's not strictly necessary in this position. Michael Adams later showed that 8...c5 9 dxc5 Bb5! 10 f4 Bxc5 gives Black a good game.

9 gxf5 c5 10 dxc5 Na6! 11 Be3

Well, what about 11 b4? Doesn't that simply refute Black's play? No, that was the move Hodgson was hoping for! After 11 b4 Nxb4! 12 Nxb4 Qxe5+ 13 Be3 Qe4! Black forks the rook on h1 and the knight on b4.

A few years later in I.Gurevich-Hodgson, Philadelphia 1990, White preferred 11 Nh3 Nxc5 12 Nhf4 with the idea of maintaining his strong knight on d3 without having to give up his bishop. Black eventually won but this position should be okay for White.

11...Nxc5 12 Bxc5 Bxc5 13 Qg4 Bf8! 14 0-0-0 Nh6 15 Qe2 Nf5

Black reaps the benefits of his 8th move.

16 Nf4 Rc8 17 Kb1 Ba4 18 b3 Ba3!! 19 bxa4 0-0!

Wonderful play from Hodgson, reminiscent of the great Mikhail Tal,

who would often first sacrifice and then play a quiet move. 19...0-0 has the obvious benefit of bringing the black king to safety and the king's rook nearer the action, but it also introduces the concrete threat of Nd4. It is almost impossible to deal with.

20 Rd3

20 Qd3 doesn't stop 20...Nd4!, while 20 Nf3 Qc3 21 Nd3 Rc4, threatening ...Rb4+, is the end.

20...Nd4! 21 Rxd4

Neither would White last long after 21 Qd1 Nxc2.

21...Qb6+ 22 Qb5

The reason ...Nd4 didn't work with the black king on e8 is that this move would have been check.

22...Qxd4 23 Nd3 Rc5!! (Diagram 6)

Another wonderful move. Black is trying to force White to take on b7 in order to open the b-file.

24 Qxb7

Of course 24 Nxc5 Qd1 is mate, while Klinger doesn't even bother with 24 Qb3 Rc3 25 Qb5 as after 25...a6 he has to take on b7 anyway.

24...Rcc8! 25 Ne2 Qc4 26 Qb3

There is nothing better.

26...Rb8 27 Ng3 Rfc8!

Even stronger than taking the queen. Black threatens ...Qxc2+.

28 Nb4 Qxb4 29 Bb5 Qc5 0-1

After he wins the bishop with ...a7-a6 Black will be a rook up.

TIP: Play through this game again. It's rather good.



Main Line with 4...e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2 c5

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2

Once White has played a wild move like g2-g4 it is not enough for him to simply develop his pieces – he must develop purposively. The move he would like to play is 6 h4 but this is well met by 6...h5. The idea of the text is to prepare h2-h4 so that when Black replies ...h7-h5 White can play Nf4.

6...c5

This is the main line although in recent times more and more Black players have started to play 6...Ne7 (see the next section).

7 h4 (Diagram 7)

White indulges in a bit of traditional bishop hunting. The more solid 7 Be3 is examined in Game 45.

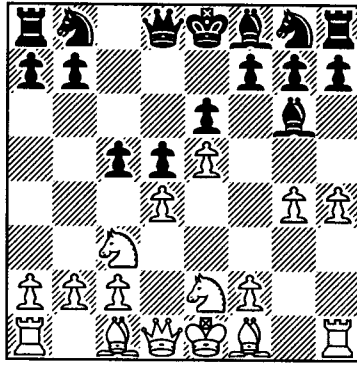


Diagram 7
White hunts the bishop

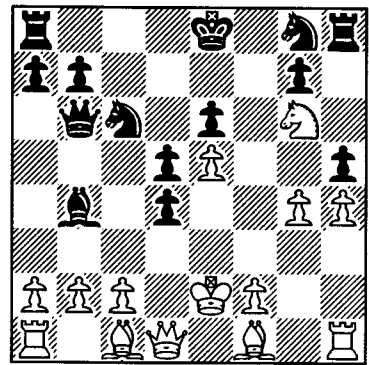


Diagram 8
A crazy position

7...h5

Black has two other important possibilities:

a) 7...h6 is the obvious way to save the bishop. White efforts have mainly centred on 8 Be3 Nc6 9 f4 but his results have been unspectacular. The best he can hope for there, it would seem, is a spot of mutual butchery. A more dangerous line for Black seems to be 8 f4. This move had not been taken seriously because of the reply 8...Be7 but in Shirov-Nisipeanu, FIDE World Championship, Las Vegas 1999, White calmly played 9 Bg2 Bxh4+ 10 Kf1 and eventually developed a very dangerous attack. Black has won a pawn and forced the white king to move but he has wasted valuable time. The next few moves were 10...Be7 11 f5 Bh7 12 Nf4 Qd7 and now Shirov played 13 Nh5, which is not bad, but ended up losing a wild encounter. The Russian Grandmaster Volzhin has analysed the position in depth and he is of the opinion that the piece sacrifice 13 Ncxd5 exd5 14 Bxd5 leaves Black in serious trouble. I agree with him.

b) Sometimes Black flicks in 7...cxd4 8 Nxd4 before playing 8...h5. The idea is that White can no longer destroy his kingside pawn structure with Nf4. But how clever can it be to lure the white knight to d4? It looks like, as compensation for missing out on Nf4, that White will have to settle for a massive attack instead! The key line is 9 Bb5+ Nd7 10 f4! hxg4 11 f5 Rxh4! 12 Rf1!. White is attempting to smash through via the e6-square and in practice he has notched up an incredible 91% from this position (37 games). That is not good enough for the theoreticians, though, and they suggest that 12...Rh5 is all right for Black. They argue that 13 fxg6 Qh4+ is unclear and, although I'm far from convinced that White isn't doing well here, a safer way for White to play is 13 Bxd7+ Kxd7 14 Qxg4 exf5 15 Nxf5 Rxf5 16 Rxf5 Bxf5 17 Qxf5+ Ke8 18 Bg5 with more than enough play for the pawn, Emodi-Volzhin, Hungary 1994.

8 Nf4 Nc6

Black has the choice between sacrificing a pawn with 8...Bh7 (see Game 46) or allowing his kingside pawn structure to be ruined. Of course he understood all this when he played 7...h5, but he is relying on counterplay in the centre.



NOTE: One of the main recurring themes throughout this chapter is the destruction of the white centre whilst he wreaks havoc on the kingside. It is impossible to generalise on which is the better strategy – each situation has to be judged on concrete factors.

9 Nxc6 fxc6 10 Ne2

The knight heads to the kingside and holds the centre together.

10...Qb6

Increasing the pressure. 10...Nge7 is a reasonable alternative while 10...hxc6 suffered a crushing defeat in Nunn-Seirawan, Monaco 1994. After 11 Nf4 Nh6?! 12 Nxc6 Nxd4 13 Nxh8 Nf3+ Black's attacking hopes were coolly snuffed out by 14 Qxf3!! gxf3 15 Bb5+, leaving him with the choice between 15...Ke7 16 Bg5 mate or the endgame a rook down after 15...Qd7.

11 Nf4 cxd4 12 Nxc6!?

After this move both sides are in trouble. 12 Bd3 is a saner looking alternative that vacates the f1-square for the king.

12...Bb4+ 13 Ke2 (Diagram 8)

White has little choice but to boldly advance his king as the position after 13 Bd2 Bxd2+ 14 Qxd2 Qxb2 15 Rd1 Rh6 is extremely unappealing for him.

The position after 13 Ke2 was first reached in Morozevich-Bareev, Sarajevo 2000. Morozevich, a player whose chess style is a throwback to the 19th century romantics, has never been adverse to such adventures. Play continued 13...hxc6 14 a3 Rh5! 15 axb4 Nge7 16 Nxe7 Rxe5+ 17 Kd2 Kxe7 with a totally chaotic position.

Theoretical?

You bet! See next 'Theoretical'.

Statistics

White has scored 57% from over 800 games against 6...c5. With 7 h4 his score is 59% but if Black plays the main line with 7...h5 then he keeps White down to a roughly average 53%. With the 7 Be3 of Game 45 White has scored 56% from 220 games.

Game 45

□ Sutovsky ■ Adianto

Batumi (rapid) 2001

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2 c5 7 Be3

This is a slightly more solid continuation than 7 h4, although to be honest White parted company with solidity once he played 4 Nc3 and 5 g4. The main ideas behind the text are to grab the pawn on c5 (admittedly at the cost of the e5-pawn) and to bring the king another step nearer to the relative safety of the queenside.

7...Nc6

7...cxd4!? 8 Nxd4 Bb4 was played recently by Grischuk, while the hard-working Slovakian Grandmaster Igor Stohl has played 7...Qb6. Perhaps these sidelines will become the main lines of the future.

8 dxc5 Nxe5

In Shirov-Morozevich, Monaco 2002, Black opted for 8...Rc8, his idea being to pick up the c-pawn rather than the e-pawn. After the further moves 9 Nd4 Nxd4 10 Qxd4 Bxc5 11 Qa4+ Kf8 12 Bxc5+ Rxc5 13 Qxa7 b6 14 Nb5 h5! 15 g5 Ne7 16 Nd4 Kg8 17 Qa3 Nc6 18 Nxc6 Rxc6 he had excellent positional compensation for the pawn. It will be interesting to see if anyone dares to play like this against Shirov again.

9 Nf4!?

Traditionally White has played 9 Nd4 but the text has been quite popular recently. It is useful in many variations to have the possibility of removing the bishop on g6, while in others there may even be a knight sacrifice on d5.

9...Nf6

Let's have a look at a couple of alternatives:

a) 9...d4 sets a little trap. If White plays 10 Bxd4 then Black simply replies 10...Qxd4! 11 Qxd4 Nf3+ and 12...Nxd4. Of course White doesn't fall for this and plays 10 Bb5+, with the point that if Black drops his knight back to block the check, then White simply takes the d-pawn. Therefore, Black has to go bravely forward with 10...Ke7 when, in order to save his piece, White must play 11 Nxc6+ hxc6 12 Bf4. Black then plays 12...f6 after which the knight on c3 still can't move because of ...Qa5+. White has to play 13 Bxe5 fxe5 14 Qf3!, daring Black to take the knight. In Apicella-Flouzat, French League 1998, he declined with 14...Rc8 but after 15 0-0-0 he was more or less lost. Instead, after 14...dxc3 15 Qxb7+ Kf6 White has a draw if he wants it with 16 Qf3+ but should probably try for more with 16 g5+ Kxg5 17 Rg1+ Kf6 18 Rd1.

b) In Sutovsky-Rogers, Batumi (rapid) 2001 (yes, the same event) Black preferred 9...Nc6. Play continued 10 Bb5 Nge7 11 Qe2 Qc7 12 h4!? (12 0-0-0 is more prudent) 12...d4 and now, rather than play 13 Nxc6, Sutovsky decided to sacrifice a piece with 13 Bxd4?! Qxf4 14 Be5 Qb4 15 0-0-0. Rogers now played 15...Qxc5?, allowing Sutovsky to regain it with 16 h5. Instead, 15...f6 or 15...h5 would have kept the extra material and left the onus on White to prove he has sufficient compensation for the piece. Somehow, I doubt that Sutovsky would have played like this with a slower time control.

10 Bb5+ Nfd7

The most obvious move, 10...Nc6, would also be met by 11 Qe2 and 0-0-0.

11 Qe2 (Diagram 9)

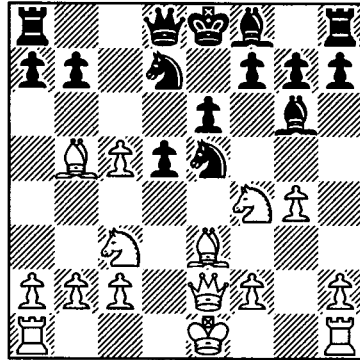


Diagram 9

White prepares to castle queenside

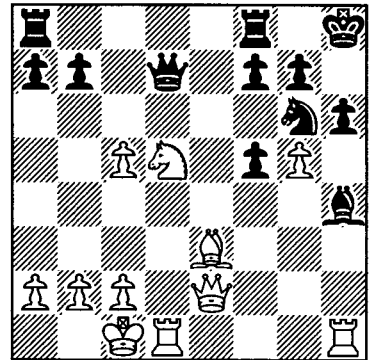


Diagram 10

Black's kingside will deteriorate

11...Be7 12 0-0-0 0-0 13 h4! Bxh4?

I was already a little sceptical about Black rushing his king to the kingside, but castling and then opening the h-file is madness. He should have played something like 13...Rc8 14 h5 Be4 15 Nxe4 dxe4 as there is no obvious way for White to take advantage of the pin on the d-file. Instead White might be better off playing 14 Nxd5 followed by h4-h5.

14 Nxd5 Nxd5 15 f4 h6 16 Bxd7! Qxd7 17 f5 exf5 18 Nxd5 Kh8 19 g5! (Diagram 10)

This is stronger than 19 Nb6. Now both 19...hxg5 and 19...Bxg5 just lose a piece so there is nothing Black can do to prevent his kingside crumbling. The remaining moves were:

19...Rae8 20 gxh6 f4 21 hxg7+ Kxg7 22 Bd4+ f6 23 Qg2 Qf5 24 Rxh4 f3 25 Qg3 f2 26 Qc7+ Rf7 27 Rh7+ Kxh7 28 Qxf7+ Kh6 29 Bxf2 Re2 30 Be3+ Kh5 31 Nf4+ 1-0

Game 46

□ David ■ Kallai

French League 1996

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2 c5 7 h4 h5 8 Nf4 Bh7

We saw 8...Nc6 in the theoretical section. This time Black is willing to give up a pawn to keep his bishop.

9 Nxh5 cxd4 10 Qxd4?!

Some white players have taken to playing 10 Nb5 here and this may

well be a better move. After 10...Nc6 11 Nxd4 Black should probably play the courageous 11...Nxe5. White has compensation after 12 Bb5+ or 12 Bf4 but Black is certainly in the game. He can also consider playing 10...Be4!?, as one of the leading experts on this line, the Hungarian Grandmaster Kallai, has started doing.

10...Nc6 11 Bb5 Nge7 12 Bh6

More flash than effective. After 12 Bg5 a6 13 Bxc6+ Nxc6! Black has also solved his opening problems.

12...Rg8! (Diagram 11)

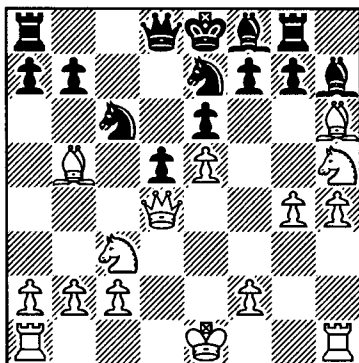


Diagram 11
Calm defence from Black

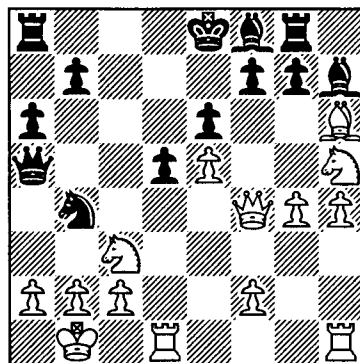


Diagram 12
Black's h7-bishop is a monster

An excellent reply. Naturally Black avoided 12...gxh6 13 Nf6 mate.

13 0-0-0 a6 14 Bxc6+ Nxc6 15 Qf4 Qa5 16 Kb1?

White should have been looking to exchange queens as after the text he is going to come under heavy fire. 16 Qa4 was the best chance of an equal game.

16...Nb4 (Diagram 12)

The long range power of the bishop on h7 makes itself felt. This is the sort of attack Black dreams about when playing 3...Bf5.

17 Rc1 Rc8 18 a3

Now we are in for a sacrificial treat!

18...Nxc2! 19 Rxc2 Rxc3! 20 bxc3 Qxc3! 21 Qc1

Whatever White does, Black wins back at least the rook and will keep his extra pawns. For example, 21 Qd2 Qb3+ 22 Kc1 Bxa3+ 23 Kd1 Qf3+ and the rook on h1 drops.

21...Qb3+ 22 Ka1 Bxc2 23 Qb2 Qxb2+!



WARNING: One of the most dangerous moments during a chess game is when you think it's all over and you are wallowing in your own wonderful play. Never drop your guard until the opponent has

resigned. Almost any position can be thrown away. Here, for example, there was still time for Black to blunder with 23...Bxa3?? 24 Qxb3 Bxb3 as after 25 Rh3! White wins one of the bishops.

24 Kxb2 Bg6 25 Bg5 Bxh5 26 gxh5 Bc5! 27 Kb3 Bd4 28 Re1 Rh8 29 Re2 Rxh5 30 Kc2 Bc5 0-1

Main Line: Alternatives to 6...c5

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2 Ne7

This move has gained in popularity dramatically over the last few years. Not long ago it warranted just a mere footnote and now it is virtually the main line. Black's idea is that before embarking on the mind-boggling complications that are the signature tune of this variation, he protects his bishop against the Nf4xg6 manoeuvre that ruins his pawn structure.

6...f6 is the subject of Game 47.

7 Nf4

7 h4?! is not very good now because after 7...h5 8 Nf4 hxg4!, 9 Nxg6 no longer destroys Black's pawn structure. That is the sort of thing we were talking about above. White must play Nf4 before h4 if he is going bishop hunting.

A dangerous alternative that White has begun to investigate recently is 7 f4. That is covered in Game 48.

7...c5

Of course vigorous play in the centre is the only way to test the soundness of White's set-up. 7...Nd7 8 h4 h6 9 Nxg6 Nxg6 10 h5 Ne7 is a more solid line but White's space advantage gives him an edge.

8 dxc5!

White players keep oscillating between the text and 8 h4 – and so do I. Originally I gave 8 dxc5 as the main line, then I switched to 8 h4, but the very latest twist means that we are back to 8 dxc5.

The main line of 8 h4 currently runs: 8 h4 cxd4 9 Nb5 Nec6 10 h5 Be4 11 f3 (the black bishop is lost but he is going to get a massive centre in return) 11...a6 12 Nd6+ (White has tried many moves here but he can't escape the fact that his king is awfully exposed) 12...Bxd6 13 exd6 g5! (it is much better to drive the knight to an inferior square than to take the doomed d-pawn at once) 14 Nh3 h6 15 fxe4 dxe4 16 Bg2 f5 when Black's massive centre gives him full compensation for the piece.

8...Nec6 (Diagram 13)

9 h4

The centre is collapsing. It's time to go after the bishop.

9...Qc7 10 h5! Qxe5+ 11 Nfe2!

The new move which has changed the evaluation of this line. Previ-

ously it was thought that White couldn't play like this because after 11 Be3 Be4 12 f3 the bishop on e3 is no longer defended and Black has the resource 12...Bxc2!.

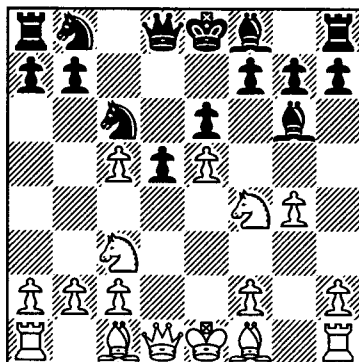


Diagram 13
Again the centre collapses

11...Be4 12 Bf4 Qf6 13 g5!

White is better after both 13...Ne5 (threatening the big one) 14 Rh3 Qf5 15 Bxe5 Qxe5 16 f4 Qc7 17 Nxe4 dxe4 18 Qd4 and 13...Qe7 14 Nxe4 dxe4 15 Nc3. I hope this verdict survives the book's trip to the printers.

Theoretical?

The main lines of 4 Nc3 are as sharp and as theoretical as it gets. I have merely scratched the tip of the iceberg here. In this book theoretical variations have been kept to the minimum in order not to bamboozle the reader and to keep space for verbal explanations. The danger of doing so here is that you may well stumble into a dastardly trap the move after I've stopped my variation. A final word of advice:



WARNING: If you are playing Black and like to play on general principles then GET OUT OF HERE. Run a mile or at least as far as 3...c5 or one of the 4th move alternatives. If you want to play this way with White then that is your choice but make sure you keep up with the latest games and ... Good luck!

Statistics

White has scored just 51% against 6...Ne7 from 214 games. If he plays 7 f4 then that rises to a crushing 81%. It's early days, though, as *there are only 18 games.*

Against 6...f6 White has only managed 52%, but when he plays 7 h4 that rises to 59%.

Game 47

□ Sax ■ Lauber

Gyula 1997

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2 f6

One of the first strategical lessons that young chess players are taught, after mastering the basics, is that an attack on the wing is best countered by an attack in the centre. The move 6...f6, then, is perfectly justified by old chess theory. But the move has never totally captured the hearts of Caro-Kann players. That is because it is easy enough for White to protect his centre while Black is creating weaknesses in his own camp.

7 h4

The other move that White plays quite often is 7 Nf4. Now Black has a choice between retreating his bishop or taking a chance with 7...fxe5:

a) After 7...Bf7 White does best to play 8 Qe2!, targeting the fresh weakness on e6. Now it may well be that Black's best move is 8...Qe7. but a number of games have continued 8...fxe5 9 Qxe5 Nd7 10 Qe2 Qe7 11 Nd3 Bg6 and now 12 h4! gives White the advantage. Black is caught between a hard place and a rock. If he allows the status quo to remain then White is better because of the weaknesses on the e-file (the e6-pawn and the e5-square). On the other hand, if he plays ...Bxd3 and ...e6-e5 in order to free his game then he will be opening the position for the bishop pair he has just conceded.

b) 7...fxe5! is the better move.

b1) Now 8 Nxg6 hxg6 9 dxe5 Nd7 10 Bf4 Bb4 doesn't trouble Black as White's position is an ugly mess. He has exchanged off his most active minor piece and the ones he has developed are passively placed.

b2) 8 dxe5 is a slight improvement but after 8...Bf7 9 Qe2 Nd7 the position is generally thought to be fine for Black.

b3) The critical line is 8 Nxe6 Qe7 9 Nxf8 exd4+ 10 Be2 dxc3 11 Nxg6 hxg6 12 Qd3 Nf6 with an interesting strategic battle ahead. On one side there are bishops in a relatively open position whilst on the other there are knights but with a more healthy structure. Theory has yet to deliver a final verdict on this position.

7...fxe5

If Black doesn't capture at once then White will be able to play f2-f4 and then recapture with the f-pawn. For example, 7...Nd7 8 h5 Bf7 9 f4 fxe5 10 fxe5 leaves Black passively placed and in potential danger on the f-file.

8 h5

The move order is actually important because if White thinks that 8 dxe5 Nd7 9 h5 is just going to transpose, then he is in for a surprise: 9...Nxe5!, threatening ...Nf3 mate, and after 10 f4 Be4! 11 Nxe4 Nf3+ 12 Kf2 dxe4 Black saves the piece and has the better game.

8...Bf7 9 dxe5 Nd7 10 f4 Qb6 (Diagram 14)

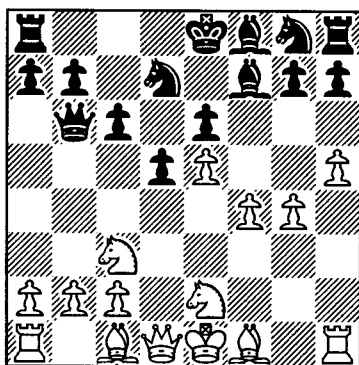


Diagram 14
Black is gasping for air

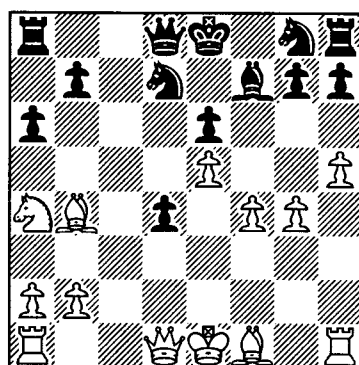


Diagram 15
White sees to the end

A strange position. At first glance it may look as if White has overdone it on the kingside but the reality is that Black's pieces are suffocating and he has no way to break up the pawn chain. With 10...Qb6 he hopes to get some counterplay on the g1-a7 diagonal. 10...Bc5 11 Nd4 Qb6 leads to the same position.

11 Nd4 Bc5

There are a couple of other moves:

a) 11...c5 is quite logical. Sax gives 12 Nf3 Ne7 13 Ng5 Bg8 14 Nb5 Nc6 15 c4 as better for White. This Nb5 and c2-c4 manoeuvre is quite instructive and typical for such positions. White is trying to force Black to advance his d-pawn as then he will gain control of the central light squares, and in particular e4.

b) 11...0-0-0 12 a3 c5 13 Nf3 Ne7 is well met by the pawn sacrifice 14 b4!. The idea is to open lines on the queenside in order to get at the black king.

12 Na4

In Chapter 9 we can see White react in similar fashion to a black battery on the g1-a7 diagonal.

12...Qa5+ 13 c3 Bxd4 14 Qxd4 c5 15 Qd1 a6

This move looks a little slow; 15...Ne7 may be best. What about 15...b5, I hear you ask? Doesn't this win the knight? Well, it does, but only for one move as after 16 Nxc5! Nxc5 17 b4 White regains the piece with advantage with the subsequent moves 17...Qb6 18 bxc5 Qxc5 19 Qd4!. Note that 19...Qxd4 can be met by the intermezzo 20 Bxb5+.

16 Be3 d4

This doesn't work out well but moves such as 16...Ne7 or 16...0-0-0

are strongly met by 17 Nxc5! Nxc5 18 b4. The move 16...Qc7 was best, although with 17 b4 White takes control of the dark squares and has a clear positional advantage.

17 Bd2 Qd8 18 cxd4 cxd4 19 Bb4! (Diagram 15)

Sax, without doubt, saw the final position here as otherwise he would have chosen a safer continuation.

19...b5 20 Nc5 Nxc5 21 Bxc5 Qd5 22 Qxd4! Qxh1 23 0-0-0! Qd5
 23...Qc6 or 23...Qb7 also lose to 24 Bg2!.

24 Bg2! 1-0

24...Qxg2 25 Qd7 is mate and 24...Qxd4 25 Bc6+! is totally hopeless.

Game 48

□ Svidler ■ Galkin

Tomsk 2001

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 e5 Bf5 4 Nc3 e6 5 g4 Bg6 6 Nge2 Ne7 7 f4!?

This looks like it is going to seriously test the popularity of 6...Ne7.

7...Na6

Black plans to launch a quick attack against c2 by playing ...Nb4. The most obvious move is 7...h5, but the positional sacrifice 8 f5! gxf5 9 g5 is most unpleasant for Black. White's idea is to blockade the kingside with Nf4 and h4 to kill off the bishop on g6. Black can try and free his game with 9...f4 but after 10 Nxf4 his problems are only just beginning.

8 Ng3!

8 h4? falls in with Black's plans. After 8...Nb4 9 f5 Nxf5! 10 gxf5 Bxf5 11 Kf2 Nxc2 12 Rb1 c5 Black has more than enough compensation for the piece. After the careful 8 Ng3! White's control of f5 makes such a sacrifice impossible.

8...Nb4 9 f5 exf5 10 a3 f4 (Diagram 16)

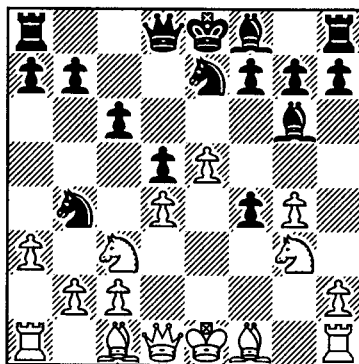


Diagram 16
 10...f4 – the only move

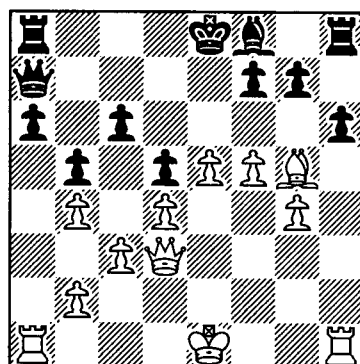


Diagram 17
 White is on a roll

The depth of White's play is revealed after 10...Na6, which he meets with 11 Nb5!. The point is that after 11...cxb5 12 Bxb5+ Nc6 the black knight has been dragged away from f5. After first playing 13 Bxc6+ bxc6 so that he doesn't lose his bishop to ...Qa5+, White regains his piece with advantage after 14 gxf5.

11 axb4 fxc3 12 hxc3 a6

This stops White from playing b4-b5 (he had gained the advantage in an earlier game after 12...Nc8 13 b5) but allows the annoying pin.

13 Bg5 Qb8?! 14 Bd3 Qa7 15 Ne2 b5 16 c3

White takes it nice and easy, waiting to see how Black is going to resolve his kingside traffic jam.

16...Bxd3 17 Qxd3 Ng6 18 Nf4 Nxf4 19 gxf4

The pawns are just going to roll forward.

19...h6 20 f5 (Diagram 17) 20...Qc7 21 Qe3 a5

A rather desperate attempt for activity but the opening of the a-file just helps White.

22 e6 f6 23 Bf4 Qf8 24 Qh3 h5 25 gxh5 axb4 26 Ke2! Ra4 27 Qg3 Qe7 28 b3 Ra3 29 cxb4 Qxb4 30 Bd2 1-0

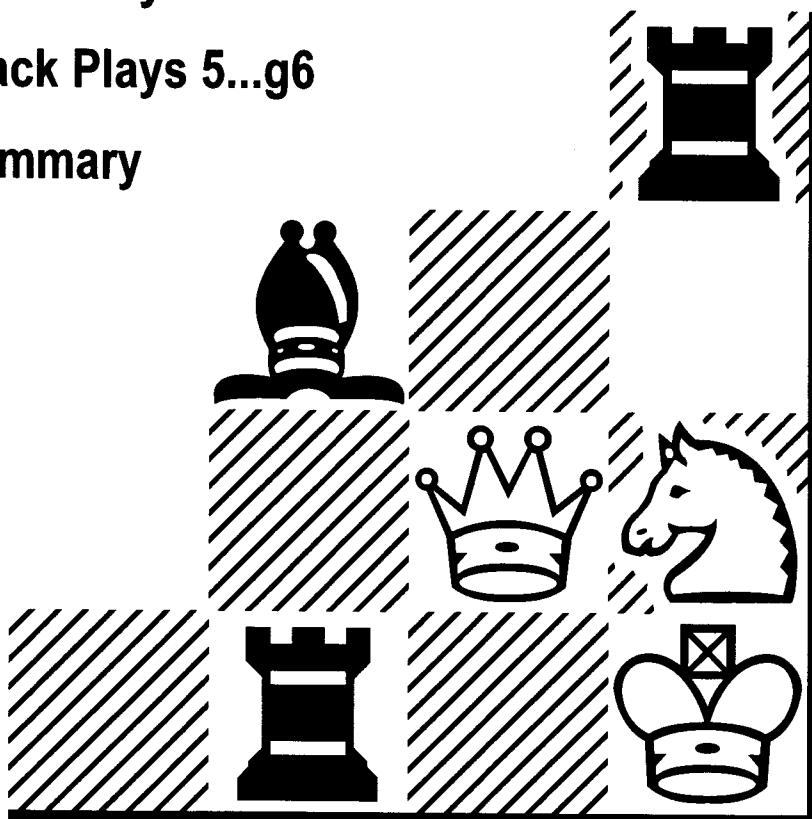
Summary

- 1) This chapter contains the most tactically complex and theoretically heavy material in the book.
- 2) The 4th move alternatives to 4...e6 are a relatively safe haven for those black players looking for a quieter life.
- 3) Of Black's three main choices on move 6 in the main line, 6...Ne7 is popular but maybe not for long, 6...c5 is a vast topic with assessments constantly changing and 6...f6 is less popular mainly because of the reply 7 h4.

Chapter Eight

The Panov-Botvinnik Attack

-  Introduction
-  Black Plays 5...e6
-  Black Plays 5...Nc6
-  Black Plays 5...g6
-  Summary



Introduction

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 (Diagram 1)

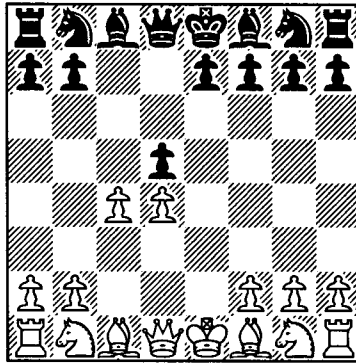


Diagram 1
The Panov-Botvinnik Attack

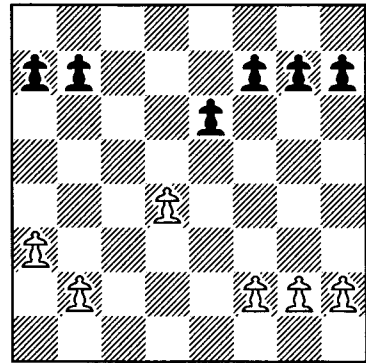


Diagram 2
An IQP structure

The Panov-Botvinnik Attack is named after the little known Soviet master Vasily Panov (1906-1973) and one of the all time chess greats, Mikhail Botvinnik, World champion from 1948-63 with a couple of one-year gaps. Panov was the man who set the ball rolling but important contributions from Botvinnik in the 1930s and 1940s led to his name tagging on. In the latter part of his career Botvinnik rarely played 1 e4 so there was no longer much input from him to the variation. Another famous World Champion, Alexander Alekhine, also played the line extensively but as there was already a major opening bearing his name he was left out of the equation. Nowadays the line is popular at all levels of chess. Not only has the variation remained popular with the chess elite (nearly all the world's best have played it recently), but it also has a strong grassroots following that helps to cement its place as one of the major variations of the Caro-Kann.

What are the ideas behind the Panov-Botvinnik Attack and, while you're at it, can you also tell me a bit about isolated pawns and IQP's in particular?

The idea behind 4 c4 is simply to bring pressure on the black centre so that he doesn't get a turbulence free ride to the middlegame. There are several types of position that can arise but in all of them White will have free and easy development for his pieces. The price he has to pay for this freedom is a weak d-pawn. Very often a structure such as the following will arise (the main exception being when White advances c4-c5). Take a look at **Diagram 2**.



NOTE: White's d-pawn is said to be isolated as there are no friendly pawns on adjacent files.

An isolated pawn is usually a disadvantage as, if attacked, it cannot be defended by another pawn. It will have to be defended by a piece or sacrificed. The other main drawback to isolated pawns is that the square in front of them cannot be attacked by a pawn and thus it becomes an ideal outpost for enemy forces. The more central the outpost the more valuable it is. And they don't come much better than the d5-square, the outpost Black has in his possession here.

So, why does White willingly go in for a position with an isolated queen's pawn (IQP). Well, to start with these IQP positions are a bit special. They have a life and a culture all of their own. They can arise from many different openings and whole books have even been devoted to the subject of the IQP.

So what advantages does the pawn structure from the previous diagram bestow upon White? Well, firstly, he has the more advanced central pawn and that provides him with more space. Secondly, the fact that there are no white pawns on the c and e-files means that these open (or half-open) files can be used profitably by White's major pieces. White is usually looking to transform these advantages into a direct attack while Black will often have to soak up early pressure before he can start to feel the benefits of his position. IQP positions can be thought of as a sort of gambit line where White (or sometimes Black) accepts a positional weakness in return for attacking chances.



TIP: As an extremely rough guide I tend to think of IQP positions with four sets of minor pieces as favourable for White, ones with three sets of minor pieces as about level and when it gets down to just two sets, then things are starting to turn Black's way. That is because with fewer pieces there is less chance of a successful attack. This rule assumes that White has the IQP and that the major pieces are still on the board.

How should Black Organise his Forces?

After the virtually universal moves 4...Nf6 5 Nc3 Black has three basic ways of handling the position.

- 1) He can defend his centre with the solid 5...e6. This is Black's most popular way of meeting the Panov-Botvinnik and is the line that often leads to the classic IQP position. It is discussed in the next section.
- 2) He can rapidly develop his queenside with ...Nc6 and ...Bg4 (or ...Be6). This would be quite risky if it wasn't for the fact that it is backed up by a lot of theory. This is discussed in the second section.
- 3) Black can play 5...g6 in order to deploy his king's bishop most actively on the long diagonal. However, this line involves a pawn sacrifice so may not be to everyone's taste.

Black Plays 5...e6

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 e6 (Diagram 3)

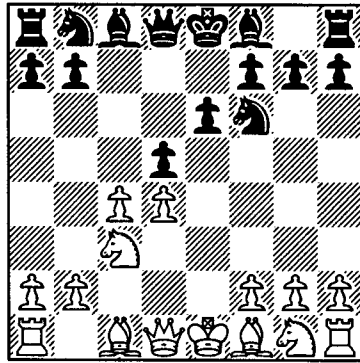


Diagram 3
The solid choice

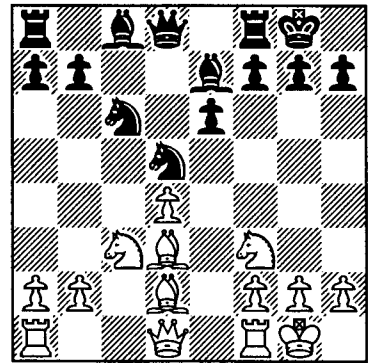


Diagram 4
The d-file is cluttered

As mentioned above, this is the most solid move at Black's disposal. He defends his centre and plans to develop his kingside as quickly as possible.

6 Nf3

White is going to have to make a decision in the centre. The choice is between playing c4-c5 in order to create a dangerous queenside pawn majority, or to capture on d5 after which his attention will most likely be focused on the kingside. Black may take this decision out of White's hands by capturing on c4, but he will be reluctant to do so as this just aids White's development.

TIP: In such positions Black normally only plays ...dxc4 once White has moved his king's bishop.

If White really wants to play with c5, then 6 c5 is an option. This is the subject of Game 49 but this line, though complicated, is considered relatively harmless for Black.

6...Bb4

Black's main choice is between the text and 6...Be7. They are equally popular and the latter is covered in Game 50.

One move that Black should avoid is 6...Nc6?! as the reply 7 c5! gives White a favourable version of Game 49. With the knight already on c6 it is harder for Black to break up White's queenside. This is because the knight can be annoyed by both Bb5 and the pawn advance b2-b4-b5. If Black wants to play with ...Nc6 then he should do so before he locks his bishop in with ...e7-e6 (5...Nc6 is one of the main lines and is considered later).

7 cxd5

White clarifies the central situation before deciding on his scheme of development. Alternatives such as 7 a3 Bxc3+ 8 bxc3 dxc4 9 Bxc4 Qc7



and 7 Bd3 dxc4 are considered relatively harmless for Black, while 7 c5 no longer makes much sense and is well met by 7...Ne4. Finally, 7 Bd3 dxc4 8 Bxc4 leads to similar IQP positions to the main line.

7...Nxd5

Entering an IQP position is far more popular than maintaining the symmetry with 7...exd5, even though this line offers Black good chances of equality and at worst a small disadvantage. Here are a couple of possible continuations:

a) 8 Bd3 0-0 9 Ne5 Nc6 (9...Ne4 is also played quite often) 10 Nxc6 bxc6 11 0-0 Bg4 12 Qc2 Bh5 and Black will follow up with Bg6 in order to exchange of his 'bad bishop'. His pawn structure on the queen-side may be slightly inferior but White's edge, if it exists, is small.

b) 8 Qa4+ Nc6 9 Bb5 0-0 10 Bxc6 Bxc3+ 11 bxc3 bxc6 and now 12 Qxc6 is risky with the white king still in the centre while 12 0-0 Qb6 13 Ba3 Re8 14 Ne5 Ne4 leads to an equal game.

8 Bd2

8 Qc2 is an alternative way to defend the knight. After 8...Nc6 9 Bd3 we have:

a) 9...Ba5 is extremely ambitious. Black's idea is that after 10 a3, preventing ...Nb4, he can win a pawn with 10...Nxc3 11 bxc3 Nxd4 12 Nxd4 Qxd4. However, after 13 Bb5+ Bd7 14 0-0 Qd5 15 c4 Qf5 16 Bxd7+ Kxd7 his king is stranded in an open centre. Certain black players think they can get away with this because the material is somewhat reduced, but I don't really recommend to anyone to play in this fashion. 17 Qb2 b6 18 a4! is not easy for Black to deal with.

b) 9...Be7 is a more solid reaction. After 10 a3 Black is not ready to castle so must choose between 10...Nf6 or 10...h6. Although the latter move is usually considered a serious weakness in such positions, here the white queen and bishop are the wrong way round to exploit it.

8...0-0 9 Bd3 Nc6 10 0-0 Be7 (Diagram 4)

An interesting moment. You may have noticed that Black has played ...Bb4 and then returned the bishop voluntarily to e7. If we compare this to Game 50, where he played ...Be7 directly, White has been given the developing move Bd2 for free. This is not an oversight by Black but an argument that the bishop is inferior on d2 to on c1. The logic behind this is that the bishop just gets in the way of the white queen. Not only does it interfere with her protection of the d-pawn, which allows Black to target and win this pawn in certain lines, but it also hinders the standard white attacking plan of Bc2 and Qd3.

I think it would be fair to conclude that having the bishop already on d2 somewhat restricts White's options but that still does not mean that Black is in for an easy game.

11 Qe2

This looks the most accurate, so that 11...Bf6 can be met by 12 Qe4.

11...Nf6

This retreat is played quite often in such positions as the knight is often needed on f6 to defend its king.

12 Ne4 Qb6

An active move that will keep White's mind on his loose pawns, even if for the moment Black is not ready to take either of them.

12...Nxd4?, for example, leads to trouble after 13 Nxd4 Qxd4 14 Bc3 Qd8 15 Nxf6+ Bxf6 16 Rad1 as the move Black would like to play, 16...Qe7, just loses an exchange to 17 Qe4 g6 18 Bb4.

After 12...Qb6, the game Kamsky-Karpov, Elista 1996 continued 13 a3 Bd7 14 Rfd1 Rad8 15 Nxf6+ (15 b4 is better) 15...Bxf6 16 Qe4 g6 17 Be3 Ne7! with good play for Black. His knight is heading for f5 to attack the isolated pawn and the bishop is going to c6 to occupy a fine diagonal.

White didn't play the last few moves very well. It would have been better to have switched plan and turned his attention to the queen-side, playing something like 14 Be3 Nd5 15 b4 and following up with moves such as Rfc1 and Nc5. In that way, I believe, he can still hope for an opening plus.

Theoretical?

There is a fair amount of theory to be learnt and some general ideas that have to be assimilated. Reading middlegame books which deal in more detail with the IQP should also be beneficial.

Statistics

After 5...e6 White has an overall score of 57%. Breaking this down, White has scored an excellent 61% from 1500 games against the main line of 6...Be7 (i.e. the position after move 9 in Game 50) but Black does much better when he plays 6...Bb4. Against this White only manages 53%.

Game 49

□ Rajlich ■ Groszpeter

Paks 2001

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 e6 6 c5

This advance is one of the basic ideas of the Panov-Botvinnik and can be very dangerous for the unprepared black player. However, by careful and above all energetic play Black should be able to fully equalise the game. The main drawback to playing c4-c5 is that it takes all the pressure of the black centre. On the plus side it creates a dangerous queenside pawn majority and has a cramping effect on the black game. The plan Black adopted in this game is the correct way to nullify an early c4-c5 (6 Nf3 Be7 7 c5 is another common move order).

First, though, the king is brought to safety.

6...Be7 7 Nf3 0-0 8 Bd3 b6!

Black starts the process of breaking up the white pawn structure

9 b4

9 cxb6 Qxb6 would just be an admission that White's strategy has failed. He must make every effort to keep his advanced pawn.

9...a5! (Diagram 5)

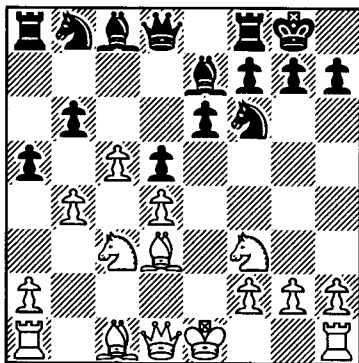


Diagram 5

Black attempts to break the bind

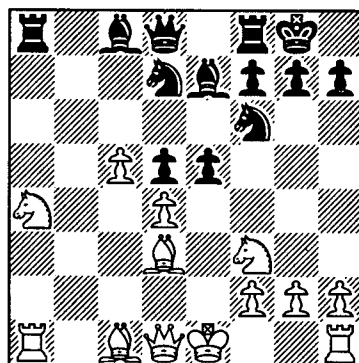


Diagram 6

Striking from another direction

The tension rises. Black takes advantage of the fact that 10 a3 is no good to force White into a decentralising manoeuvre.

10 Na4! Nbd7 11 a3

11 c6 just drops a pawn to 11...Bxb4+, but another white idea is to play 11 Bf4, waiting for 11...axb4 before playing 12 c6. Now of course 12...Nb8 just loses to 13 c7 so Black should play 12...Nh5 13 Bd2 (after 13 cxd7 Bxd7 two white pieces are attacked) 13...Nc5!? 14 dxc5 bxc5, with an armada of queenside pawns in return for the piece.

11...axb4 12 axb4 bxc5 13 bxc5 e5! (Diagram 6)

Just when White thought he was going to get a moment's peace, Black strikes in the centre.

14 Nxe5

14 dxe5 Nxc5! is good for Black.

14...Bxc5! 15 0-0

Neither 15 dxc5 Nxe5 nor 15 Nxd7 Bb4+ leave White very well placed.

15...Nxe5 16 dxe5 Ne4

The complications now peter out into a drawn endgame.

16...Ng4 is more tricky as after 17 Bf4 Nxf2! White is in some danger because of his uncoordinated forces. However, by playing 17 Bxh7+! Kxh7 18 Qc2+ followed by 19 Qxc5, he can maintain the balance.

17 Bxe4 dxe4 18 Qxd8 Rxd8 19 Bg5 Rd5 20 Nxc5 Rxa1 21 Rxa1

Rxc5 22 Rc1 ½-½

Why didn't they play another move? After 22...Rxc1 23 Bxc1 a position of perfect symmetry would have arisen. Quite remarkable, considering the course of the game.

Game 50

□ Adams ■ Doettling

French League 2002

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 e6 6 Nf3 Be7 7 cxd5 Nxd5

Here, too, Black has the option of recapturing with the pawn, but practice has demonstrated that the position after 7...exd5 8 Bb5+ Bd7 (or 8...Nc6 9 Ne5 Bd7 10 0-0 0-0 11 Re1 with an edge to White) 9 Bxd7+ Nbx d7 10 Qb3 Nb6 11 0-0 is uncomfortable for Black. White usually follows up with Re1 and Bg5.

8 Bd3

A better square than c4 as once Black castles, h7 will be his weakest point.

8...0-0 9 0-0 Nc6

This position is extremely well known to chess theory as it arises not only from the Caro-Kann, but from a variety of other openings as well. One of the most popular alternative move orders is through a variation of the Queen's Gambit Declined called the Semi-Tarrasch. The usual move order there is 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 Nc3 Nf6 4 Nf3 c5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 e3 Nc6 7 Bd3 cxd4 8 exd4 Be7 9 0-0 0-0.

10 Re1 Nf6

Black's least active piece is his light-squared bishop and he would like to deploy it on the long diagonal. However, 10...b6? is a serious mistake because of the reply 11 Nxd5 exd5 (11...Qxd5 12 Be4 and 13 Qc2 is even worse) 12 Bxh7+! Kxh7 13 Qc2+ and 14 Qxc6, when White has won a pawn. Therefore 10...Nf6 can be looked upon as paving the way for the development of the queen's bishop.

Another move that Black plays quite often is 10...Bf6. After White defends his d-pawn with 11 Be4 Black usually plays 11...Nce7 in order to keep control of the important d5-square. A typical continuation then has been 12 Ne5 g6 (12...Bd7 may be a slight improvement) 13 Bh6 Bg7 14 Bxg7 Kxg7 15 Qf3. White's idea now is to capture on d5 with his bishop in order to bring about a good knight versus bad bishop position (this assumes that Black will have to recapture with a pawn on d5). This should give him a nagging edge long into the end-game.

11 a3

White plans to play Bc2 and Qd3 in order to create threats against the black kingside. If he didn't pre-empt this with a2-a3 then Black would simply reply ...Nb4 and exchange off the powerful bishop.

11...b6 12 Bg5

White delays 12 Bc2 in order to deny Black the possibility of 12...Ba6!?. However, very often Black doesn't take up this option and just meets 12 Bc2 with 12...Bb7. After 13 Qd3 Black must then take great care as innocent moves like 13...Re8 and 13...Rc8 get blown away by 14 d5!. For example, 13...Rc8 14 d5! exd5 15 Bg5! when White threatens Bxf6 and Qxh7 mate. Black can stop this with 15...g6 but then 16 Rxe7! wins, while the only other move 15...Ne4 also leads to a hopeless situation after 16 Nxe4 dxe4 17 Qxe4. So Black must meet 13 Qd3 with 13...g6!, when 14 Bh6 Re8 15 Rad1 leads to a fairly typical IQP position similar to the main game.



NOTE: The advance d4-d5 is an important theme in these IQP positions. Here are three reasons White might want to play d4-d5:

- 1) To take advantage of a tactical opportunity as in the line above. The opening of the e-file is often crucial.
- 2) In order to open the centre to exploit his more active pieces.
- 3) In order to try and equalise by eliminating the weak isolated pawn.

Of course on many occasions the d5-square is firmly under Black's control and there is no possibility to play d4-d5.

12...Bb7 13 Bc2 Nd5

Now that Black has completed his ...b7-b6 and ...Bb7 manoeuvre, the black knight returns to the centre to try and exchange pieces.



NOTE: Exchanges in these IQP positions usually favour Black as the less pieces there are, the less chance there is of White launching a successful attack, and the more relevant structural defects become.

13...Rc8 is also played quite often, but after 14 Qd3 g6 15 Bh6 Re8 16 Rad1 Nd5 17 Ba4 we have just transposed back into the main line 14 Qd3 (Diagram 7)

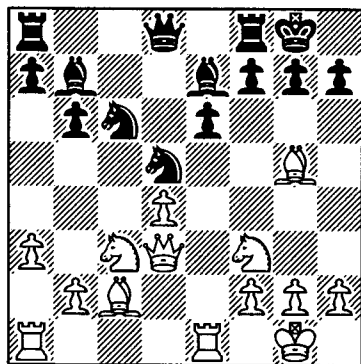


Diagram 7
A powerful battery

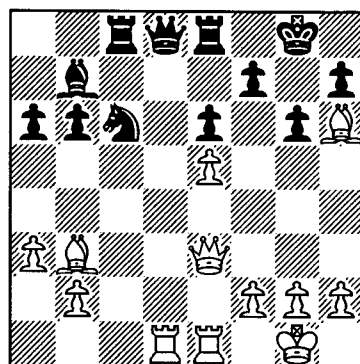


Diagram 8
Black has dark-squared weaknesses

14...g6 15 Bh6 Re8 16 Rad1 Rc8 17 Ba4!

The black position is now under quite serious pressure.

17...a6 18 Nxd5 Qxd5

18...exd5 looks like a terrible move as it kills off the b7 bishop, but who knows, maybe it's objectively the best move.

19 Qe3! Bf6 20 Bb3 Qd8

20...Qh5 21 d5! Nd8 22 d6 once led to a crushing defeat for the young Karpov.

21 Ne5!

This rather obvious-looking move is in fact the first new move of the game and was prepared just beforehand by Adams.

21...Bxe5

It's rather sad to give up the bishop like this but how else is Black to deal with the thematic threat of Nxf7 followed by Bxe6+?

22 dxe5 (Diagram 8) 22...Qc7 23 Rc1

After a long think examining more direct continuations, White concluded that Black was often able to save himself with the manoeuvre ...Ne7-f5. Adams, therefore, decided to pin the knight and in certain cases he may even remove it. For example, after 23...b5 24 Bg5 Qb8 25 Rxc6! Bxc6 26 Bf6 Black will soon be mated on g7.

23...Qb8

In view of variations such as the above, Black decides to break the pin immediately, even if it means jettisoning a pawn or two.

24 Qxb6 Ne7 25 Bxe6! Rc6 26 Rxc6 Bxc6 27 Qxb8 Rxb8 28 Bc4 1-0

Black resigned a bit prematurely although the ending is lost.

Black Plays 5...Nc6

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 Nc6

On the face of it, this is more aggressive than 5...e6, but with the main line worked out long into the endgame this is illusory.

6 Nf3

If White wants to steer clear of the main line then 6 Bg5 is the alternative. Black has not really settled on one defence as there are several which offer him good chances of equality. Here is a snapshot of the current state of theory after 6 Bg5:

a) 6...e6 7 Nf3 (7 cxd5 exd5 is thought to only offer equality) 7...Be7 (7...dxc4 is a slight concession some Black players make to guarantee an IQP position) 8 c5 0-0 9 Bb5 Ne4 10 Bxe7 Nxe7 with a roughly level game. Black's plan will be to play ...b7-b6 to try and break up the white queenside.

b) 6...Qa5 7 a3 Ne4 8 Bd2! is a bit better for White.

c) 6...Be6 7 a3!? Qd7 8 Bxf6 gxf6 9 c5 Bg4 10 f3 Bf5 is unclear.

d) 6...dxc4 7 d5 Ne5 8 Qd4 h6 9 Bf4 Ng6 10 Bxc4 Nxf4 11 Qxf4 a6 is usually assessed as roughly level. White has a lead in development but if nothing happens to Black over the next few moves (while he is attempting to fianchetto and castle) then he can look forward to the future with some confidence.

6...Bg4

If I was to dump all my theoretical baggage and examine this position through fresh eyes, then my first reaction would be that Black's strategy is rather risky. True, he is developing his queenside pieces actively and creating pressure against White's weak d4-pawn, but he is neglecting the development of his kingside. He is not even close to evacuating his king from the centre.



WARNING: This sort of chess is liable to lead to accidents. In this particular variation practice has proved that Black can get away with it (although not without some casualties along the way) but this might not always be the case.

7 cxd5 Nxd5 8 Qb3 (Diagram 9)

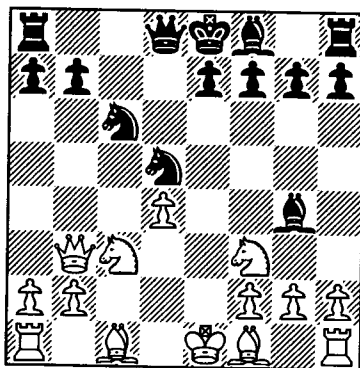


Diagram 9

White attacks d5 and b7

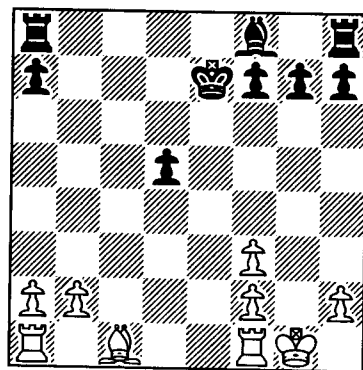


Diagram 10

From the opening to the endgame

The calm 8 Be2!? may be a line for the future. The Israeli Grandmaster Mikhalevski claims that White is doing rather well after 8...e6 9 0-0 Be7 10 h3 Bh5 11 Qb3!. It certainly has the benefit of avoiding the long theoretical line and the endgame that follows.

8...Bxf3 9 gxf3 e6

Other moves are inferior:

a) 9...Nxd4 loses to 10 Bb5+.

b) 9...Nb6 10 d5 Nd4 11 Bb5+ Nd7 12 Qa4 Nxb5 (12...Nxf3+ 13 Kf1 is good for White) 13 Qxb5 g6 14 0-0 Bg7 15 Re1 0-0 16 Bg5 and White's

activity more than compensates for his damaged pawn structure.

10 Qxb7 Nxd4 11 Bb5+ Nxb5 12 Qc6+

White takes the opportunity to embarrass the black king as 12...Qd7 fails to 13 Qxa8.

12...Ke7 13 Qxb5 Qd7! 14 Nxd5+

White can avoid the exchange of queens (14 Qe2, for example), but rarely does so as in the middlegame he may well find that it is his king that is more exposed. Black can improve the position of his king with ...f7-f6 and ...Kf7 but there is nowhere really safe for the white king.

14...Qxd5 15 Qxd5

15 Bg5+ f6 16 Qxd5 exd5 17 Be3 Ke6 18 0-0-0 Bb4 is another version of the same ending. Black holds the balance here as well.

15...exd5 16 0-0 (Diagram 10)



TIP: In the ending the king is a powerful piece. If it has the choice between cowering away in a corner or being in the thick of the action it will take the latter unless there is serious danger of getting checkmated.

So why did White castle then? Well he wants to activate his rooks as quickly as possible and he didn't want his king obstructing them. It was equally possible to play 16 Be3 and keep his king in the centre.

16...Ke6!

This endgame has been reached on countless occasions in master chess. It is slightly more comfortable for White as the weaknesses on the black queenside are more relevant than the ones on White's kingside. But with Black's king so active and the material quite reduced, the final result is usually a draw. See Game 51 for an example.

Theoretical?

The theory of this line must be studied but, while complex on the surface, there are not too many branches. It would also be advisable to study the endgames that arise from this variation.

Statistics

White has scored 55% against 5...Nc6 (just over 3000 games). If we take the ending from the main line White has scored 56%, although a very high 64% of the games end in draws. With 6 Bg5 White's score rises slightly to 58%. Black's most successful reply is 6...Be6 (45%) followed by 6...e6 (43%).

Game 51

□ Adams ■ Dreev

Wijk aan Zee 2002

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 Nc6 6 Nf3 Bg4 7 cxd5

Nxd5 8 Qb3 Bxf3 9 gxf3 e6 10 Qxb7 Nxd4 11 Bb5+ Nxb5 12 Qc6+ Ke7 13 Qxb5 Qd7 14 Nxd5+ Qxd5 15 Qxd5 exd5 16 0-0 Ke6 17 Re1+ Kf5 (Diagram 11)

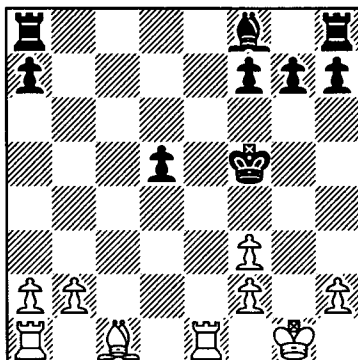


Diagram 11

Black has an active king

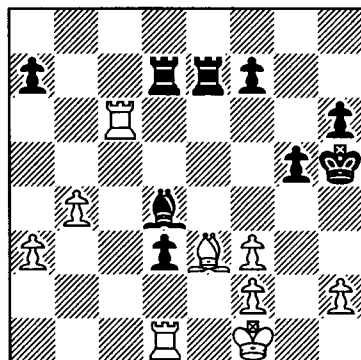


Diagram 12

Heading for a rook and pawn ending

There cannot be many lines known to opening theory where after 17 moves one side has everything still at home except for a far advanced king. But what a well-placed king – there is probably no better square for it. On f5 it is active whilst also enjoying a fair degree of shelter from the white rooks.

18 Rd1 Rd8 19 Be3 Rd7 20 Rac1 Be7 21 Rd4 g5!

Black doesn't allow his king to be driven back by Rf4+.

22 Ra4 Bf6 23 b4 d4 24 Ra5+ Kg6 25 Bd2 Re8 26 Kf1 d3 27 Rd1 h6 28 Be3 Bc3 29 a3 Ree7 30 Ra6+ Kh5 31 Rc6 Bd4! (Diagram 12)

Activity is the name of the game. It would be much worse to retreat the bishop to g7 and then remain idle while White advanced his queenside pawns.

32 Rxd3 Bxe3 33 Rxd7 Rxd7 34 fxe3 Rd3 35 Kf2 Rxa3 36 Rf6 Rb3 37 Rxf7 Kh4 38 Rxa7 Rb2+ 39 Kg1 ½-½

Black Plays 5...g6

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 g6

This continuation is quite popular at club level without ever achieving total acceptance at master level. There is nothing wrong with the concept of fianchettoing the king's bishop – that is a fine idea – but Black won't be able to carry it out and hang on to his d5-pawn as well. The pawn White wins will be doubled and isolated and require constant protection, but it is still an extra central pawn which can have a great influence on the game. If for no other reason than White can return it

with d5-d6 at an inconvenient moment.

6 Qb3

This is now considered to be the most accurate move order. The alternative 6 cxd5 is considered in Game 52.

6...Bg7

Certainly not 6...dxc4 7 Bxc4, when White has a serious lead in development and Black is forced to play the ugly 7...e6.

7 cxd5 0-0 8 Be2

The play will now revolve almost totally around the pawn on d5. If Black can win it back and maintain a blockade of the d5-square then he will stand well. White therefore will be trying to hang onto this pawn until he can find a suitable moment to return it with the advance d5-d6. Typically, he develops with Be2-f3 and then Nge2 and Nf4 if necessary. Black also piles up on the d5-square and usually plays ...Nd7-b6, ...Qd7 and ...Rd8, with his light squared bishop going to either g4 or f5.

8...Nbd7

Certain black players prefer 8...Na6 9 Bf3 Qb6 in order to exchange queens. The generally held view is that after 10 Qxb6 axb6 11 Nge2 Nb4 12 0-0 Rd8 13 d6! (the first of many d6's) 13...Rxd6 14 Bf4 Rd7 15 Rfd1 Nbd5 16 Be5 that White has the more pleasant position.

9 Bf3 Nb6 10 Nge2 Bf5

Black envisages the manoeuvre ...Bf5-d3-c4 xd5 to take control of the position. A major alternative is 10...Bg4 in order to exchange off one of the principal defenders of d5. The problem is that after 11 Bxg4 Nxg4 the black knight is misplaced and time will be lost repositioning it. 12 Bf4 Nf6 13 d6! is thought to give White a positional advantage.

11 0-0 Bd3 (Diagram 13)

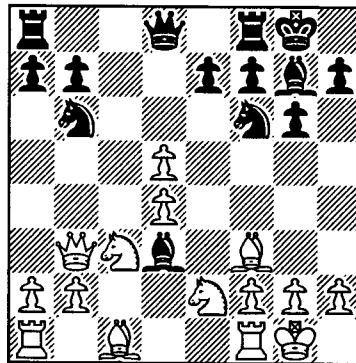


Diagram 13
Black plans ...Bc4

After this White can exchange his weakling on d5 for a real pawn on b7. Certain players prefer 11...Qd7 when one way for White to obtain an edge is 12 Bf4!? Bd3 13 d6! exd6 14 Na4!. The counterattack against the bishop on d3 allows White to make favourable exchanges.

12 d6! exd6 13 Bxb7 Rb8 14 Bf3

Black didn't blunder his b7 pawn. This is the main line of the variation and most theoretical works state that Black has sufficient compensation for the pawn. I am a little sceptical of this assessment (even though I made it myself once), mainly because Black has nothing concrete for the pawn. The white position is awkward and difficult to handle, but I can't help feeling that a sequence of good moves may just leave Black a pawn down for nothing.

See Game 53 for an example of White successfully unravelling.

Theoretical?

It's not overly theoretical. You should be all right if you just remember to develop the pieces towards d5 and to be on the lookout for a good moment to play d5-d6 if you are playing White.

Statistics

White has scored 57% from nearly 2000 games where Black has played 5...g6. If we take the position after 10 Nge2 in the main line then the white score is around 58%.

Game 52

□ Timofeev ■ Yevseev

Kazan 2001

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 g6 6 cxd5 (Diagram 14)

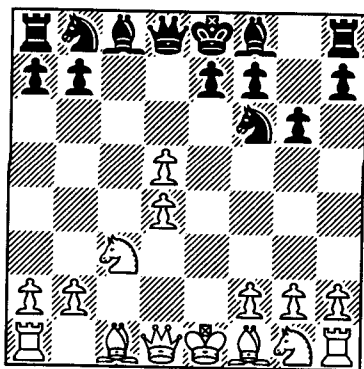


Diagram 14

White tries a different approach

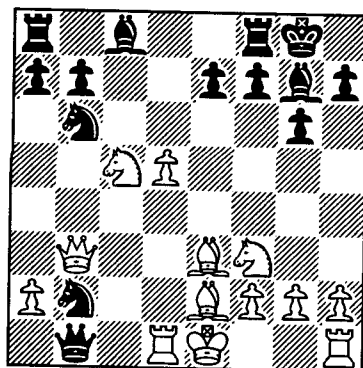


Diagram 15

White forces a draw

6...Nxd5

If Black just plays 6...Bg7 then White has some serious alternatives to 7 Qb3 (transposing to the main line). For example, 7 Bb5+ Bd7 8 Bc4!, when the bishop is misplaced on d7, while 7...Nbd7 is well met by 8 d6! exd6 9 Qe2+ Qe7 10 Bf4 Qxe2+ 11 Bxe2! Ke7 12 Bf3 with advantage to White.

7 Qb3 Nb6

On 7...Nxc3 White can throw in 8 Bc4! in order to force the weakening 8...e6 (8...Ne4? 9 Bxf7+ Kd7 10 Qe6+ wins) before playing 9 bxc3.

8 d5

White seizes space in the centre but in view of the assessment of this line the alternative 8 Bb5+ Bd7 9 Nf3 deserves serious consideration.

8...Bg7 9 Be3 0-0 10 Rd1 Na6 11 Be2

White can also play 11 Bxa6 to double Black's pawns but after 11...bxa6 12 Nge2 a5 Black will obtain active play on the queenside.

11...Qd6!

Preparing ...Nc5. Black must do something active before White can consolidate his strategical advantage.

12 Nf3 Nc5 13 Qb5

13 Qa3 is also met by 13...Nca4 while after 13 Qb4?? Black would be unlikely to resist 13...Nd3+.

13...Nca4! 14 Ne4

Black's point was that 14 Nxa4 is met by 14...Bd7, regaining the piece with a comfortable game.

14...Qd7 15 Qb3

White has to give up the b-pawn as something like 15 b3 Qxb5 16 Bxb5 Bf5! is quite awkward for him.

15...Nxb2 16 Nc5 Qf5! 17 Rd2

White must stay defending the d-pawn

17...Qb1+ 18 Rd1! (Diagram 15)

White takes advantage of the pin to force a repetition that neither side can profitably avoid.

18...Qf5 19 Rd2 Qb1+ ½-½

Game 53

□ A.Kovacevic ■ Kostic

Novi Sad 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 c4 Nf6 5 Nc3 g6 6 Qb3 Bg7 7 cxd5 0-0 8 Be2 Nbd7 9 Bf3 Nb6 10 Nge2 Bf5 11 0-0 Bd3 12 d6 exd6 13 Bxb7 Rb8 14 Bf3 (Diagram 16)

All this was discussed in the theoretical section where I expressed my scepticism about Black's position. Well, I like his position but not the fact that he is a pawn down.

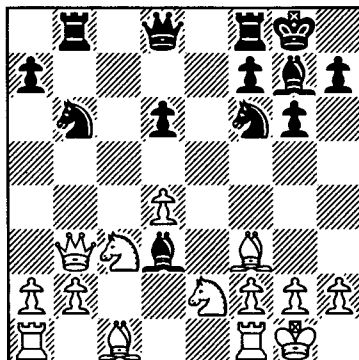


Diagram 16

Does Black have enough compensation?

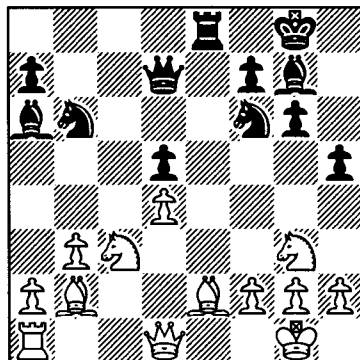


Diagram 17

White offers a trade

14...Re8 15 Qd1

The queen was uncomfortable sharing an open file with a black rook.

15...Ba6 16 Re1 Qd7 17 b3

White's last two moves are the start of the unravelling process and they diminish the pressure Black had on the b- and e-files.

17...Rbc8 18 Bb2 d5 19 Ng3

White will be looking to exchange as many pieces as possible.

19...h5 20 Rxe8+ Rxe8 21 Be2! (Diagram 17) 17...Bxe2 22 Ngxe2 Nc8 23 Qd3 Nd6 24 Rd1 Nf5 25 Ng3 Nd6 26 Nf1 Nf5 27 Ne2 h4 28 Rd2 Re4 29 Rc2 Qe8 30 f3! Re7 31 Ba3 Re6 32 Nf4 Re1 33 Re2 Rxe2 34 Nxe2

White's careful play is paying dividends. One can no longer really talk of compensation for the pawn, just a position that is difficult for White to win.

34...Nh7 35 Kf2 Ng5 36 Ne3 Nxe3 37 Qxe3 Ne6 38 Qc3 Qb8 39 Kg1 Qe8 40 Kf2 Qb8 41 g3 Bf6 42 Bc1 Kg7 43 Be3 hxg3+ 44 hxg3 Qh8 45 Kg2 and White eventually converted his plus on move 88.

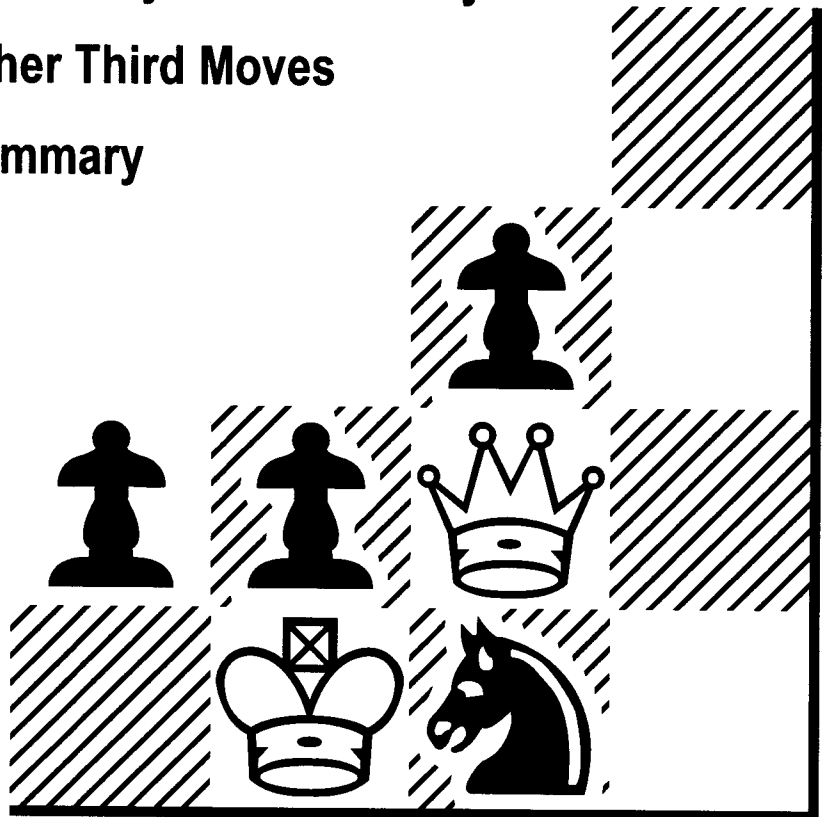
Summary

- 1) To my eye, the main lines of the IQP positions that arise after 5...e6 look quite uncomfortable for Black. However, it is often a matter of taste which side one prefers in such positions.
- 2) The lines with 5...g6 are not totally reliable as a well-timed d5-d6 can give White a positional advantage.
- 3) 5...Nc6 looks like the best chance of obtaining an equal game. Black should quite easily be able to hold the ending that arises in the main line assuming he has done a bit of homework on it.

Chapter Nine

The Fantasy Variation: 3 f3

- ▨ Introduction
- ▨ Black Exchanges in the Centre: 3...dxe4
- ▨ Black Plays in French Style: 3...e6
- ▨ Other Third Moves
- ▨ Summary



Introduction

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 (Diagram 1)

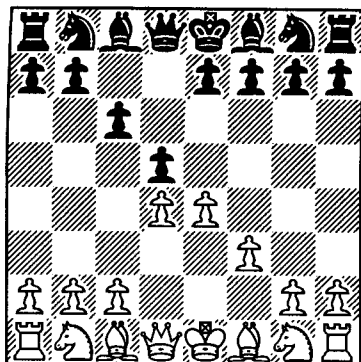


Diagram 1
The Fantasy Variation

Who Plays it?

In my early days as a chess player I was only interested in one aspect of chess – tactics and combinations. A nicely played endgame or a deep positional subtlety would either leave me completely cold or just pass right over my head. When one day I heard there was a line in the Caro-Kann called the Fantasy Variation I knew at once that this was the variation for me. By the time I had checked out what little theory there was available I was completely hooked. The verdict then was about the same as it is today: a positionally suspect line but one full of dangerous traps for Black to avoid.

The ‘positionally suspect’ bit only began to bother me later as my chess style became more rounded. However, I also realised that it was not as positionally suspect as it was made out to be. After all, how positionally suspect can a variation be when a former World Champion Vassily Smyslov, renowned for his classical style of play, and the current World Number 4 Michael Adams, not exactly noted for burning his boats, are willing to play it? True, a well prepared black player should have little trouble getting to a roughly level middlegame position, but that is the case in many mainstream lines. And these level positions that one obtains from the Fantasy Variation have the advantage of been relatively unexplored and offer plenty of scope for original play. What I like most about the Fantasy Variation, though, is what happens to the unprepared player – they are simply torn to shreds. Black suffers more quick defeats in the Fantasy variation than in all the other lines put together (well, maybe).

The Fantasy Variation, therefore, is a perfect opening to play at club level, where many black players simply have no idea what to do against it. At international level it is still playable, but as I have found out in this database age, more effective as a surprise weapon to be wheeled out from time to time.

The Pros and Cons of 3 f3

If White wishes to maintain the perfect pawn centre (pawns on e4 and d4) against the Caro-Kann, then the only way to do so is to play 3 f3. Maintaining this centre comes at a price as the move f2-f3 has a couple of serious defects. Firstly, by depriving the king's knight of its natural home, it turns White's kingside development into a rather laborious affair. The second drawback is the weakening of the sensitive g1-a7 diagonal – sensitive because of its proximity to the white king.

Black's Strategies

Black has a number of distinct ways to combat the Fantasy Variation. The first is to exchange in the centre and counter at once with ...e7-e5. This is examined in the first sub-section. In the second section Black plays the rock solid 3...e6, giving the game a French Defence character. In the third section we look at a couple of lesser-played, but still important alternatives: the attempt at outright refutation, 3...e5 and the relatively solid 3...g6.

It's difficult to say which of these lines is best. However, as a word of warning to Black, I suspect that most practitioners of the Fantasy Variation are hoping for the lines where Black opens the position (3...dxe4 and 3...e5), and are not so keen on the lines where the position stays closed. When playing White I have certainly had most trouble against 3...e6.

Black Exchanges in the Centre: 3...dxe4

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 dxe4 4 fxe4 e5

Black would never have exchanged in the centre if it weren't for this follow-up. According to many theoretical sources this is the simplest path to equality. I, myself, am a little sceptical of this line of play. All the defects of playing f2-f3 have suddenly disappeared. White will now have free and easy development and an open f-file to satisfy his attacking instincts. This is not a bad line for Black, just one where he is playing on his opponent's territory.

5 Nf3

Of course White doesn't take on e5, allowing an exchange of queens for an absolutely useless extra pawn.

5...Be6!

In my experience about half the people who play the Caro-Kann are

already out of their theoretical knowledge by this stage. That explains why so many play the almost suicidal 5...exd4?. After 6 Bc4! White has excellent attacking prospects. See Games 54 and 55 for the details.

There is one other move that deserves a mention and that is 5...Bg4. White usually plays 6 Bc4 but in certain variations he can regret that his e-pawn is not more solidly defended. That is why I suggest the more modest 6 c3 Nd7 7 Bd3. After 6 c3, both 6...exd4 7 Bc4 and 6...Bxf3 7 Qxf3 exd4 7 Bc4 are rather risky for Black.

6 c3

White supports his centre. The tactical justification behind Black's last move was that 6 Nxe5? is met by 6...Qh4+.

6...Nd7

Sometimes Black plays 6...Nf6. This may just transpose if White plays 7 Bd3 but this move order gives White the option of taking on e5. After 7 Nxe5 Nxe4 Michael Adams played 8 Nf3 in a game against the former American Champion Yasser Seirawan. This solid move prevents Qh4+ and promises White a small advantage. It was, though, also possible to play 8 Bd3 as after 8...Qh4+?! 9 g3 Nxe4 10 Nf3! Qh3 11 Rg1 Black is in serious trouble.

7 Bd3 Bd6 (Diagram 2)

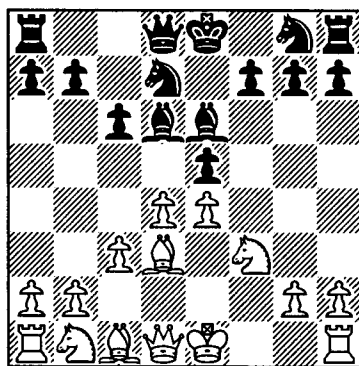


Diagram 2
Black protects e5

Adding protection to the crucial e5-square.



NOTE: The golden rule for Black in this variation is to hold the e5-square at all costs. In fact, he should have an extremely compelling reason to even contemplate exchanging on d4.

8 0-0 Ngf6

With the above note in mind, certain players prefer to play 8...f6 followed by ...Ne7 and ...0-0. Whilst this certainly reinforces the e5-

square, the downside is that Black's pieces are quite passively placed and once he has completed his development it won't be easy to find anything constructive to do.

9 Kh1

The idea is to play Be3 and, in the event of been attacked by ...Ng4, the bishop can drop back to g1.



NOTE: Long range pieces like bishops are quite happy on the back ranks. The main reason they need to be developed in the first place is to let the rooks into the game.

An alternative strategy for White is to go after the bishop pair with 9 Ng5!?

9...Qc7 10 Be3 c5!

This move gives Black the best chance of equalising. After, for example, 10...0-0 11 Nbd2 followed by Qc2 and Rae1, White's extra space gives him some advantage. After 10...c5 White would like to play 11 d5 but then 11...Bxd5! 12 exd5 e4 gives Black an equal game. Therefore, in Movsesian-Stohl, Austria 2001, White tried 11 Nbd2 and after 11...cxd4 12 cxd4 exd4 13 Rc1 Qb8 14 Nxd4 Bg4 15 Be2 Bxe2 16 Qxe2 0-0 the chances were about level. Black's control of the e5-square is of paramount importance.

Theoretical?

The line is full of tricks and traps. Most black players know little about it and pay the inevitable price (see below).

Statistics

White scores an amazing 67% from the position after 4...e5. This confirms the opinion that even if this line is theoretically all right for Black he is playing on White's territory.

Game 54

□ Gallagher ■ E.Lee

Chelmsford 1984

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 dxe4 4 fxe4 e5 5 Nf3 exd4?

What could be more natural than this exchange in the centre. The only problem is that after this move Black is already in deep trouble. What is even more amazing is that in practice the text occurs as often as the correct 5...Be6 (see above). Do Black players really think that White is going to play 6 Nxd4, allowing 6...Qh4+, or 6 Qxd4, meekly exchanging queens. Do they have no sense of danger?

6 Bc4! (Diagram 3)

Of course. White develops in the most aggressive manner, taking aim at the f7-square, which is even more vulnerable than usual because of the open f-file.

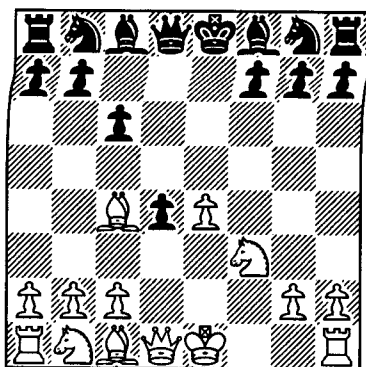


Diagram 3

White is already doing well

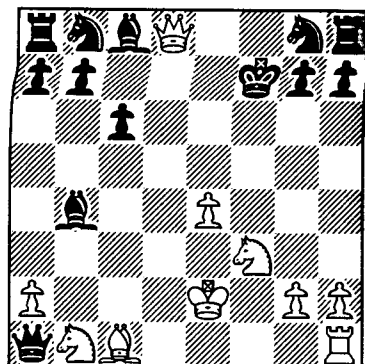


Diagram 4

White can force mate



NOTE: the f7-square (or f2 for White) is the Achilles' Heel of the black position because it is only defended by the king. Many of the most aggressive opening variations, such as the King's Gambit, are based on a quick attack against this square.

6...Bb4+?!

Black is most obliging and heads for glorious defeat. The other defensive tries are seen in the next game.

7 c3! dxc3

I suppose any bishop move is stronger but it's too late to criticise Black's move. He has already crossed over the precipice.

8 Bxf7+! Kxf7

After 8...Ke7 9 Qb3! cxb2+ (other moves are no better) 10 Qxb4+ Kxf7 11 Bxb2 the black king is too exposed to harbour any real hopes of survival.

9 Qxd8

The Bxf7+ trick in order to deflect the black king from the defence of the queen is one of the best known traps in chess and appears in many guises. But hasn't White overlooked something here? Hasn't Black got a little counterattack of his own?

9...cxb2+ 10 Ke2 bxa1Q (Diagram 4)

I have always been impressed by the power of the move 'pawn takes rook = queen'. That is one hell of a material gain. But no, White hadn't overlooked it. Now it's his turn.

11 Ng5+! Kg6 12 Qe8+ Kh6

Or 12...Kf6 13 Rf1+ Bf5 14 Rxf5 mate.

13 Ne6+! g5 14 Bxg5 mate

I have given this game as Gallagher-Lee, Chelmsford 1984. That was a little presumptuous of me as this game has occurred on numerous occasions. I, myself, have won it three times.

Game 55

□ Teichmann ■ Mises

Berlin 1910

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 dxe4 4 fxe4 e5 5 Nf3 exd4 6 Bc4 Nf6

We have just seen the catastrophic consequences of 6...Bb4+. In this game we look at a couple of other tries for Black. As well as the text he can play:

- a) 6...Be7, although this usually just transposes to the game after 7 0-0 0 Nf6.
- b) 6...Bc5, when White should play 7 0-0, not fearing 7...d3+ which will only open more lines for White.
- c) 6...Be6 is played quite often but after 7 Bxe6 fxe6 8 0-0 White is well on top. A typical continuation has been 8...Be7 9 Nxd4 Bf6 10 e5! Be7 (10...Bxe5 11 Qh5+ and 12 Qxe5) 11 Nxe6 Qxd1 12 Nxg7+ Kd8 13 Rxd1+ with two extras pawns and an ongoing attack.

7 0-0

Note that here and in all the lines above White wisely castles before starting his attack.

7...Be7

White now wins material by force but I doubt there is a better move for Black.

8 Ng5 0-0 9 Nxf7! Rxf7 10 Bxf7+ Kxf7 11 e5 (Diagram 5)

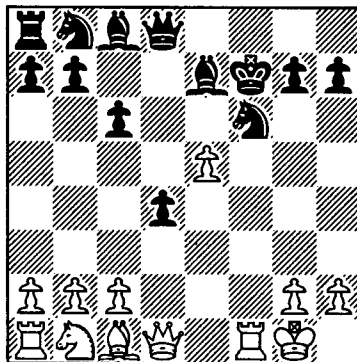


Diagram 5
White wins material

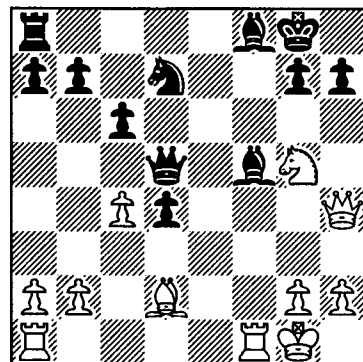


Diagram 6
20 c4 – a clever move

The knight on f6 is pinned and Black will be left with just a pawn for the exchange. From a theoretical point of view the game is over, although in practice White must still take care (I am afraid I once drew

this position). This trap is still occurring periodically in tournaments today. The lessons of a century ago have, evidently, not been assimilated by everyone.

11...Kg8 12 exf6 Bxf6 13 Nd2 Be6 14 Ne4 Be7 15 Qh5 Nd7 16 Bg5 Qa5 17 Qh4 Bf8 18 Bd2 Qd5 19 Ng5 Bf5 20 c4! (Diagram 6)

The last thing Black wants to do now is to take en passant – this opens the position for the white rooks – but he has no choice as the queen must stay defending the bishop and after 20...Qc5 21 b4! this is no longer possible.

20...dxc3 21 Bxc3 Bg6 22 Rad1 Qc5+ 23 Kh1 Nb6 24 Ne6 Qh5 25 Rd8! 1-0

Black Plays in French Style: 3...e6

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 e6 (Diagram 7)

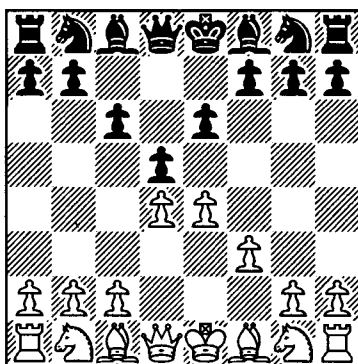


Diagram 7
Black remains solid

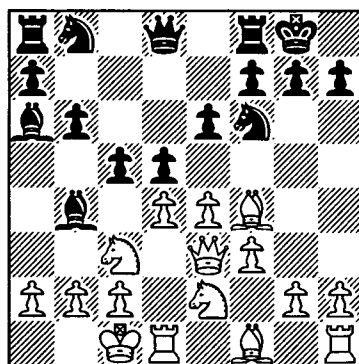


Diagram 8
Black strikes in the centre

This is the most reliable and solid move at Black's disposal. We now have a French Defence with the moves f2-f3 and ...c7-c6 included. This should be slightly in Black's favour as the pawn on f3 impedes the development of the white kingside while the move ...c7-c6 opens a path to the queenside for the black queen. Both sides will feel the urge to push these pawns again, and when this happens there is a good chance of transposing directly into the French Defence.

4 Nc3

The move 3...e6 actually created a threat: 4...dxe4 winning a pawn because 5 fxe4 is met by ...Qh4+. The text defends the pawn on e4 but it was also possible to gambit it with 4 Be3. This idea can be examined in Game 56.

4...Bb4

By pinning the knight on c3 Black reintroduces his threat to the e-

pawn. Another common continuation has been 4...Nf6 5 e5 c5 6 f4 c5 with a direct transposition into the popular Steinitz variation of the French Defence.

5 Bf4

This has become 'the main line' but the feeling remains that f4 is a slightly awkward square for the bishop. It does, however, at least have the advantage of not losing a pawn like the two other bishop moves that are examined in Game 57.

5...Nf6

5...Ne7 is an interesting alternative. See Game 58.

6 Qd3

Black was trying to tempt White into playing e4-e5, but this advance doesn't fit with the moves f2-f3 and Bf4. It makes more sense to cover e4 and castle queenside.

6...b6

Preparing Ba6. One can't argue with the logic of this move.

7 Nge2 Ba6 8 Qe3 0-0

Normally the side with less space (i.e. Black) should strive to exchange pieces but this position is an exception. After 8...Bxc3+ 9 Nxc3 Bxf1 10 Rxf1 Black has only managed to swap off the white kingside pieces that were stepping on each other's toes.

9 0-0-0 c5!? (Diagram 8)

9...Be7 and 9...Nbd7 have been played more often, but if we are to believe the Indian master Ravi, this central strike gives Black a fully equal game.

10 a3

The other key variation is 10 dxc5 Bxc5 11 Qd2 Nc6 12 exd5 Nxd5 13 Nxd5 exd5 14 Qxd5 Qxd5 15 Rxd5 Nb4 and Black regains the pawn with a level game.

10...cxd4 11 Nxd4 Bxc3 12 Qxc3 Bxf1 13 Rhxf1 Qc8

We are following the game Conquest-Ravi, Madras, 1994. The position is level according to Ravi. I suspect White still has some initiative after 14 Qe3.

Theoretical?

Theory is slightly less important after 3...e6 than in the previous section but it always helps to know what one is doing.

Statistics

Even against 3...e6 White has scored a perfectly respectable 55%. And when you take into account that Black has averaged 20 rating points more this figure becomes quite impressive.

Game 56

□ Mitkov ■ Dreev

European Club Cup, Neum 2000

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 e6 4 Be3

When I first started playing the Fantasy variation I played like this but over the years I grew to distrust it.

4...Qb6

This is the most obvious way to exploit the 'premature' development of the queen's bishop. Black has another way to win a pawn as after 4...dxe4 White cannot recapture because of Qh4+. However, by playing 5 Nd2 exf3 6 Ngxf3 Nf6 7 Nc4 he obtains good compensation. He is ahead in development and there are open lines on the kingside that will guarantee attacking chances.

5 Nd2

White could protect the pawn with the passive 5 Qc1 but this is not in the spirit of the variation. Anyway, 5...c5 would give Black good play.

5...Qxb2 (Diagram 9)

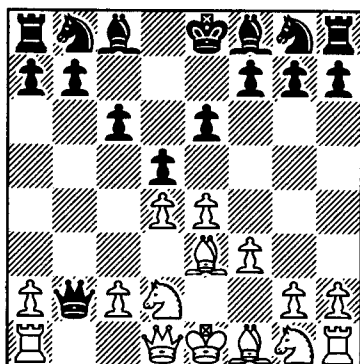


Diagram 9
Black grabs a pawn

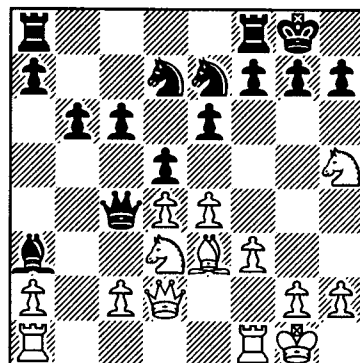


Diagram 10
Black plays a novelty

6 Bd3 Qa3

Black can only get away with grabbing such a pawn because of the blocked nature of the position. If the centre were open such play would be suicidal but with it firmly closed it is quite difficult for White to capitalise on his lead in development. The quality of the pawn grabbed is quite important as well. The b-pawn is the most important of the flank pawns because without it White's whole queenside becomes positionally weak on the dark squares. If it were an a-pawn Black were taking it probably wouldn't have been worth the trouble.

7 Ne2 b6!

The idea is to exchange off the passive bishop on c8.

8 0-0 Ba6 9 Nb3 Bxd3 10 Qxd3 Qa6 11 Qd2 Ba3 12 Ng3 Nd7 13 Nc1

Mitkov comes up with the painfully slow plan of transferring the passive knight on b3 to the kingside. This gives Black time to organise his defensive set-up. Why not just push the f-pawn? 13 f4, followed by 14 f5, must be the critical test of Black's set-up.

13...Ne7 14 Nd3 0-0 15 Nh5 Qc4! (Diagram 10)

The tentacles of modern day opening preparation even stretch into the Fantasy Variation! In Mitkov-Khenkin, Bolzano 1999, Black played 15...g6. Dreev obviously decided that it was not necessary to weaken his kingside in this fashion. He prefers a different defensive set-up based on playing ...f7-f6. From here on in the game gradually slips away from White.

16 c3 f6 17 Rab1 Ng6 18 Ng3 Rad8 19 Rfd1 Rfe8 20 Bf2 e5 21 exd5 Qxd5 22 Nb4 Bxb4 23 Rxb4 Ndf8 24 Qc2 Ne6 25 c4 Qd7 26 d5 Nef4 27 d6 c5 28 Rb3 Nh4 29 Ne4 Nf5 30 a4 Qxa4 31 Qb1 Ne2+ 0-1

Game 57

□ Gallagher ■ Timmer

Biel 1987

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 e6 4 Nc3 Bb4 5 Be3?!'

If White wants to avoid 5 Bf4 then 5 Bd2 is probably the most interesting alternative. If Black decides to go after the pawn with 5...Bxc3 6 Bxc3 dxe4, then White should probably play 7 Qe2 (7 fxe4 Qh4+) in order to force clarification in the centre. The position after 7...exf3 8 Nxf3 looks full of danger for Black. The solid 5...Ne7 may well represent the best choice.

5...dxe4 6 a3 Bxc3+ 7 bxc3 (Diagram 11)

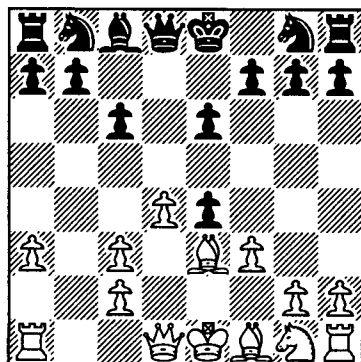


Diagram 11
An important moment

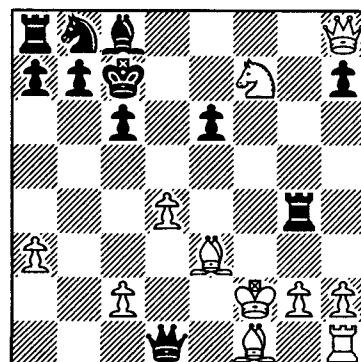


Diagram 12
White threatens mate

7...Nf6?

At the time of this game theoretical sources tended to quote the ancient game *Tartakower-Flohr*, Kemer 1937 as the main line. That game went 7...Qa5 8 Bd2 Nf6 9 c4 Qc7 10 fxe4 Nxe4 11 Bd3 Nxd2 12 Qxd2 0-0 13 Nf3 with compensation for the sacrificed pawn. However, I knew that instead of 8...Nf6 Black should play 8...e3! 9 Bxe3 Qxc3+ with a good game. What was I doing still playing this line then? Well, in those days I was a bit of a gambler and I enjoyed the other variations so much that I thought it was worth running the risk. Unfortunately, retribution was pretty swift. A couple of weeks after this Timmer game I played White against Conquest in the last round of the British Championship. It was a big game which I had to win to secure a GM norm and 2nd place in the championship. When Conquest played 7...Qa5 my spirits sank and, after a long think, I decided not to find out if he knew what I knew. Instead I opted for a double pawn sacrifice with 8 fxe4!? Qxc3+ 9 Bd2 Qxd4 10 Bd3 and eventually lost an exciting game.

8 fxe4 Nxe4 9 Qg4 Nf6 10 Qxg7 Rg8 11 Qh6 Rg6 12 Qh4 Rg4 13 Qf2 Qa5?!

I doubt that Black was motivated by greed. Probably he felt that his position was so awful that he should do anything to change the course of the game.

14 Qxf6! Qxc3+ 15 Kf2 Qxa1 16 Qh8+ Kd7 17 Nf3 Qd1 18 Ne5+ Kc7 19 Nxf7! (Diagram 12)

Even stronger than 19 Nxe4. White now threatens Qd8 mate.

19...Qxc2+ 20 Kg1 Rxe2+

Black relies on a last trick as other moves would have lost quickly as well.

21 Bxe2 Qb1+ 22 Bf1

And not 22 Kf2? Qf5+, followed by ...Qxf7.

22...Qg6+ 23 Bg5! 1-0

A nice final touch. 23...Qxf7 no longer prevents 24 Qd8 mate.

Game 58

□ Gallagher ■ Khenkin

Geneva 1995

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 e6 4 Nc3 Bb4 5 Bf4 Ne7!?

The more common 5...Nf6 was dealt with in the theoretical section. It's difficult to say which knight move is better. On f6 the knight pressurises the white centre but on e7 it presents White with less of a target.

6 Qd2 0-0 7 Nge2 Nd7 8 a3 Ba5 9 e5

The last few moves did not come easily. I was worried about Black breaking open the centre with ...c6-c5 and had the feeling that my

bishop on f4 was misplaced. Not only does the possibility of ...Ng6 have to be taken into account, but in some lines it can also get hit by ...e6-e5. For example, 9 Ng3 c5 10 dxc5 e5 is good for Black. Playing b2-b4 didn't appeal to me because Black can counterattack with ...a7-a5 and, after rejecting 9 Bd6, I decided to block the centre with e4-e5 in order to reduce the impact of the ...c5 break.

9...c5 10 dxc5 Bc7 (Diagram 13)

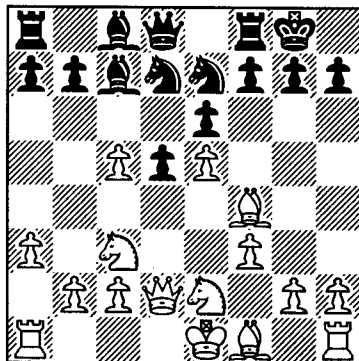


Diagram 13
Black targets the e5-pawn

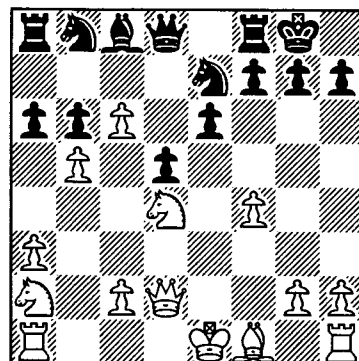


Diagram 14
17 Na2 – a saving resource

Of course not 10...Nxc5 11 b4, but 10...Ng6 was an interesting alternative.

11 Nd4 Bxe5 12 Bxe5 Nxe5 13 f4 Nd7!?

13...N7c6, with a roughly level game, was more solid. The text is the start of a provocative plan. The idea is to lure white's queenside pawns forward and then destroy them.

14 b4 b6 15 c6 Nb8 16 b5 a6!

The whole point of Black's play is that White can't support his pawn chain with 17 a4 because of the pin on the a-file after 17...axb5.

17 Na2! (Diagram 14)

If it weren't for this move White would be in trouble. The knight is heading for the outpost on b4 where it can offer protection to the c6 pawn.

17...axb5 18 Nb4 f6!

Black must react in the centre before White consolidates.

19 Bxb5 e5 20 Nb3! Qd6 21 0-0

Note that if the white knight hadn't gone back to b3, then White wouldn't have been able to castle here because of ...Qc5+. Now, after all the excitement, there comes a series of exchanges and the game peters out into a drawn ending.

21...Nbxc6 22 Bxc6 Nxc6 23 fxe5

The immediate 23 Qxd5+ would have been simpler.

23...Nxe5 24 Qxd5+ Qxd5 25 Nxd5 Bb7! 26 Rfd1 Nc4 27 Ne7+!
Kh8 28 Rd7 Be4 29 Rd4 Bxc2 ½-½

In view of the variation 30 Rxc4 Bxb3 31 Rb4 with equality.

Other Third Moves

A) 1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 e5!? (Diagram 15)

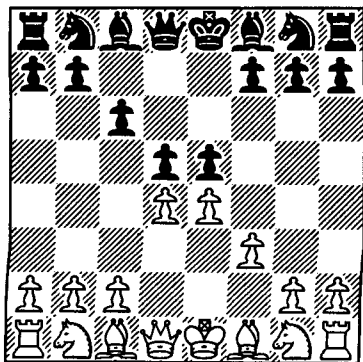


Diagram 15

Very sharp!

A move with violence in its heart. The idea is to gain control of the sensitive g1-a7 diagonal. It was rarely seen until the Dutch publication *New in Chess* suggested it as a possible refutation of the Fantasy Variation. It then became quite popular until it was clear that *New in Chess* had failed to take into account White's strongest line.

4 dxe5 Bc5 5 Nc3!

This is the move that had escaped *New in Chess*. They only considered inferior continuations such as 5 Ne2 and 5 cxd5. These moves do nothing to counter Black's intended Qb6. For example, after 5 cxd5 Qb6 6 Nh3 (forced) 6...Bxh3 7 gxh3 cxd5 8 Qxd5 Ne7 Black has a big lead in development and attacking chances in return for his pawns.

5...Qb6

It is not too late for Black to change plan. 5...Ne7! is examined in Game 60.

6 Na4!

This was the point of 7 Nc3. Black's control of the g1-a7 diagonal is immediately challenged.

6...Qa5+

The other possibility is 6...Bf2+ but after 7 Ke2 the only queen move

that doesn't lose the bishop is 7...Qd4, when White can just exchange queens and remain a pawn to the good. For example, 8 Qxd4 Bxd4 9 exd5 cxd5 10 f4 Bg4+ 11 Nf3 Nc6 12 c3.

7 c3

Now the knight on a4 is defended and White threatens to win a piece with b2-b4.

7...Bxg1

Black can also retreat the bishop but this loses some momentum. Gallagher-Tukmakov, Geneva 1994 continued 7...Bf8 8 b4 Qc7 9 exd5 Qxe5+ 10 Qe2 Qxe2+ 11 Nxe2. Now, rather than defending the miserable 11...cxd5 12 Nd4, Tukmakov preferred 11...Nf6 but after 12 dxc6 Nxc6 13 b5 Na5 14 Nd4 he didn't have any real compensation for the pawn.

8 Rxxg1 dxe4 9 Bf4!

This is much stronger than the move 9 f4 which blocks in the white pieces. I believe that White has an edge in this most complex position. See Game 59 for the details.

B) 1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 g6

This line should appeal to those players who want a reasonably solid position but do not feel particularly comfortable in the French-type positions that arise after 3...e6.

4 Nc3

With this move White decides to try and hold his central position. A case can also be made for blocking it at once with 4 e5. Hodgson-Adianto, Biel 1995 continued 4...Bg7 5 f4 Nh6 6 Nf3 0-0 7 c3 Qb6 8 h3 f6 9 g4 fxe5 10 dxe5 Na6 11 Qe2 Nc7 12 Be3 with a promising game for White.

4...Bg7 5 Be3 Qb6! (Diagram 16)

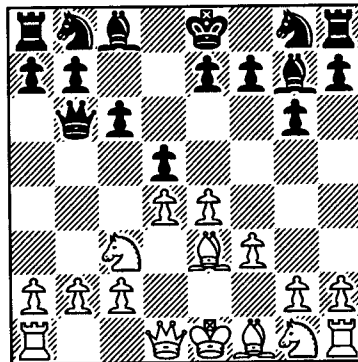


Diagram 16

Once again Black targets b2

Ideally Black would prefer to just continue developing his pieces but there is no obvious way to do so. The move 5...Nf6, for example, just allows e4-e5 with gain of tempo. There is nowhere sensible to put the light-squared bishop and ...Nd7 just loses the d-pawn. A large number of players have decided there is nothing better than the anti-positional exchange on e4. That is covered in Game 61. The text is, in fact, the best move. Black counterattacks against b2 and he is willing to part with a central pawn

6 Qd2

Not a real sacrifice as Black can only win a pawn if he exchanges on e4 before capturing on b2. This, though, is hardly worth even thinking about as it brings all the white pieces to life. 6 Rb1 is well met by 6...e5, but 6 Na4 Qa5+ 7 c3, followed by b2-b4, could be worth trying.

6...Qxb2 7 Rb1 Qa3 8 exd5 Nf6!

Black's chances are no worse in this complex position. For example, the high-class encounter Adams-Leko, Tilburg 1996 continued 9 dxc6 bxc6! 10 Bd3 Nbd7 11 Nge2 0-0 12 0-0 Ba6! with equal chances.

Theoretical?

The play after 3...e5 can be very sharp so it will certainly help to have studied and memorised a few lines. After 3...g6 one can just play chess as long as you know about 5...Qb6.

Statistics

White has only scored 52% against 3...e5 but there have only been 50 games so I wouldn't read too much into that. Against 3...g6 White has scored 58% from 240 games.

Game 59

□ Gallagher ■ Anic

Lyon 1993

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 e5 4 dxe5 Bc5 5 Nc3 6 Na4 Qa5+ 7 c3 Bxg1 8 Rxb1 dxe4 9 Bf4 Ne7

Refusing to make the rook on g1's day by playing 9...exf3.

10 fxe4

10 b4 is another possibility but during the game I was fascinated by the idea of 10 Qd6!?, letting the knight on a4 go in order to keep Black's king in the centre. In the end I couldn't reach any definite conclusion and decided to play safe (later analysis confirmed that 10 Qd6!? is indeed playable although not devastating for Black).

10...0-0 11 b4 Qd8 (Diagram 17) 12 Qxd8 Rxd8

White is happy to exchange queens as he has no safe place to park his king. White is relying more on his bishop pair than on the extra doubled and isolated e-pawn to make something of the position.

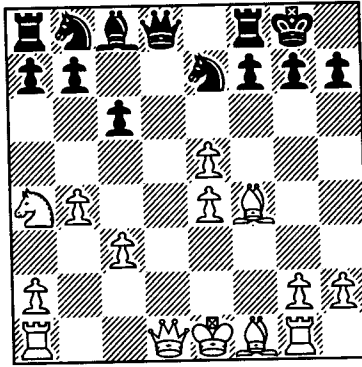


Diagram 17

White will exchange queens

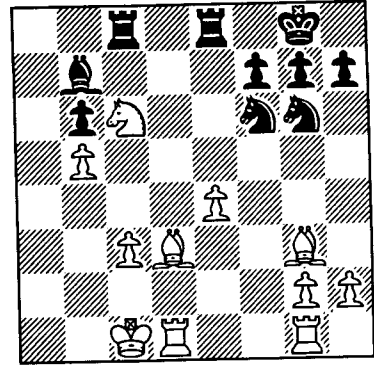


Diagram 18

23...Rac8 – not the best move

13 Nc5 Ng6 14 Bg3 b6 15 Nb3 Nd7 16 0-0-0 Re8 17 e6!?

There was an argument for playing this on the last move when Black would have to recapture with the pawn. Now Black can play more actively.

17...Rxe6 18 Nd4 Re8 19 Nxc6 Nf6!

This is why Black didn't capture on e4 with the rook – he wants to take with the knight.

20 Bd3 Bb7 21 b5 a6 22 a4 axb5 23 axb5 Rac8?! (Diagram 18)

Black overlooks the coming sequence. He should have played 23...Nxe4 with just a small plus for White after 24 Bxe4.

24 e5 Nh5 25 Bf5! Nxc3

25...Rc7 26 Rd7! is promising for White.

26 Bxc8! Ne2+ 27 Kd2 Bxc6

27...Bxc8 28 Kxe2 Bg4+ 29 Kf2 Bxd1 30 Rxd1 Kf8 31 Rd5! and White remains a pawn to the good.

28 bxc6 Rxc8

28...Nxc3 29 Bd7 is totally hopeless. Now White emerges a clear exchange ahead. The remaining moves were:

29 Kxe2 h6 30 e6 Nf4+ 31 Ke3 Nxe6 32 Rd6 Nd8 33 c7 Ne6 34 Rc6 Kf8 35 Rb1 Nxc7 36 Kf3 Ke7 37 Rbxb6 Kd7 38 Rd6+ Ke7 39 Rdc6 Kd7 40 Rc4 Ke7 41 Rbc6 Kd7 42 Kg4 Kd8 43 h4 Kd7 44 h5 Kd8 45 Rd4+ Ke7 46 Kf3 Ke8 47 Rcc4 Ke7 48 Rg4 1-0

Game 60

□ Mitkov ■ Kallai

French League 1994

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 e5 4 dxe5 Bc5 5 Nc3 Ne7!?

This time Black just concentrates on his development, relying on the

fact that white's king will be stuck in the centre for some time to provide his compensation.

6 Bd3 0-0 7 f4 Na6 8 Qf3 Qb6 9 Nge2 Nb4 10 g4!? (Diagram 19)

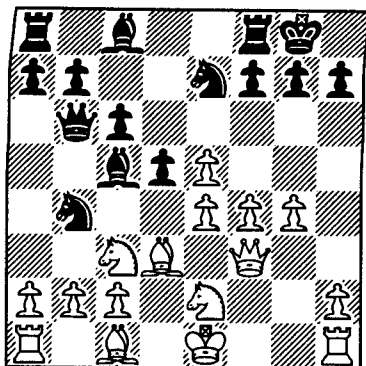


Diagram 19

No safety first play by White

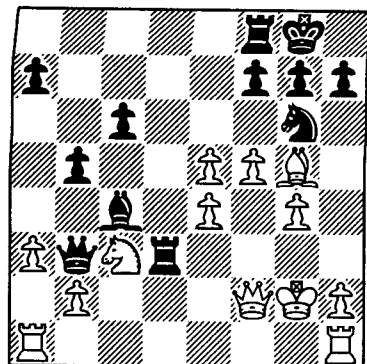


Diagram 20

21...Ng6 – an easy move to miss

A wild-looking move but White just wants to walk his king to the relative safety of g2.

10...Be6 11 Kf1 Nxd3 12 cxd3 Rad8

I think White should have exchanged on d5 earlier. Now it is too late as Black can recapture with pieces. Meanwhile, the threat of ...dxe4 and an invasion on the d-file hangs over White.

13 Na4 Qa5 14 Nxc5 Qxc5 15 Nc3 b5 16 Qf2 Qb4 17 f5 dxe4! 18 a3 Qb3 19 dxe4

After 19 fxe6 fxe6 20 Bf4 Ng6 Black has a winning attack. We shall see a similar idea in the game soon.

19...Rd3 20 Bg5 Bc4 21 Kg2 Ng6! (Diagram 20)

A wonderful way to bring the knight into the attack. After 22 fxg6 fxg6 White is lost, e.g. 23 Bf4 Rxf4 24 Qxf4 Qxb2+.

22 Ne2 Qxb2 23 Nc1 Nh4+! 0-1

An impressive game but White's play between moves 7 and 10 didn't inspire. Something like 8 exd5 cxd5 9 a3, which both clarifies the position in the centre and makes it harder for the knight on a6 to get into the game, suggests itself.

Game 61

□ Gallagher ■ J.Bellin

London 1984

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 f3 g6 4 Nc3 Bg7 5 Be3 dxe4?! 6 fxe4 Nf6 7 Nf3 Ng4

I don't think this is a particularly good manoeuvre from Black but it

is at least consistent with exchanging on e4.

7...Qb6 is the other try. White can either sacrifice his b-pawn with 8 Qd2, or poison it with 8 a3. Now if Black captures then White plays 9 Na4 trapping the queen. The reason 8 a3 is preferable to 8 Rb1 is that White keeps the option of castling queenside.

8 Bg5 h6 9 Bh4 Ne3 10 Qd2 Nxf1 11 Rxf1 (Diagram 21)

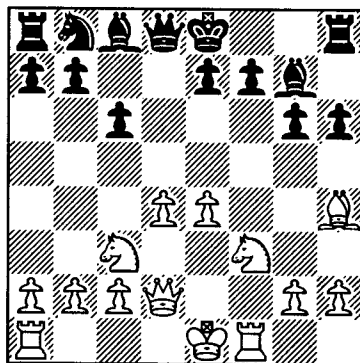


Diagram 21

White has a big development lead

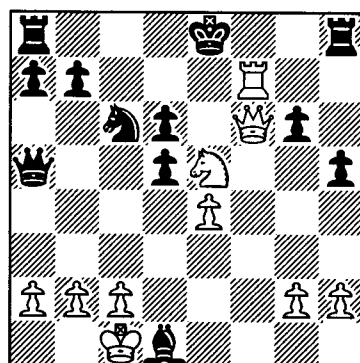


Diagram 22

Black will be mated

Black has spent an awful lot of time exchanging off an unmoved piece and she is now lagging dangerously behind in development

11...Be6 12 0-0-0 Qa5 13 d5!?

I was very pleased with the combination that followed but White has in fact a much simpler continuation here, namely 13 Bxe7!. The point is that if Black plays 13...Kxe7 then he loses his queen after 14 Nd5+. This simple tactic didn't occur to me at all – my mind was lost in more complicated tasks.

13...Bg4 14 Qf4 h5 15 Ne5! Bh6 16 Bg5 Bxg5 17 Qxg5 Bxd1 18 d6!

I found this more convincing than 18 Rxf7 Qc5 19 Qxg6 Kd8.

18...exd6 19 Nd5!

Now the queen's path to e5 is blocked.

19...cxd5 20 Rxf7 Nc6 21 Qf6! 1-0 (Diagram 22)

I particularly enjoyed the fact that the bishop at d1 is being used as a shield to prevent ...Qe1 mate. The double threat of Qxh8 and Qe6 forces mate.

Summary

1) You will have noticed my obvious bias concerning this variation, *but what about the statistics? White has an amazing overall score of 61% in the Fantasy Variation! That is not because it is so strong but*

Starting Out: The Caro-Kann

because so many black players don't know anything about it.

2) The four black lines considered above all lead to roughly balanced middlegames, but my advice to *Black* would be to keep the position closed. The players who play this line with *White* are usually more happy in open positions.

3) Why not give it a go as *White*!

Chapter Ten

Miscellaneous Systems

- ▨ The Exchange Variation
- ▨ White Plays c2-c4
- ▨ The Two Knights Variation
- ▨ White Plays 2 d3
- ▨ 1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2/Nc3 w/o 3...dxe4
- ▨ Summary



This chapter covers the rest of the lines in the Caro Kann. They are not exactly sidelines, just variations that didn't quite merit a chapter of their own within the space restrictions I have had to work.

Exchange Variation

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 Bd3 (Diagram 1)

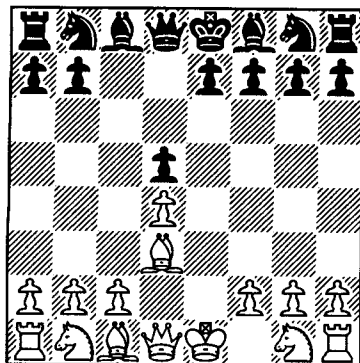


Diagram 1
The Exchange Variation

Nowadays the Exchange Variation is thought of as one of the most harmless lines in the Caro-Kann and is rarely seen in master chess. This was not always the case. I have an old book on the Caro-Kann where the late Edmar Mednis awards 4 Bd3 an '!' and claims that White is doing very well. The popularity of the line can be traced back to the 1970 USSR-Rest of the World match, where Bobby Fischer used the Exchange Variation to defeat 'iron' Tigran Petrosian. This was the period of Fischer-mania, when anything the great Bobby did was copied by the masses. I, too, was a fan and played the Exchange Variation in my chess youth. I think I was mainly attracted by White's direct and simple strategy and the number of exclamation marks that Mednis gave White's moves. It served me reasonably well until I started to meet strong players and then I had to find a new system.

Plans

White develops in the following manner: bishops to d3 and f4, knights to d2 and f3, he castles kingside and the queen goes to b3 if attacked by the black bishop (he plays c2-c3 early on). The main plan is then to play Ne5 and attack on the kingside.

The black knights go to f6 and c6 and he castles kingside. His main choice will be between fianchettoing the dark squared bishop, and playing ...e7-e6 (after ...Bg4) followed by ...Be7 or ...Bd6. Both are vi-

able plans but the line with ...e6 is more popular. In this line, once Black has completed his development, he will seek to launch a minority attack on the queenside.



NOTE: The term 'minority attack' is most frequently used to describe an attack where the player with fewer pawns on the queenside advances them to try and create weaknesses in the enemy camp. In this case it means Black playing ...b7-b5-b4.

4...Nc6 5 c3

This is more accurate than 5 Nf3, to which Black can reply 5...Bg4.

5...Nf6 6 Bf4 (Diagram 2)

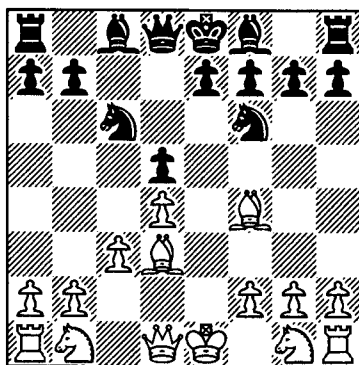


Diagram 2

Bishops before knights

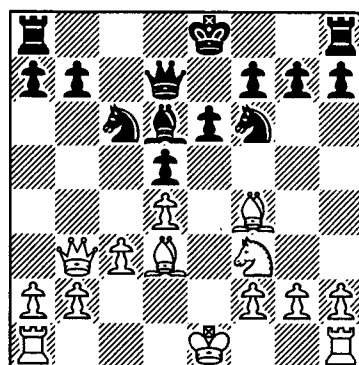


Diagram 3

Black offers a pawn

Beginners are often taught that knights should be developed before bishops. While there is some truth in this as bishops are more flexible than knights, this rule should be taken with a pinch of salt. Here, White again delays Nf3 because of the reply 6...Bg4.

6...Bg4

6...g6 is a major alternative, when a typical continuation is 7 Nf3 Bg7 8 0-0 0-0 9 Re1 Bf5!. When this was played against me for the first time I just assumed that my opponent had taken leave of his senses. After all, who in their right mind would voluntarily loosen their king's position? It was only when he had total control of the centre and a powerful attack along the g-file that I began to appreciate his strategy. After 10 Bxf5 gxf5 Black's pawn phalanx gives him a very powerful position in the centre. One possible continuation is 11 Ne5 Nxe5 12 Bxe5 Kh8!? with the idea of playing ...Rg8 and then ...Ne4 (if possible) to develop a kingside attack. 12...e6 is another sensible move. Before moving on, a couple more points. Black can equally play ...Bf5 on move 7 or 8 and secondly, if playing White, I would be seriously tempted not to take on f5 and just allow Black to exchange on d3.

7 Qb3 Qd7

7...Na5?! 8 Qa4+ Bd7 9 Qc2 was the continuation in the famous Fischer-Petrosian game. Black's attempt to harass the white queen has just left his pieces on inferior squares.

In the old days 7...Qd7 was thought to be a mistake as it was not appreciated that Black could sacrifice his b-pawn (see later). 7...Qc8 was thought superior as the queen is out of range of a knight landing on e5. In fact, 7...Qc8 is still considered a perfectly good move. For example, 8 Nd2 e6 9 Ngf3 Be7 10 0-0 Bh5! gives Black equal chances as he will be able to blunt White's kingside play by playing ...Bg6.

8 Nd2 e6 9 Ngf3 Bxf3

It's best to get rid of the bishop before White plays Ne5. Black has a more straightforward plan than ...Bh5-g6 in mind.

10 Nxf3 Bd6! (Diagram 3) 11 Bxd6

Neither 11 Bg3 0-0 12 0-0 Bxg3 13 hxg3 nor 11 Be5 Qc7 12 Bxf6 gxf6 offer White the slightest glimmer of an advantage.

11...Qxd6 12 0-0

It is actually a real pawn sacrifice as after 12 Qxb7 Rb8 13 Qa6 it is impossible for Black to play 13...Rxb2 on account of 14 Bb5!. Instead he plays 13...0-0 when it is very risky for White to try and hang onto the pawn, e.g. 14 Rb1 Rb6 15 Qa4 e5! and 14 Bb5 Rb6 15 Qa4 Ne7 16 b3 Ne4 both give Black a strong initiative. I suppose 14 Qa3 hangs on to the pawn as well but that doesn't really count as White's queenside is such a mess after 14...Qxa3 15 bxa3. In fact, White can play 14 0-0 as 14...Rxb2 still fails to 15 Bb5. Black would play 14...Rb6, meeting 15 Qa4 with 15...Rxb2 and 15 Qa3 with 15...Qxa3 16 bxa3 Rfb8. This ending is probably about level.

12...0-0 13 Rae1

Now White is ready to play Ne5 and start operations on the kingside. Black has two good defensive moves which maintain equality, 13...Qc7 and 13...Nd7, but most players prefer the double-edged 13...Rab8 to set the minority attack in motion at once. A possible continuation is 14 Ne5 b5 15 a3 a5 16 f4 (16 Bxb5 can be met by the surprising 16...Ne4!) 16...b4 (16...g6!?) 17 axb4 axb4 18 Qd1 bxc3 19 bxc3 g6 20 Re3 Nd7 with chances for both sides. White has a weak pawn on c3 but some attacking chances. I suspect most Grandmasters would prefer Black.

Theoretical?

Not really, but there are clear plans available to both sides.

Statistics

White has scored 52% from over 5000 games in the Exchange Variation. Against our main line (say, the position after 10...Bd6) White's score is down to 49%. The figures are not very impressive (remember 54% is the average White score).

White Plays 2 c4

1 e4 c6 2 c4

This rather strange, ugly looking move (ugly, in my opinion, because it creates a hole on d4) occurs regularly in practice but we don't hear so much about it as it is often swallowed up by its big brother, the Panov-Botvinnik Attack. In this section we shall examine some independent lines. Incidentally, the position is often reached via the English Opening, when after 1 c4 c6 White turns down the invitation to a Slav (2 d4 d5) in favour of testing his opponent's knowledge of the Caro-Kann with 2 e4.

2...d5

This is the move that occurs most often as it suits the style of Caro Kann players. 2...e5, however, is a perfectly reasonable alternative. After 3 Nf3 d6 4 d4 Nf6 5 Nc3 Nbd7 we have transposed into the Old Indian Defence, a solid but slightly passive variation that normally arises via 1 d4. With the Caro-Kann move order Black can try the more enterprising 4...Bg4. The idea is to meet 5 dxe5 with 5...Bxf3 6 Qxf3 dxe5, when the hole on d4 is no longer just ugly but also a potentially fine outpost for a black knight. Of course White should play 6 gxf3 dxe5 7 Qxd8 Kxd8 8 f4 in order to try and open the position for his bishops, but this position is far from clear after 8...Bb4+.

White doesn't have to take on e5. He can block the centre with 5 d5 or he can develop with 5 Be2, although against the latter 5...Be7 6 0-0 Bxf3 7 Bxf3 Bg5! looks like a good plan.



NOTE: Exchanges normally favour the side with less space and here, with his central pawns on d6 and e5, Black is especially happy to exchange off the dark-squared bishops.

3 exd5 cxd5 4 cxd5

4 d4 is, of course, a direct transposition to the Panov-Botvinnik Attack.

4...Nf6

If Black wants to make certain of regaining his pawn he can play 4...Qxd5. A possible continuation then would be 5 Nc3 Qd8 6 d4 Nf6 7 Nf3 e6 8 Bd3 Be7 9 0-0 Nc6 10 Re1 0-0 and we have transposed to Game 50. The manoeuvre ...Nxd5 and back to f6 comes to the same thing as ...Qxd5 and back to d8.

5 Bb5+ (Diagram 4)

The idea of this check is to force a piece to d7 so that it won't be easy for Black to regain his pawn. There are a couple of alternatives that need to be looked at.

a) 5 Qa4+ has similar intentions to 5 Bb5+ but it is less reliable to develop the queen so early. After 5...Bd7 (5...Nbd7 is also fine) 6 Qb3 Na6 Black already has quite a lead in development. Now 7 Qxb7

would demonstrate a death wish (7...Nc5 8 Qb4 e6 threatens to win the queen with ...Nd3+) so White should choose between 7 Nc3 Nc5 8 Qd1 and 7 d4 Qb6!, but in neither case can he claim to have the advantage.

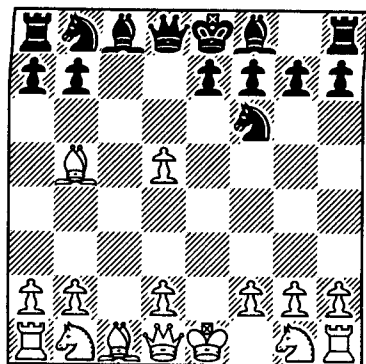


Diagram 4
An annoying check

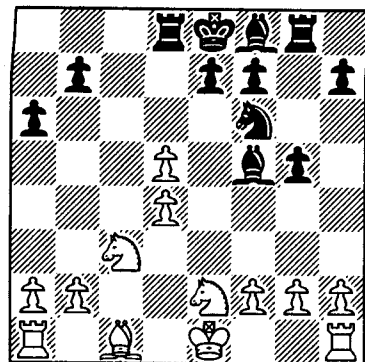


Diagram 5
Black regains the pawn

b) 5 Nc3 Nxd5 is quite likely to lead back into the Panov-Botvinnik. For example, 6 Nf3 Nc6 7 d4 Bg4 is Game 51. If White wants to avoid this line he can try 7 Bb5, while Black can vary with 6...Nxc3 7 bxc3 g6.

5...Nbd7

White's idea is that after 5...Bd7 6 Bc4! the bishop is misplaced on d7. Not only does it upset the queen for blocking her path to d5, but it also annoys the knight on b8 by taking away its favoured square. If Black now plays 6...Qc7 then White should prefer 7 d3 to 7 Bb3 to avoid the tactic 7...Nxd5 8 Bxd5 Qe5+. With a pawn on d3 this doesn't work because of the reply 9 Be4. In order to try and justify the position of his bishop on d7, Black usually flings his queenside pawns up the board, e.g. 6...b5 7 Bb3 a5, but White's prospects are slightly better after 8 a3.

6 Nc3 a6

This is better than the alternative plan of 6...g6 7 d4 Bg7 as this transposes to a line in the Panov where 8 d6! is promising for White (see Game 52).

7 Qa4

White uses the pin to keep Black bottled up for as long as possible. It would be extremely feeble to play something like 7 Bxd7+ Qxd7 8 Qb3 as Black just plays 8...b5 followed by ...Bb7.

7...Rb8

This forces the issue but Black could also have just developed his kingside. After 7...g6 8 Nf3 Bg7 9 0-0 0-0 White has to play 10 Bxd7

(before the knight goes to b6), when after 10...Bxd7 11 Qb3 d5 12 d4 a5 Black has quite reasonable compensation for the pawn.

8 Bxd7+

Retreating the bishop would be inconsistent and just met by 8...b5.

8...Qxd7

After 8...Bxd7 White can play the active 9 Qf4. He could also consider this now, instead of the queen exchange, as Black would be forced to return his rook to a8. However, he will subsequently pick up the d-pawn so shouldn't have too many problems.

9 Qxd7+ Bxd7 10 Nge2 Rd8 11 d4 Bf5 12 Nf4 g5 13 Nfe2 Rg8 (Diagram 5)

Now Black wins back the pawn on d5 with a roughly level game.

Theoretical?

Considering that one can hardly play this variation without a thorough knowledge of the Panov-Botvinnik, I suppose you have to call it theoretical. Black could try 2...e5 if he wants less familiar positions.

Statistics

This is a tricky one for your statistician because of all the transpositions. Here are a couple of interesting points. After 5 Bb5+, if Black interposes his bishop he only manages 33% but if he plays 5...Nbd7 then he scores 48%. With 5 Qa4+ White scores 53%, while with 2...e5 Black scores 41%. Overall with 2 c4, if we discount the games that transpose directly to the Panov, White has scored 56%.

Two Knights Variation

1 e4 c6 2 Nc3 d5 3 Nf3 (Diagram 6)

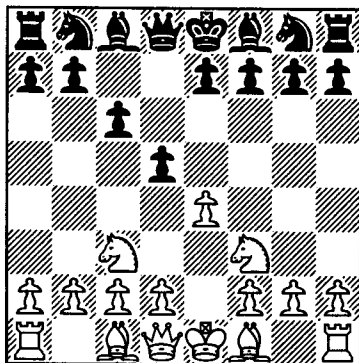


Diagram 6
The Two Knights Variation

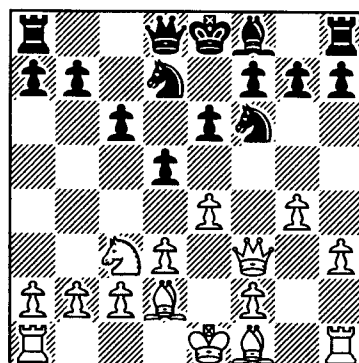


Diagram 7
White gains space

In the Two Knights Variation White has played Nf3 in place of the usual d2-d4. 3 Nf3 is not a bad move but it does offer Black a serious alternative to conceding the centre. With the pawn on d4 and the knight on g1 Black has little choice but to play 3...dxe4 (all right, there is 3...g6 which we discuss later), but after 3 Nf3 he has another interesting strategy that starts with 3...Bg4. The idea is to exchange bishop for knight and then hold the centre with the move ...e7-e6. In such a position it will not be easy for White to prove that the bishop pair is an advantage.



TIP: If you have just one bishop left then it is ideal to have your central pawns on the opposite colour to your bishop. This means that they complement each other and the pawns won't restrict the movement of the bishop. This is a perfect example as Black has a dark-squared bishop with all his pawns on light squares.

But what if Black doesn't want to play 3...Bg4? Can't he just play his normal line, i.e. 3...dxe4 4 Nxe4 followed by either 4...Nf6, 4...Nd7 or 4...Bf5? When White eventually plays d2-d4, which he surely must, then don't we just transpose into one of the earlier chapters of the book? Well, the answer is yes and no. After 4...Nf6 5 Nxf6 gxf6 (or 5...exf6) White has nothing better than to play 6 d4 transposing to Chapter 5. The same goes for 4...Nd7 but be careful if you are a ...Bf5 player. After 4...Bf5 5 Ng3 Bg6?! (5...Bg4) 6 h4 h6 7 Ne5 White can put the tempo saved on d4 to good use. Black should now settle for 7...Qd6 as after 7...Bh7 8 Qh5 g6 9 Bc4! (more convincing than 9 Qf3) 9...e6 10 Qe2 White has an excellent attacking position. The bishop on h7 is particularly ridiculous.

3...Bg4 4 h3 Bxf3

White attacked the bishop at once because at this precise moment it is very risky for Black to play 4...Bh5. This is because White has an aggressive, forcing continuation that exploits the bishop's absence from the queenside. The main line runs 5 exd5 cxd5 6 Bb5+ Nc6 7 g4 Bg6 8 Ne5 Rc8 9 d4 e6 10 Qe2 and now:

a) 10...Bd6 was thought to equalise until White showed in a couple of recent games that he has the advantage after 11 Nxc6 hxc6 12 Nxd5 Bb8 13 Nb4!.

b) 10...Bb4 is the old line that has been the subject of many heated theoretical battles over the years. After 11 h4! White usually ends up winning the bishop on g6 for a few pawns and the current view is that he gets slightly the better of an endgame. You will, I'm afraid, have to consult a more advanced book for the details (or a database).

5 Qxf3

Only a complete beginner would take with the pawn here, don't you think? That was certainly the view of the purist Soviet press when they savaged Mikhail Tal for playing 5 gxf3 in the 3rd game of his 1960 match with Botvinnik. They virtually accused him of bringing the game into disrepute. Tal defended his decision on psychological

grounds. The game ended in a draw but Tal won the match and became World Champion.

5...Nf6

Black can also play 5...e6 but most players prefer the text. That is because the pawn sacrifice 6 d4 dxe4 7 Nxe4 Qxd4 is not considered very promising, but the one after 5...e6 6 d4 dxe4 7 Nxe4 Qxd4 is thought to have more bite. Anyway, there is no harm in playing 5...Nf6 as 6 e5 Nfd7 7 d4 e6 is just a good French for Black, i.e. one where he has got rid of his problem piece, the light-squared bishop.

6 d3

White has several plans and, as they nearly all involve playing d2-d3, he usually plays it straight away. Nigel Short, who has started playing this system quite regularly, prefers 6 Be2 e6 7 0-0 so that if Black continues with the natural 7...Nbd7 White can play 8 d4. However, even here 8...dxe4 9 Nxe4 Nxe4 10 Qxe4 Nf6 11 Qe3 Bd6 is only a minimal edge for White. Anand drew very easily with Short from this position last year.

6...e6 7 Bd2

The most aggressive move. White plans to castle queenside and advance his kingside pawns.

7 g3 used to be played quite often but the position after 7...Nbd7 8 Bg2 Bb4 is relatively harmless for Black.

7 Qg3 Nbd7 8 Be2 is a more dangerous set-up and requires accurate play from Black. The sequence 8...g6 9 0-0 Bg7 is probably best (otherwise it is not easy for him to develop his kingside) but after 10 Bf4 Black should avoid 10...0-0? 11 Bd6 Re8 12 e5, when his knight has no retreat square, and flick in 10...Qb6 11 Rab1 before castling. Still, this position looks slightly more comfortable for White and this may be his best way to treat this variation.

7...Nbd7

7...Bb4!? can also be played with the idea of playing ...d5-d4 and exchanging bishops. Black is not worried about 8 e5 Nfd7 9 Qg4 Bf8! as, although he has lost two tempi, he has made White block the centre.

8 g4 (Diagram 7) 8...g6

So that after 9 g5 Black can play 9...Nh5. 8...h6 would just encourage White to play 9 h4 but 8...Bc5 is interesting, when after 9 g5 Black calmly retreats to g8 and then re-emerges again on e7.

NOTE: When the centre is open, time is of the essence and the play is usually quite direct. When the centre is blocked time is not so important and one can usually manoeuvre one's pieces towards their best squares at a leisurely pace.

9 Qg3 d4

Black has got into trouble with other ideas so it looks best to block the centre. For example, after 9...dxe4 10 dxe4 e5 11 0-0-0 Qc7 12 f4



White has a dangerous initiative.

10 Ne2 Qb6 11 0-0-0 0-0-0

White has more space on the kingside and Black on the queenside. The chances are about level in this unclear position.

Theoretical?

It is not very theoretical and in master chess it is often played as a surprise weapon to avoid the more theoretical lines. But, as usual, the more you know beforehand the better your results.

Statistics

After 5 Qxf3 White has scored 53% from around 1400 games. If Black plays 4...Bh5 then Black's score is down to 43%. After 3...dxe4 Black scores 42% but many of these games just transpose to the main lines. If he plays the 4...Bf5?! I warned you about his score plummets to 32% from 250 games.

White Plays 2 d3

1 e4 c6 2 d3

2 d3 has never been as popular against the Caro-Kann as it has against the French Defence (1 e4 e6 2 d3). The reason is that in the Caro Black can play ...e7-e5 in one go and consequently he can occupy and hold the centre. It would be fair to say that 2 d3 is only really played by the slavish devotees of the King's Indian Attack (or as a surprise).

2...d5 3 Nd2 e5

This is the most straightforward. The main alternative is to play 3...g6 4 Ngf3 Bg7 5 g3 and only then 5...e5 but White seems to have more chances of obtaining active play there.

4 Ngf3 Bd6

The move order is quite important as after 4...Nd7?! White can open the centre favourably with 5 d4. As we shall see, this is not so promising after 4...Bd6 because Black's development is easier.

5 g3 (Diagram 8)

After this move we transpose into a King's Indian Attack, i.e. a King's Indian Defence in reverse. Although White has an extra tempo, the fact that he has played Nd2 means that he has a rather passive form of the King's Indian. White has a few other ideas:

a) 5 Be2 leads to a sort of reversed Philidor. It is surprising that such a set-up can have supporters. After 5...Nf6 6 0-0 0-0 7 c3 Re8 Black has an easy game.

b) 5 d4 is more spirited but after 5...exd4 6 exd5 (6 Nxd4 Nf6) 6...cxd5 7 Nxd4 Nc6 8 N2f3 Nf6 Black has a comfortable IQP position.

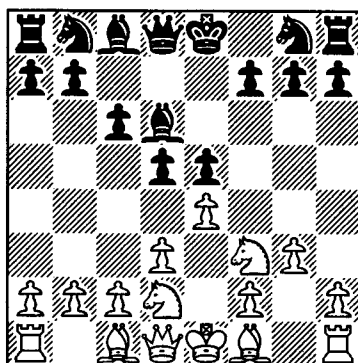


Diagram 8
A King's Indian Attack

c) 5 Qe2 (threatening 5 exd5) 5...Qe7 6 d4 is an attempt to improve upon the immediate 5 d4 as now the queens are likely to be exchanged which favours the side battling against the IQP. After, for example, 6...exd4 7 exd5 cxd5 8 Nxd4 Nc6 9 N2b3 White has chances of obtaining a small plus. A reasonable alternative for Black is to block the centre with 5...d4 as the white queen is not particularly well placed on e2.

5...Nf6

Black just keeps playing natural moves.

6 Bg2 0-0 7 0-0 Re8 8 Re1

White has a wide choice (8 b3, 8 c3, 8 h3, to name a few) but he usually ends up playing Re1 at some point.

8...Nbd7 9 b3

9 c3 is well met by 9...a5 in order to stop White expanding on the queenside. The central break 10 d4 just leads to a drawn position after 10...exd4 11 Nxd4 dxe4 12 Nxe4 Nxe4 13 Rxe4 Rxe4 14 Bxe4 Nf6.

9...Nf8

A good move. The knight heads for g6 from where it defends e5 without getting in the way of the other pieces. True, it doesn't have many active possibilities on g6 but the board is too crowded for every piece to be active.

10 Bb2 Ng6

The position can be considered about level. A couple of recent examples:

a) 11 a4 Bg4 12 h3 Bd7 13 Kh2 h6 14 a5 Rc8 15 d4 dxe4 16 Nxe5 Nxe5 17 dxe5 Bxe5 18 Bxe5 Rxe5 19 Nxe4 Nxe4 20 Rxe4 Rxe4 21 Bxe4 Qe7, Azmaiparashvili-Karpov, Dubai (rapid) 2002. Karpov went on to win this equal endgame.

b) 11 d4 Nxe4 12 Nxe4 dxe4 13 Nxe5 f5 led to a sharper struggle in Nevednichy-Svetushkin, Kishnev 2001, but Black won that as well.

Theoretical?

No, there are very few sharp lines to remember. As Grandmaster King said: 'It's the kind of variation you like to play in the Sunday morning Bundesliga game; it gives you a little time to wake up before anything too dramatic happens.'

Statistics

With 2 d3 White has scored 54% from around 2,500 games. The average White score, but if Black follows the theoretical recommendation then there's a dramatic reversal and it's Black who scores 54% (from 350 games after 5...Nf6).

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nd2/c3 Without 3...dxe4

After the moves 1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 you will notice that White plays both 3 Nd2 and 3 Nc3 but almost always ends up in the same position after 3...dxe4 4 Nxe4. Does it matter which one White plays? Well, it can do if Black refrains from capturing on e4. Let's take a look at each one in turn.

A) 3 Nc3

Against 3 Nc3 Black has one quite major alternative to capturing on e4 and that is 3...g6. In fact, many players use the 3 Nd2 move order to avoid this line. The move 3...g6 has the reputation of being less effective against 3 Nd2 but that doesn't mean it's anything for White to worry about against 3 Nc3, either. If we add in the usual moves 4 Nf3 (4 e5 is also possible and after 4...Bg7 that is also a variation of the Modern) 4...Bg7 then we have reached a position that is more often reached via the Modern Defence. The usual move order there is 1 e4 g6 2 d4 Bg7 3 Nc3 c6 4 Nf3 d5. For some reason the powers that be decided to classify it as a Caro-Kann, so I'd better have a quick look at it even if I consider it beyond the call of duty. (I bet you're thinking that if I was writing a book on the Modern then I would claim that this line is really a Caro-Kann!)

Anyway, after the moves 1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 Nc3 g6 4 Nf3 Bg7 White usually plays the semi waiting move...

5 h3 (Diagram 9)

White doesn't know where to put his bishops yet so he plays a useful move that rules out ...Bg4. After Black's next move White should have more idea about how to develop.

5...Nf6

A provocative move. There are a couple of alternatives:

a) 5...dxe4 is very solid. After 6 Nxe4 Nd7 7 Bc4 Ngf6 8 Nxf6+ Nxf6 9 0-0 0-0 10 Re1 White has a small plus.

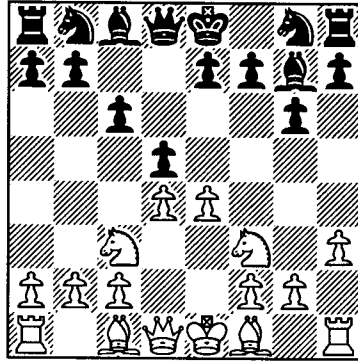


Diagram 9
White prevents ...Bg4

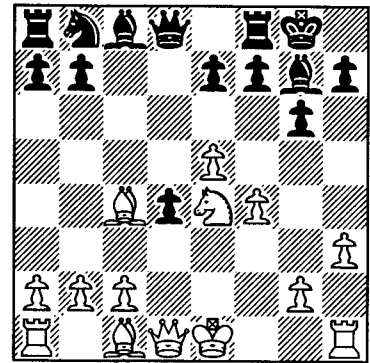


Diagram 10
White has a pleasant game

b) 5...Nh6 is a slightly more eccentric continuation. After 6 Bd3 0-0 7 0-0 Black must decide how he wants to bring his knight on h6 into the game. There are two choices. He can either play 7...dxe4 8 Nxe4 Nf5, when White's position is again a bit better after 9 c3, or he can try the more dynamic 7...f6 followed by ...Nf7. Against this latter plan White probably does best to play 8 Ne2 in order to follow up with c2-c4 as soon as possible.

6 e5

White accepts the challenge. Instead, 6 Bd3 dxe4 7 Nxe4 Nxe4 8 Bxe4 0-0 9 0-0 Nd7 10 Bg5 is an edge in a much calmer position.

6...Ne4 7 Nxe4

Many games have gone 7 Bd3 Nxc3 8 bxc3 c5 but Black has not done too badly here.

7...dxe4 8 Ng5 c5

Black must strike quickly in the centre.

9 Bc4

9 d5!? Bxe5 10 Nxe4 is also not bad.

9...0-0 10 Nxe4 cxd4 11 f4 (Diagram 10)

White has the better chances in a complicated struggle.

B) 3 Nd2

It is even rarer for Black to refrain from 3...dxe4 against 3 Nd2. The move 3...g6 is still played from time to time but the generally held view is that it is not so attractive to fianchetto the king's bishop when White can still block the long diagonal with c2-c3. In practice it is of-

ten similar to what we have seen above. For example, 4 Ngf3 Bg7 5 c3 Nh6 (or 5...dxe4 6 Nxe4 Nd7 7 Bc4 with an edge for White) 6 Bd3 0-0 7 0-0 f6 8 Re1 Nf7 9 c4 e6 10 b3 with some advantage to White.

There is not much else that Black plays apart from 3...dxe4 and 3...g6. There is the occasional game with 3 Nd2 Qb6, when 4 c3 dxe4 5 Nxe4 Bf5 6 Bd3 is a typical continuation, and a few games with 3 Nc3 b5 when 4 a3 is White's most popular reply. Then after 4...dxe4 5 Nxe4 we have a slightly weird version of whichever variation Black chooses to play.

Theoretical?

No, we are off the beaten track as far as the Caro-Kann is concerned, even if the line with 3 Nc3 g6 leads to a fairly mainstream variation of the Modern Defence.

Statistics

After 3 Nd2 g6 White scores 57%, whilst in the line with 3 Nc3 g6 White has scored 55%. Black does as well here as in the main lines.

Summary

- 1) The days of the Exchange Variation strutting around the world stage are long gone.
- 2) 2 c4 is a decent line that often transposes into the Panov-Botvinnik Attack.
- 3) The position is too closed in The Two Knights variation for White to profit from his bishop pair.
- 4) 2 d3 is a good variation for those who don't like to play White.
- 5) Those of you who want to play with ...g7-g6 should buy a book on the Modern.

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starting out: the caro-kann

The Caro-Kann Defence has a well-deserved and established reputation as an incredibly solid and, at the same time, dynamic defence to 1 e4. The Caro-Kann appeals to all types of players, but is especially popular with black players who prefer a sound platform on which to build, and who are resourceful in both defence and counter-attack. Star players who enjoy using the Caro-Kann include Vishy Anand, Michael Adams and the legendary Anatoly Karpov. In this easy-to-read guide, Grandmaster Joe Gallagher goes back to the basics of the Caro-Kann, studying the key principles of its many variations. Throughout the book there are numerous notes, tips, warnings and exercises to help the improving player, whilst important strategies, ideas and tactics for both sides are clearly illustrated.

- User-friendly design to help readers absorb ideas
- Concentrates on the key principles of the Caro-Kann
- Ideal for the improving player

2001 British Champion **Joe Gallagher** is an English Grandmaster who has been living in Switzerland for a number of years and is a regular member of the Swiss national team. His many books have deservedly earned him a reputation as a top-class writer. His previous works include *The Magic of Mikhail Tal* and *Starting Out: The King's Indian*.

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